

**EUROPEAN RESEARCH EXECUTIVE AGENCY (REA)**

REA.C – Future Society
C.1 – Inclusive Society

GRANT AGREEMENT**Project 101286806 — CitiSense****PREAMBLE**

This **Agreement** ('the Agreement') is **between** the following parties:

on the one part,

the **European Research Executive Agency (REA)** ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'),
under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and

on the other part,

1. 'the coordinator':

EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI), PIC 999902385, established in VIA DEI
ROCCETTINI 9, FIESOLE 50014, Italy,

and the following other beneficiaries, if they sign their 'accession form' (see Annex 3 and Article 40):

2. **UNIVERSITEIT MAASTRICHT (UM)**, PIC 999975911, established in
MINDERBROEDERSBERG 4, MAASTRICHT 6200 MD, Netherlands,

3. **SIHTASUTUS RAHVUSVAHELINE KAITSEUURINGUTE KESKUS (ICDS)**, PIC
998833251, established in Narva mnt 63/4 East Building, TALLINN 10152, Estonia,

4. **ISTITUTO AFFARI INTERNAZIONALI (I.A.I.)**, PIC 999694708, established in VIA DEI
MONTECATINI 17, ROMA 00186, Italy,

5. **CEU GMBH (CEU)**, PIC 901064817, established in QUELLENSTRASSE 51, WIEN 1100,
Austria,

6. **UNIVERSITAET DUISBURG-ESSEN (UDE)**, PIC 999843312, established in
UNIVERSITATSSTRASSE 2, ESSEN 45141, Germany,

7. **INSTITUT FUR EUROPAISCHE POLITIK EV (IEP)**, PIC 951217309, established in
BUNDESALLEE 23, BERLIN 10717, Germany,

8. **EUROPEAN PARTNERSHIP FOR DEMOCRACY (EPD)**, PIC 907381457, established in
RUE FROISSART 123-133, BRUXELLES 1040, Belgium,

9. **STOCKHOLMS UNIVERSITET (SU)**, PIC 999885022, established in UNIVERSITETSVAGEN 10, STOCKHOLM 10691, Sweden,
10. **TRANS EUROPEAN POLICY STUDIES ASSOCIATION (TEPSA)**, PIC 997222081, established in RUE D EGMONT 11, BRUXELLES 1000, Belgium,
11. **UNIVERZITA KOMENSKÉHO V BRATISLAVE (CUB)**, PIC 999841566, established in SAFARIKOVO NAM 6, BRATISLAVA 1 814 99, Slovakia,
12. **UNIWERSYTET SWPS (USWPS)**, PIC 999884634, established in UL. CHODAKOWSKA 19/31, WARSZAWA 03-815, Poland,
13. **ILIA STATE UNIVERSITY (ISU)**, PIC 999612937, established in K CHOLOKASHVILI AV 3-5, TBILISI 0162, Georgia,
14. **NATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF KYIV-MOHYLA ACADEMY (KMU)**, PIC 955856431, established in 2 HRYHORIYA SKOVORODY STR, KYIV 04070, Ukraine,
15. **ASOCIATIA OBSTEASCA INSTITUTUL PENTRU POLITICI SI REFORME EUROPENE (IPRE)**, PIC 894698610, established in STR. BUCURESTI 90 OF 20, CHISINAU 2001, Moldova,
16. **INSTITUT ZA DEMOKRATIJA SOCIETAS CIVILIS SKOPJE (IDSCS)**, PIC 942478773, established in MIROSLAV KRLEZA 52 1-2, SKOPJE 1000, Republic of North Macedonia,

Unless otherwise specified, references to ‘beneficiary’ or ‘beneficiaries’ include the coordinator and affiliated entities (if any).

If only one beneficiary signs the grant agreement (‘mono-beneficiary grant’), all provisions referring to the ‘coordinator’ or the ‘beneficiaries’ will be considered — *mutatis mutandis* — as referring to the beneficiary.

The parties referred to above have agreed to enter into the Agreement.

By signing the Agreement and the accession forms, the beneficiaries accept the grant and agree to implement the action under their own responsibility and in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

The Agreement is composed of:

Preamble

Terms and Conditions (including Data Sheet)

Annex 1	Description of the action ¹
Annex 2	Estimated budget for the action
Annex 3	Accession forms (if applicable) ²
Annex 3a	Declaration on joint and several liability of affiliated entities (if applicable) ³
Annex 4	Model for the financial statements
Annex 5	Specific rules (if applicable)

¹ Template published on [Portal Reference Documents](#).

² Template published on [Portal Reference Documents](#).

³ Template published on [Portal Reference Documents](#).

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DATA SHEET

1. General data

Project summary:

Project summary
How can the EU pursue a more effective and resilient enlargement policy by fostering understanding of its security, economic, and societal impacts among citizens? CitiSense – Making Sense of EU Enlargement for, with and by Citizens – addresses this challenge through an innovative threefold approach: "for citizens" by producing clear evidence on the costs and benefits of enlargement and non-enlargement; "with citizens" by systematically analysing public attitudes, perceptions, and concerns; and "by citizens" by creating direct opportunities to participate in debates and co-design solutions. CitiSense's novelty lies in treating citizens not as passive recipients of knowledge but as co-creators of evidence, dialogue, and policy recommendations. CitiSense brings together 16 consortium partners – universities, think tanks, and CSOs – to investigate the security, economic, and societal dimensions of enlargement in both member states and candidate countries. It builds on previous Horizon projects adapting and scaling up proven formats like Youth Labs, Civil Society Networks, and Expert Hubs. It advances earlier research by contributing new methods and original data. The project employs a multimethod research design. CitiSense will generate a wide range of outputs: multidimensional toolboxes for policymakers, administrators, educators, and civil society, integrating public opinion data, cost-benefit analyses, and foresight scenarios with manuals for participatory mechanisms such as Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies, and Youth Labs. It will also deliver a digital guidebook of "30 FAQs on Enlargement", a Europe-wide collection of student-authored country reports, educational resources for schools, and multimedia formats (podcasts, Instagram reels, and interactive art exhibition). Together, these outputs provide accessible, user-friendly, and transferable resources that promote transparent communication and inclusive policymaking, and inform public debate on EU enlargement.

Keywords:

- Political science
- citizen-centered; EU enlargement; public opinion; evidence-based policy; participatory research

Project number: 101286806

Project name: Making Sense of EU Enlargement for, with and by Citizens

Project acronym: CitiSense

Call: HORIZON-CL2-2025-01

Topic: HORIZON-CL2-2025-01-DEMOCRACY-03

Type of action: HORIZON Research and Innovation Actions

Granting authority: European Research Executive Agency

Grant managed through EU Funding & Tenders Portal: Yes (eGrants)

Project starting date: fixed date: 1 October 2026

Project end date: 30 September 2029

Project duration: 36 months

Consortium agreement: Yes

2. Participants

List of participants:

N°	Role	Short name	Legal name	Ctry	PIC	Max grant amount
1	COO (IO)	EUI	EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE	IT	999902385	562 414.88
2	BEN	UM	UNIVERSITEIT MAASTRICHT	NL	999975911	528 063.79
3	BEN	ICDS	SIHTASUTUS RAHVUSVAHELINE KAITSEUURINGUTE KESKUS	EE	998833251	150 736.26

N°	Role	Short name	Legal name	Ctry	PIC	Max grant amount
4	BEN	I.A.I.	ISTITUTO AFFARI INTERNAZIONALI	IT	999694708	131 658.75
5	BEN	CEU	CEU GMBH	AT	901064817	100 225.00
6	BEN	UDE	UNIVERSITAET DUISBURG-ESSEN	DE	999843312	241 600.00
7	BEN	IEP	INSTITUT FUR EUROPAISCHE POLITIK EV	DE	951217309	184 600.00
8	BEN	EPD	EUROPEAN PARTNERSHIP FOR DEMOCRACY	BE	907381457	307 875.00
9	BEN	SU	STOCKHOLMS UNIVERSITET	SE	999885022	372 100.00
10	BEN	TEPSA	TRANS EUROPEAN POLICY STUDIES ASSOCIATION	BE	997222081	405 526.67
11	BEN	CUB	UNIVERZITA KOMENSKEHO V BRATISLAVE	SK	999841566	107 621.25
12	BEN	USWPS	UNIWERSYTET SWPS	PL	999884634	113 850.00
13	BEN	ISU	ILIA STATE UNIVERSITY	GE	999612937	86 475.00
14	BEN	KMU	NATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF KYIV-MOHYLA ACADEMY	UA	955856431	67 100.00
15	BEN	IPRE	ASOCIATIA OBSTEASCA INSTITUTUL PENTRU POLITICI SI REFORME EUROPENE	MD	894698610	60 850.00
16	BEN	IDSCS	INSTITUT ZA DEMOKRATIJA SOCIETAS CIVILIS SKOPJE	MK	942478773	64 100.00
Total						3 484 796.60

Coordinator:

- EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI)

3. Grant**Maximum grant amount, total estimated eligible costs and contributions and funding rate:**

Maximum grant amount (Annex 2)	Maximum grant amount (award decision)
3 484 796.60	3 484 796.60

Grant form: Lump Sum**Grant mode:** Action grant**Budget categories/activity types:** Lump sum contributions**Cost eligibility options:** n/a**Budget flexibility:** No**4. Reporting, payments and recoveries****4.1 Continuous reporting** (art 21)**Deliverables:** see Funding & Tenders Portal Continuous Reporting tool**4.2 Periodic reporting and payments**

Reporting and payment schedule (art 21, 22):

Reporting					Payments	
Reporting periods			Type	Deadline	Type	Deadline (time to pay)
RP No	Month from	Month to				
					Initial prefinancing	30 days from entry into force/10 days before starting date – whichever is the latest
					Interim payment	90 days from receiving periodic report
					Final payment	90 days from receiving periodic report

Prefinancing payments and guarantees:

Prefinancing payment	
Type	Amount
Prefinancing 1 (initial)	2 787 837.28

Reporting and payment modalities (art 21, 22):

Mutual Insurance Mechanism (MIM): Yes

MIM contribution: 5% of the maximum grant amount (174 239.83), retained from the initial prefinancing

Restrictions on distribution of initial prefinancing: The prefinancing may be distributed only if the minimum number of beneficiaries set out in the call conditions (if any) have acceded to the Agreement and only to beneficiaries that have acceded.

Interim payment ceiling (if any): 90% of the maximum grant amount

No-profit rule: n/a

Late payment interest: ECB + 3.5%

Bank account for payments:

IT69M0306902887100000002912 BCITITMMXXX

Conversion into euros: n/a

Reporting language: Language of the Agreement

4.3 Certificates (art 24): n/a**4.4 Recoveries (art 22)****First-line liability for recoveries:**

Beneficiary termination: Beneficiary concerned

Final payment: Each beneficiary for their own debt

After final payment: Beneficiary concerned

Joint and several liability for enforced recoveries (in case of non-payment):

Individual financial responsibility: Each beneficiary is liable only for its own debts (and those of its affiliated entities, if any)

Joint and several liability of affiliated entities — n/a

5. Consequences of non-compliance, applicable law & dispute settlement forum

Suspension and termination:

Additional suspension grounds (art 31)

Additional termination grounds (art 32)

Applicable law (art 43):

Standard applicable law regime: EU law + law of Belgium

Special applicable law regime:

- EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI): EU law + law of Italy + general principles governing the law of international organisations and the general rules of international law

Dispute settlement forum (art 43):

Standard dispute settlement forum:

EU beneficiaries: EU General Court + EU Court of Justice (on appeal)

Non-EU beneficiaries: Courts of Brussels, Belgium (unless an international agreement provides for the enforceability of EU court judgements)

Special dispute settlement forum:

- EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI): Arbitration

6. Other

Specific rules (Annex 5): Yes

Standard time-limits after project end:

Confidentiality (for X years after final payment): 5

Record-keeping (for X years after final payment): 5 (or 3 for grants of not more than EUR 60 000)

Reviews (up to X years after final payment): 2

Audits (up to X years after final payment): 2

Extension of findings from other grants to this grant (no later than X years after final payment): 2

Impact evaluation (up to X years after final payment): 5 (or 3 for grants of not more than EUR 60 000)

CHAPTER 1 GENERAL

ARTICLE 1 — SUBJECT OF THE AGREEMENT

This Agreement sets out the rights and obligations and terms and conditions applicable to the grant awarded for the implementation of the action set out in Chapter 2.

ARTICLE 2 — DEFINITIONS

For the purpose of this Agreement, the following definitions apply:

Actions — The project which is being funded in the context of this Agreement.

Grant — The grant awarded in the context of this Agreement.

EU grants — Grants awarded by EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies (including EU executive agencies, EU regulatory agencies, EDA, joint undertakings, etc.).

Participants — Entities participating in the action as beneficiaries, affiliated entities, associated partners, third parties giving in-kind contributions, subcontractors or recipients of financial support to third parties.

Beneficiaries (BEN) — The signatories of this Agreement (either directly or through an accession form).

Affiliated entities (AE) — Entities affiliated to a beneficiary within the meaning of Article 190 of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509⁴ which participate in the action with similar rights and obligations as the beneficiaries (obligation to implement action tasks and right to charge costs and claim contributions).

Associated partners (AP) — Entities which participate in the action, but without the right to charge costs or claim contributions.

Purchases — Contracts for goods, works or services needed to carry out the action (e.g. equipment, consumables and supplies) but which are not part of the action tasks (see Annex 1).

Subcontracting — Contracts for goods, works or services that are part of the action tasks (see Annex 1).

In-kind contributions — In-kind contributions within the meaning of Article 2(38) of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509, i.e. non-financial resources made available free of charge by third parties.

⁴ For the definition, see Article 190 Regulation (EU, Euratom) 2024/2509 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 23 September 2024 on the financial rules applicable to the general budget of the Union (recast) ('EU Financial Regulation') (OJ L, 2024/2509, 26.9.2024): "**affiliated entities** [are]:

- (a) entities that form a sole beneficiary [(i.e. where an entity is formed of several entities that satisfy the criteria for being awarded a grant, including where the entity is specifically established for the purpose of implementing an action to be financed by a grant)];
- (b) entities that satisfy the eligibility criteria and that do not fall within one of the situations referred to in Article 138(1) and 143(1) and that have a link with the beneficiary, in particular a legal or capital link, which is neither limited to the action nor established for the sole purpose of its implementation".

Fraud — Fraud within the meaning of Article 3 of EU Directive 2017/1371⁵ and Article 1 of the Convention on the protection of the European Communities' financial interests, drawn up by the Council Act of 26 July 1995⁶, as well as any other wrongful or criminal deception intended to result in financial or personal gain.

Irregularities — Any type of breach (regulatory or contractual) which could impact the EU financial interests, including irregularities within the meaning of Article 1(2) of EU Regulation 2988/95⁷.

Grave professional misconduct — Any type of unacceptable or improper behaviour in exercising one's profession, especially by employees, including grave professional misconduct within the meaning of Article 138(1)(c) of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509⁸.

Applicable EU, international and national law — Any legal acts or other (binding or non-binding) rules and guidance in the area concerned.

Portal — EU Funding & Tenders Portal; electronic portal and exchange system managed by the European Commission and used by itself and other EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies for the management of their funding programmes (grants, procurements, prizes, etc.).

CHAPTER 2 ACTION

ARTICLE 3 — ACTION

The grant is awarded for the action **101286806 — CitiSense** ('action'), as described in Annex 1.

ARTICLE 4 — DURATION AND STARTING DATE

The duration and the starting date of the action are set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 1).

CHAPTER 3 GRANT

ARTICLE 5 — GRANT

5.1 Form of grant

⁵ Directive (EU) 2017/1371 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 5 July 2017 on the fight against fraud to the Union's financial interests by means of criminal law (OJ L 198, 28.7.2017, p. 29).

⁶ OJ C 316, 27.11.1995, p. 48.

⁷ Council Regulation (EC, Euratom) No 2988/95 of 18 December 1995 on the protection of the European Communities financial interests (OJ L 312, 23.12.1995, p. 1).

⁸ 'Professional misconduct' includes, in particular, the following: violation of ethical standards of the profession; wrongful conduct with impact on professional credibility; breach of generally accepted professional ethical standards; false declarations/misrepresentation of information; participation in a cartel or other agreement distorting competition; violation of IPR; attempting to influence decision-making processes by taking advantage, through misrepresentation, of a conflict of interests, or to obtain confidential information from public authorities to gain an advantage; incitement to discrimination, hatred or violence or similar activities contrary to the EU values where negatively affecting or risking to affect the performance of a legal commitment.

The grant is an action grant⁹ which takes the form of a lump sum grant for the completion of work packages.

5.2 Maximum grant amount

The maximum grant amount is set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 3) and in the estimated budget (Annex 2).

5.3 Funding rate

Not applicable

5.4 Estimated budget, budget categories and forms of funding

The estimated budget for the action (lump sum breakdown) is set out in Annex 2.

It contains the estimated eligible contributions for the action (lump sum contributions), broken down by participant and work package.

Annex 2 also shows the types of contributions (forms of funding)¹⁰ to be used for each work package.

5.5 Budget flexibility

Budget flexibility does not apply; changes to the estimated budget (lump sum breakdown) always require an amendment (see Article 39).

Amendments for transfers between *work packages* are moreover possible only if:

- the work packages concerned are not already completed (and declared in a financial statement) and
- the transfers are justified by the technical implementation of the action.

ARTICLE 6 — ELIGIBLE AND INELIGIBLE CONTRIBUTIONS

6.1 and 6.2 General and specific eligibility conditions

Lump sum contributions are eligible ('eligible contributions'), if:

- (a) they are set out in Annex 2 and
- (b) the work packages are completed and the work is properly implemented by the beneficiaries and/or the results are achieved, in accordance with Annex 1 and during in the period set out in Article 4 (with the exception of work/results relating to the submission of the final periodic report, which may be achieved afterwards; see Article 21)

They will be calculated on the basis of the amounts set out in Annex 2.

⁹ For the definition, see Article 183(2)(a) EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509: '**action grant**' means an EU grant to finance "an action intended to help achieve a Union policy objective".

¹⁰ See Article 125 EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509.

6.3 Ineligible contributions

‘Ineligible contributions’ are:

- (a) lump sum contributions that do not comply with the conditions set out above (see Article 6.1 and 6.2)
- (b) lump sum contributions for activities already funded under other EU grants (or grants awarded by an EU Member State, non-EU country or other body implementing the EU budget), except for the following case:
 - (i) Synergy actions: not applicable
- (c) other:
 - (i) country restrictions for eligible costs: not applicable.

6.4 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary declares lump sum contributions that are ineligible, they will be rejected (see Article 27).

This may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

CHAPTER 4 GRANT IMPLEMENTATION

SECTION 1 CONSORTIUM: BENEFICIARIES, AFFILIATED ENTITIES AND OTHER PARTICIPANTS

ARTICLE 7 — BENEFICIARIES

The beneficiaries, as signatories of the Agreement, are fully responsible towards the granting authority for implementing it and for complying with all its obligations.

They must implement the Agreement to their best abilities, in good faith and in accordance with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

They must have the appropriate resources to implement the action and implement the action under their own responsibility and in accordance with Article 11. If they rely on affiliated entities or other participants (see Articles 8 and 9), they retain sole responsibility towards the granting authority and the other beneficiaries.

They are jointly responsible for the *technical* implementation of the action. If one of the beneficiaries fails to implement their part of the action, the other beneficiaries must ensure that this part is implemented by someone else (without being entitled to an increase of the maximum grant amount and subject to an amendment; see Article 39). The *financial* responsibility of each beneficiary in case of recoveries is governed by Article 22.

The beneficiaries (and their action) must remain eligible under the EU programme funding the grant

for the entire duration of the action. Lump sum contributions will be eligible only as long as the beneficiary and the action are eligible.

The **internal roles and responsibilities** of the beneficiaries are divided as follows:

(a) Each beneficiary must:

- (i) keep information stored in the Portal Participant Register up to date (see Article 19)
- (ii) inform the granting authority (and the other beneficiaries) immediately of any events or circumstances likely to affect significantly or delay the implementation of the action (see Article 19)
- (iii) submit to the coordinator in good time:
 - the prefinancing guarantees (if required; see Article 23)
 - the financial statements and certificates on the financial statements (CFS): not applicable
 - the contribution to the deliverables and technical reports (see Article 21)
 - any other documents or information required by the granting authority under the Agreement
- (iv) submit via the Portal data and information related to the participation of their affiliated entities.

(b) The coordinator must:

- (i) monitor that the action is implemented properly (see Article 11)
- (ii) act as the intermediary for all communications between the consortium and the granting authority, unless the Agreement or granting authority specifies otherwise, and in particular:
 - submit the prefinancing guarantees to the granting authority (if any)
 - request and review any documents or information required and verify their quality and completeness before passing them on to the granting authority
 - submit the deliverables and reports to the granting authority
 - inform the granting authority about the payments made to the other beneficiaries (report on the distribution of payments; if required, see Articles 22 and 32)
- (iii) distribute the payments received from the granting authority to the other beneficiaries without unjustified delay (see Article 22).

The coordinator may not delegate or subcontract the above-mentioned tasks to any other beneficiary or third party (including affiliated entities).

However, coordinators which are public bodies may delegate the tasks set out in Point (b)(ii) last

indent and (iii) above to entities with ‘authorisation to administer’ which they have created or which are controlled by or affiliated to them. In this case, the coordinator retains sole responsibility for the payments and for compliance with the obligations under the Agreement.

Moreover, coordinators which are ‘sole beneficiaries’¹¹ (or similar, such as European research infrastructure consortia (ERICs)) may delegate the tasks set out in Point (b)(i) to (iii) above to one of their members. The coordinator retains sole responsibility for compliance with the obligations under the Agreement.

The beneficiaries must have **internal arrangements** regarding their operation and co-ordination, to ensure that the action is implemented properly.

If required by the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 1), these arrangements must be set out in a written **consortium agreement** between the beneficiaries, covering for instance:

- the internal organisation of the consortium
- the management of access to the Portal
- different distribution keys for the payments and financial responsibilities in case of recoveries (if any)
- additional rules on rights and obligations related to background and results (see Article 16)
- settlement of internal disputes
- liability, indemnification and confidentiality arrangements between the beneficiaries.

The internal arrangements must not contain any provision contrary to this Agreement.

ARTICLE 8 — AFFILIATED ENTITIES

Not applicable

ARTICLE 9 — OTHER PARTICIPANTS INVOLVED IN THE ACTION

9.1 Associated partners

Not applicable

9.2 Third parties giving in-kind contributions to the action

Other third parties may give in-kind contributions to the action (i.e. personnel, equipment, other goods, works and services, etc. which are free-of-charge) if necessary for the implementation.

Third parties giving in-kind contributions do not implement any action tasks. They may not charge contributions to the action (no lump sum contributions) and their costs are considered entirely covered by the lump sum contributions paid to the beneficiaries.

¹¹ For the definition, see Article 190(2) EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509: “Where several entities satisfy the criteria for being awarded a grant and together form one entity, that entity may be treated as the **sole beneficiary**, including where it is specifically established for the purpose of implementing the action financed by the grant.”

The third parties and their in-kind contributions should be set out in Annex 1.

9.3 Subcontractors

Subcontractors may participate in the action, if necessary for the implementation.

Subcontractors must implement their action tasks in accordance with Article 11. The beneficiaries' costs for subcontracting are considered entirely covered by the lump sum contributions for implementing the work packages (irrespective of the actual subcontracting costs incurred, if any).

The beneficiaries must ensure that their contractual obligations under Articles 11 (proper implementation), 12 (conflict of interest), 13 (confidentiality and security), 14 (ethics), 17.2 (visibility), 18 (specific rules for carrying out action), 19 (information) and 20 (record-keeping) also apply to the subcontractors.

The beneficiaries must ensure that the bodies mentioned in Article 25 (e.g. granting authority, OLAF, Court of Auditors (ECA), etc.) can exercise their rights also towards the subcontractors.

9.4 Recipients of financial support to third parties

If the action includes providing financial support to third parties (e.g. grants, prizes or similar forms of support), the beneficiaries must ensure that their contractual obligations under Articles 12 (conflict of interest), 13 (confidentiality and security), 14 (ethics), 17.2 (visibility), 18 (specific rules for carrying out action), 19 (information) and 20 (record-keeping) also apply to the third parties receiving the support (recipients).

The beneficiaries must also ensure that the bodies mentioned in Article 25 (e.g. granting authority, OLAF, Court of Auditors (ECA), etc.) can exercise their rights also towards the recipients.

ARTICLE 10 — PARTICIPANTS WITH SPECIAL STATUS

10.1 Non-EU participants

Participants which are established in a non-EU country (if any) undertake to comply with their obligations under the Agreement and:

- to respect general principles (including fundamental rights, values and ethical principles, environmental and labour standards, rules on classified information, intellectual property rights, visibility of funding and protection of personal data)
- for the submission of certificates under Article 24: use qualified external auditors which are independent and comply with comparable standards as those set out in EU Directive 2006/43/EC¹²
- for the controls under Article 25: allow for checks, reviews, audits and investigations (including on-the-spot checks, visits and inspections) by the bodies mentioned in that Article (e.g. granting authority, OLAF, Court of Auditors (ECA), etc.).

¹² Directive 2006/43/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council of 17 May 2006 on statutory audits of annual accounts and consolidated accounts (OJ L 157, 9.6.2006, p. 87).

Special rules on dispute settlement apply (see Data Sheet, Point 5).

10.2 Participants which are international organisations

Participants which are international organisations (IOs; if any) undertake to comply with their obligations under the Agreement and:

- to respect general principles (including fundamental rights, values and ethical principles, environmental and labour standards, rules on classified information, intellectual property rights, visibility of funding and protection of personal data)
- for the submission of certificates under Article 24: to use either independent public officers or external auditors which comply with comparable standards as those set out in EU Directive 2006/43/EC¹³
- for the controls under Article 25: to allow for the checks, reviews, audits and investigations by the bodies mentioned in that Article, taking into account the specific agreements concluded by them and the EU (if any).

For such participants, nothing in the Agreement will be interpreted as a waiver of their privileges or immunities, as accorded by their constituent documents or international law.

Special rules on applicable law and dispute settlement apply (see Article 43 and Data Sheet, Point 5).

10.3 Pillar-assessed participants

Pillar-assessed participants (if any) may rely on their own systems, rules and procedures, in so far as they have been positively assessed and do not call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants or beneficiaries.

‘Pillar-assessment’ means a review by the European Commission on the systems, rules and procedures which participants use for managing EU grants (in particular internal control system, accounting system, external audits, financing of third parties, rules on recovery and exclusion, information on recipients and protection of personal data; see Article 157 EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509).

Participants with a positive pillar assessment may rely on their own systems, rules and procedures, in particular for:

- record-keeping (Article 20): may be done in accordance with internal standards, rules and procedures
- currency conversion for financial statements (Article 21): may be done in accordance with usual accounting practices
- guarantees (Article 23): for public law bodies, prefinancing guarantees are not needed
- certificates (Article 24):
 - certificates on the financial statements (CFS): may be provided by their regular internal

¹³ Directive 2006/43/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council of 17 May 2006 on statutory audits of annual accounts and consolidated accounts (OJ L 157, 9.6.2006, p. 87).

or external auditors and in accordance with their internal financial regulations and procedures

- certificates on usual accounting practices (CoMUC): are not needed if those practices are covered by an ex-ante assessment

and use the following specific rules, for:

- recoveries (Article 22): in case of financial support to third parties, there will be no recovery if the participant has done everything possible to retrieve the undue amounts from the third party receiving the support (including legal proceedings) and non-recovery is not due to an error or negligence on its part
- checks, reviews, audits and investigations by the EU (Article 25): will be conducted taking into account the rules and procedures specifically agreed between them and the framework agreement (if any)
- impact evaluation (Article 26): will be conducted in accordance with the participant's internal rules and procedures and the framework agreement (if any)
- grant agreement termination (Article 32): the final grant amount and final payment will be calculated taking into account also costs relating to contracts due for execution only after termination takes effect, if the contract was entered into before the pre-information letter was received and could not reasonably be terminated on legal grounds
- liability for damages (Article 33.2): the granting authority must be compensated for damage it sustains as a result of the implementation of the action or because the action was not implemented in full compliance with the Agreement only if the damage is due to an infringement of the participant's internal rules and procedures or due to a violation of third parties' rights by the participant or one of its employees or individual for whom the employees are responsible.

Participants whose pillar assessment covers procurement and granting procedures may also do purchases, subcontracting and financial support to third parties (Article 6.2) in accordance with their internal rules and procedures for purchases, subcontracting and financial support.

Participants whose pillar assessment covers data protection rules may rely on their internal standards, rules and procedures for data protection (Article 15).

The participants may however not rely on provisions which would breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants or beneficiaries or call into question the decision awarding the grant, such as in particular:

- eligibility (Article 6)
- consortium roles and set-up (Articles 7-9)
- security and ethics (Articles 13, 14)
- IPR (including background and results, access rights and rights of use), communication, dissemination and visibility (Articles 16 and 17)

- information obligation (Article 19)
- payment, reporting and amendments (Articles 21, 22 and 39)
- rejections, reductions, suspensions and terminations (Articles 27, 28, 29-32)

If the pillar assessment was subject to remedial measures, reliance on the internal systems, rules and procedures is subject to compliance with those remedial measures.

Participants must inform the coordinator without delay of any changes to the systems, rules and procedures that were part of the pillar assessment. The coordinator must immediately inform the granting authority.

Pillar-assessed participants that have also concluded a framework agreement with the EU, may moreover — under the same conditions as those above (i.e. not call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants or beneficiaries) — rely on provisions set out in that framework agreement.

SECTION 2 RULES FOR CARRYING OUT THE ACTION

ARTICLE 11 — PROPER IMPLEMENTATION OF THE ACTION

11.1 Obligation to properly implement the action

The beneficiaries must implement the action as described in Annex 1 and in compliance with the provisions of the Agreement, the call conditions and all legal obligations under applicable EU, international and national law.

11.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 12 — CONFLICT OF INTERESTS

12.1 Conflict of interests

The beneficiaries must take all measures to prevent any situation where the impartial and objective implementation of the Agreement could be compromised for reasons involving family, emotional life, political or national affinity, economic interest or any other direct or indirect interest ('conflict of interests').

They must formally notify the granting authority without delay of any situation constituting or likely to lead to a conflict of interests and immediately take all the necessary steps to rectify this situation.

The granting authority may verify that the measures taken are appropriate and may require additional measures to be taken by a specified deadline.

12.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28) and the grant or the beneficiary may be terminated (see Article 32).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 13 — CONFIDENTIALITY AND SECURITY

13.1 Sensitive information

The parties must keep confidential any data, documents or other material (in any form) that is identified as sensitive in writing ('sensitive information') — during the implementation of the action and for at least until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6).

If a beneficiary requests, the granting authority may agree to keep such information confidential for a longer period.

Unless otherwise agreed between the parties, they may use sensitive information only to implement the Agreement.

The beneficiaries may disclose sensitive information to their personnel or other participants involved in the action only if they:

- (a) need to know it in order to implement the Agreement and
- (b) are bound by an obligation of confidentiality.

The granting authority may disclose sensitive information to its staff and to other EU institutions and bodies.

It may moreover disclose sensitive information to third parties, if:

- (a) this is necessary to implement the Agreement or safeguard the EU financial interests and
- (b) the recipients of the information are bound by an obligation of confidentiality.

The confidentiality obligations no longer apply if:

- (a) the disclosing party agrees to release the other party
- (b) the information becomes publicly available, without breaching any confidentiality obligation
- (c) the disclosure of the sensitive information is required by EU, international or national law.

Specific confidentiality rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

13.2 Classified information

The parties must handle classified information in accordance with the applicable EU, international or national law on classified information (in particular, Decision 2015/444¹⁴ and its implementing rules).

¹⁴ Commission Decision 2015/444/EC, Euratom of 13 March 2015 on the security rules for protecting EU classified information (OJ L 72, 17.3.2015, p. 53).

Deliverables which contain classified information must be submitted according to special procedures agreed with the granting authority.

Action tasks involving classified information may be subcontracted only after explicit approval (in writing) from the granting authority.

Classified information may not be disclosed to any third party (including participants involved in the action implementation) without prior explicit written approval from the granting authority.

Specific security rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

13.3 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 14 — ETHICS AND VALUES

14.1 Ethics

The action must be carried out in line with the highest ethical standards and the applicable EU, international and national law on ethical principles.

Specific ethics rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

14.2 Values

The beneficiaries must commit to and ensure the respect of basic EU values (such as respect for human dignity, freedom, democracy, equality, the rule of law and human rights, including the rights of minorities).

Specific rules on values (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

14.3 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 15 — DATA PROTECTION

15.1 Data processing by the granting authority

Any personal data under the Agreement will be processed under the responsibility of the data controller of the granting authority in accordance with and for the purposes set out in the Portal Privacy Statement.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission, an EU regulatory or executive agency, joint undertaking or other EU body, the processing will be subject to Regulation 2018/1725¹⁵.

15.2 Data processing by the beneficiaries

The beneficiaries must process personal data under the Agreement in compliance with the applicable EU, international and national law on data protection (in particular, Regulation 2016/679¹⁶).

They must ensure that personal data is:

- processed lawfully, fairly and in a transparent manner in relation to the data subjects
- collected for specified, explicit and legitimate purposes and not further processed in a manner that is incompatible with those purposes
- adequate, relevant and limited to what is necessary in relation to the purposes for which they are processed
- accurate and, where necessary, kept up to date
- kept in a form which permits identification of data subjects for no longer than is necessary for the purposes for which the data is processed and
- processed in a manner that ensures appropriate security of the data.

The beneficiaries may grant their personnel access to personal data only if it is strictly necessary for implementing, managing and monitoring the Agreement. The beneficiaries must ensure that the personnel is under a confidentiality obligation.

The beneficiaries must inform the persons whose data are transferred to the granting authority and provide them with the Portal Privacy Statement.

15.3 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 16 — INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY RIGHTS (IPR) — BACKGROUND AND RESULTS — ACCESS RIGHTS AND RIGHTS OF USE

16.1 Background and access rights to background

¹⁵ Regulation (EU) 2018/1725 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 23 October 2018 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data by the Union institutions, bodies, offices and agencies and on the free movement of such data, and repealing Regulation (EC) No 45/2001 and Decision No 1247/2002/EC (OJ L 295, 21.11.2018, p. 39).

¹⁶ Regulation (EU) 2016/679 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 27 April 2016 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data and on the free movement of such data, and repealing Directive 95/46/EC ('GDPR') (OJ L 119, 4.5.2016, p. 1).

The beneficiaries must give each other and the other participants access to the background identified as needed for implementing the action, subject to any specific rules in Annex 5.

‘Background’ means any data, know-how or information — whatever its form or nature (tangible or intangible), including any rights such as intellectual property rights — that is:

- (a) held by the beneficiaries before they acceded to the Agreement and
- (b) needed to implement the action or exploit the results.

If background is subject to rights of a third party, the beneficiary concerned must ensure that it is able to comply with its obligations under the Agreement.

16.2 Ownership of results

The granting authority does not obtain ownership of the results produced under the action.

‘Results’ means any tangible or intangible effect of the action, such as data, know-how or information, whatever its form or nature, whether or not it can be protected, as well as any rights attached to it, including intellectual property rights.

16.3 Rights of use of the granting authority on materials, documents and information received for policy, information, communication, dissemination and publicity purposes

The granting authority has the right to use non-sensitive information relating to the action and materials and documents received from the beneficiaries (notably summaries for publication, deliverables, as well as any other material, such as pictures or audio-visual material, in paper or electronic form) for policy information, communication, dissemination and publicity purposes — during the action or afterwards.

The right to use the beneficiaries’ materials, documents and information is granted in the form of a royalty-free, non-exclusive and irrevocable licence, which includes the following rights:

- (a) **use for its own purposes** (in particular, making them available to persons working for the granting authority or any other EU service (including institutions, bodies, offices, agencies, etc.) or EU Member State institution or body; copying or reproducing them in whole or in part, in unlimited numbers; and communication through press information services)
- (b) **distribution to the public** (in particular, publication as hard copies and in electronic or digital format, publication on the internet, as a downloadable or non-downloadable file, broadcasting by any channel, public display or presentation, communicating through press information services, or inclusion in widely accessible databases or indexes)
- (c) **editing or redrafting** (including shortening, summarising, inserting other elements (e.g. meta-data, legends, other graphic, visual, audio or text elements), extracting parts (e.g. audio or video files), dividing into parts, use in a compilation)
- (d) **translation**
- (e) **storage** in paper, electronic or other form
- (f) **archiving**, in line with applicable document-management rules

- (g) the right to authorise **third parties** to act on its behalf or sub-license to third parties the modes of use set out in Points (b), (c), (d) and (f), if needed for the information, communication and publicity activity of the granting authority and
- (h) **processing**, analysing, aggregating the materials, documents and information received and **producing derivative works**.

The rights of use are granted for the whole duration of the industrial or intellectual property rights concerned.

If materials or documents are subject to moral rights or third party rights (including intellectual property rights or rights of natural persons on their image and voice), the beneficiaries must ensure that they comply with their obligations under this Agreement (in particular, by obtaining the necessary licences and authorisations from the rights holders concerned).

Where applicable, the granting authority will insert the following information:

“© – [year] – [name of the copyright owner]. All rights reserved. Licensed to the [name of granting authority] under conditions.”

16.4 Specific rules on IPR, results and background

Specific rules regarding intellectual property rights, results and background (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

16.5 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such a breach may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 17 — COMMUNICATION, DISSEMINATION AND VISIBILITY

17.1 Communication — Dissemination — Promoting the action

Unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority, the beneficiaries must promote the action and its results by providing targeted information to multiple audiences (including the media and the public), in accordance with Annex 1 and in a strategic, coherent and effective manner.

Before engaging in a communication or dissemination activity expected to have a major media impact, the beneficiaries must inform the granting authority.

17.2 Visibility — European flag and funding statement

Unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority, communication activities of the beneficiaries related to the action (including media relations, conferences, seminars, information material, such as brochures, leaflets, posters, presentations, etc., in electronic form, via traditional or social media, etc.), dissemination activities and any infrastructure, equipment, vehicles, supplies or major result funded by the grant must acknowledge the EU support and display the European flag (emblem) and funding statement (translated into local languages, where appropriate):



Funded by the
European Union



Co-funded by the
European Union



Funded by the
European Union



Co-funded by the
European Union

The emblem must remain distinct and separate and cannot be modified by adding other visual marks, brands or text.

Apart from the emblem, no other visual identity or logo may be used to highlight the EU support.

When displayed in association with other logos (e.g. of beneficiaries or sponsors), the emblem must be displayed at least as prominently and visibly as the other logos.

For the purposes of their obligations under this Article, the beneficiaries may use the emblem without first obtaining approval from the granting authority. This does not, however, give them the right to exclusive use. Moreover, they may not appropriate the emblem or any similar trademark or logo, either by registration or by any other means.

17.3 Quality of information — Disclaimer

Any communication or dissemination activity related to the action must use factually accurate information.

Moreover, it must indicate the following disclaimer (translated into local languages where appropriate):

“Funded by the European Union. Views and opinions expressed are however those of the author(s) only and do not necessarily reflect those of the European Union or [name of the granting authority]. Neither the European Union nor the granting authority can be held responsible for them.”

17.4 Specific communication, dissemination and visibility rules

Specific communication, dissemination and visibility rules (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

17.5 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 18 — SPECIFIC RULES FOR CARRYING OUT THE ACTION

18.1 Specific rules for carrying out the action

Specific rules for implementing the action (if any) are set out in Annex 5.

18.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such a breach may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

SECTION 3 GRANT ADMINISTRATION

ARTICLE 19 — GENERAL INFORMATION OBLIGATIONS

19.1 Information requests

The beneficiaries must provide — during the action or afterwards and in accordance with Article 7 — any information requested in order to verify eligibility of the lump sum contributions declared, proper implementation of the action and compliance with the other obligations under the Agreement.

The information provided must be accurate, precise and complete and in the format requested, including electronic format.

19.2 Participant Register data updates

The beneficiaries must keep — at all times, during the action or afterwards — their information stored in the Portal Participant Register up to date, in particular, their name, address, legal representatives, legal form and organisation type.

19.3 Information about events and circumstances which impact the action

The beneficiaries must immediately inform the granting authority (and the other beneficiaries) of any of the following:

- (a) **events** which are likely to affect or delay the implementation of the action or affect the EU's financial interests, in particular:
 - (i) changes in their legal, financial, technical, organisational or ownership situation (including changes linked to one of the exclusion grounds listed in the declaration of honour signed before grant signature)
 - (ii) linked action information: not applicable

(b) **circumstances** affecting:

- (i) the decision to award the grant or
- (ii) compliance with requirements under the Agreement.

19.4 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 20 — RECORD-KEEPING

20.1 Keeping records and supporting documents

The beneficiaries must — at least until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6) — keep records and other supporting documents to prove the proper implementation of the action (proper implementation of the work and/or achievement of the results as described in Annex 1) in line with the accepted standards in the respective field (if any); beneficiaries do not need to keep specific records on the actual costs incurred.

The records and supporting documents must be made available upon request (see Article 19) or in the context of checks, reviews, audits or investigations (see Article 25).

If there are on-going checks, reviews, audits, investigations, litigation or other pursuits of claims under the Agreement (including the extension of findings; see Article 25), the beneficiaries must keep these records and other supporting documentation until the end of these procedures.

The beneficiaries must keep the original documents. Digital and digitalised documents are considered originals if they are authorised by the applicable national law. The granting authority may accept non-original documents if they offer a comparable level of assurance.

20.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, lump sum contributions insufficiently substantiated will be ineligible (see Article 6) and will be rejected (see Article 27), and the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 21 — REPORTING

21.1 Continuous reporting

The beneficiaries must report on the progress of the action (e.g. **deliverables, milestones, outputs/outcomes, critical risks, indicators**, etc; if any), in the Portal Continuous Reporting tool and in accordance with the timing and conditions it sets out (as agreed with the granting authority).

Standardised deliverables (e.g. progress reports not linked to payments, reports on cumulative expenditure, special reports, etc; if any) must be submitted using the templates published on the Portal.

21.2 Periodic reporting: Technical reports and financial statements

In addition, the beneficiaries must provide reports to request payments, in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2):

- for additional prefinancings (if any): **an additional prefinancing report**
- for interim payments (if any) and the final payment: a **periodic report**

The prefinancing and periodic reports include a technical and financial part.

The technical part includes an overview of the action implementation. It must be prepared using the template available in the Portal Periodic Reporting tool.

The financial part of the additional prefinancing report includes a statement on the use of the previous prefinancing payment.

The financial part of the periodic report includes:

- the financial statement (consolidated statement for the consortium)
- the explanation on the use of resources (or detailed cost reporting table): not applicable
- the certificates on the financial statements (CFS): not applicable.

The **financial statement** must contain the lump sum contributions indicated in Annex 2, for the work packages that were completed during the reporting period.

For the last reporting period, the beneficiaries may exceptionally also declare partial lump sum contributions for work packages that were not completed (e.g. due to force majeure or technical impossibility).

Lump sum contributions which are not declared in a financial statement will not be taken into account by the granting authority.

By signing the financial statement (directly in the Portal Periodic Reporting tool), the coordinator confirms (on behalf of the consortium) that:

- the information provided is complete, reliable and true
- the lump sum contributions declared are eligible (in particular, the work packages have been completed, that the work has been properly implemented and/or the results were achieved in accordance with Annex 1; see Article 6)
- the proper implementation and/or achievement can be substantiated by adequate records and supporting documents (see Article 20) that will be produced upon request (see Article 19) or in the context of checks, reviews, audits and investigations (see Article 25).

In case of recoveries (see Article 22), beneficiaries will be held responsible also for the lump sum contributions declared for their affiliated entities (if any).

21.3 Currency for financial statements and conversion into euros

The financial statements must be drafted in euro.

21.4 Reporting language

The reporting must be in the language of the Agreement, unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

21.5 Consequences of non-compliance

If a report submitted does not comply with this Article, the granting authority may suspend the payment deadline (see Article 29) and apply other measures described in Chapter 5.

If the coordinator breaches its reporting obligations, the granting authority may terminate the grant or the coordinator's participation (see Article 32) or apply other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 22 — PAYMENTS AND RECOVERIES — CALCULATION OF AMOUNTS DUE

22.1 Payments and payment arrangements

Payments will be made in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

They will be made in euro to the bank account indicated by the coordinator (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2) and must be distributed without unjustified delay (restrictions may apply to distribution of the initial prefinancing payment; see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

Payments to this bank account will discharge the granting authority from its payment obligation.

The cost of payment transfers will be borne as follows:

- the granting authority bears the cost of transfers charged by its bank
- the beneficiary bears the cost of transfers charged by its bank
- the party causing a repetition of a transfer bears all costs of the repeated transfer.

Payments by the granting authority will be considered to have been carried out on the date when they are debited to its account.

22.2 Recoveries

Recoveries will be made, if — at beneficiary termination, final payment or afterwards — it turns out that the granting authority has paid too much and needs to recover the amounts undue.

Each beneficiary's financial responsibility in case of recovery is in principle limited to their own debt and undue amounts of their affiliated entities.

In case of enforced recoveries (see Article 22.4), affiliated entities will be held liable for repaying debts of their beneficiaries, if required by the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.4).

22.3 Amounts due

22.3.1 Prefinancing payments

The aim of the prefinancing is to provide the beneficiaries with a float.

It remains the property of the EU until the final payment.

For **initial prefinancings** (if any), the amount due, schedule and modalities are set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

For **additional prefinancings** (if any), the amount due, schedule and modalities are also set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2). However, if the statement on the use of the previous prefinancing payment shows that less than 70% was used, the amount set out in the Data Sheet will be reduced by the difference between the 70% threshold and the amount used.

The contribution to the Mutual Insurance Mechanism will be retained from the prefinancing payments (at the rate and in accordance with the modalities set out in the Data Sheet, see Point 4.2) and transferred to the Mechanism.

Prefinancing payments (or parts of them) may be offset (without the beneficiaries' consent) against amounts owed by a beneficiary to the granting authority — up to the amount due to that beneficiary.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, offsetting may also be done against amounts owed to other Commission services or executive agencies.

Payments will not be made if the payment deadline or payments are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30).

22.3.2 Amount due at beneficiary termination — Recovery

In case of beneficiary termination, the granting authority will determine the provisional amount due for the beneficiary concerned.

This will be done on the basis of work packages already completed in previous interim payments. Payments for ongoing/not yet completed work packages which the beneficiary was working on before termination (if any) will therefore be made only later on, with the next interim or final payments when those work packages have been completed.

The **amount due** will be calculated in the following step:

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the 'accepted EU contribution' for the beneficiary, on the basis of the beneficiary's lump sum contributions for the work packages which were approved in previous interim payments.

After that, the granting authority will take into account grant reductions (if any). The resulting amount is the 'total accepted EU contribution' for the beneficiary.

The **balance** is then calculated by deducting the payments received (if any; see report on the distribution of payments in Article 32), from the total accepted EU contribution:

$$\begin{aligned} & \{ \text{total accepted EU contribution for the beneficiary} \\ & \text{minus} \\ & \{ \text{prefinancing and interim payments received (if any)} \} \}. \end{aligned}$$

If the balance is **negative**, it will be **recovered** in accordance with the following procedure:

The granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to recover, the amount due, the amount to be recovered and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If no observations are submitted (or the granting authority decides to pursue recovery despite the observations it has received), it will confirm the amount to be recovered and ask this amount to be paid to the coordinator (**confirmation letter**).

If payment is not made to the coordinator by the date specified in the confirmation letter, the granting authority may call on the Mutual Insurance Mechanism to intervene, if continuation of the action is guaranteed and the conditions set out in the rules governing the Mechanism are met.

In this case, it will send a **beneficiary recovery letter**, together with a **debit note** with the terms and date for payment.

The debit note for the beneficiary will include the amount calculated for the affiliated entities which also had to end their participation (if any).

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the granting authority will **enforce recovery** in accordance with Article 22.4.

22.3.3 Interim payments

Interim payments reimburse the eligible lump sum contributions claimed for work packages implemented during the reporting periods (if any).

Interim payments (if any) will be made in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

Payment is subject to the approval of the periodic report and the work packages declared. Their approval does not imply recognition of compliance, authenticity, completeness or correctness of their content.

Incomplete work packages and work packages that have not been delivered or cannot be approved will be rejected (see Article 27).

The **interim payment** will be calculated by the granting authority in the following steps:

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

Step 2 — Limit to the interim payment ceiling

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the ‘accepted EU contribution’ for the action for the reporting period, by calculating the lump sum contributions for the approved work packages.

After that, the granting authority will take into account grant reductions from beneficiary termination (if any). The resulting amount is the ‘total accepted EU contribution’.

Step 2 — Limit to the interim payment ceiling

The resulting amount is then capped to ensure that the total amount of prefinancing and interim payments (if any) does not exceed the interim payment ceiling set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

Interim payments (or parts of them) may be offset (without the beneficiaries’ consent) against amounts owed by a beneficiary to the granting authority — up to the amount due to that beneficiary.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, offsetting may also be done against amounts owed to other Commission services or executive agencies.

Payments will not be made if the payment deadline or payments are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30).

22.3.4 Final payment — Final grant amount — Revenues and Profit — Recovery

The final payment (payment of the balance) reimburses the remaining eligible lump sum contributions claimed for the implemented work packages (if any).

The final payment will be made in accordance with the schedule and modalities set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 4.2).

Payment is subject to the approval of the final periodic report and the work packages declared. Their approval does not imply recognition of compliance, authenticity, completeness or correctness of their content.

Work packages (or parts of them) that have not been delivered or cannot be approved will be rejected (see Article 27).

The **final grant amount for the action** will be calculated in the following steps:

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

Step 2 — Limit to the maximum grant amount

Step 3 — Reduction due to the no-profit rule

Step 1 — Calculation of the total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the ‘accepted EU contribution’ for the action for all reporting periods, by calculating the lump sum contributions for the approved work packages.

After that, the granting authority will take into account grant reductions (if any). The resulting amount is the ‘total accepted EU contribution’.

Step 2 — Limit to the maximum grant amount

Not applicable

Step 3 — Reduction due to the no-profit rule

Not applicable

The **balance** (final payment) is then calculated by deducting the total amount of prefinancing and interim payments already made (if any), from the final grant amount:

$$\begin{aligned} & \{\text{final grant amount} \\ & \text{minus} \\ & \{\text{prefinancing and interim payments made (if any)}\} \}. \end{aligned}$$

If the balance is **positive**, it will be **paid** to the coordinator.

The amount retained for the Mutual Insurance Mechanism (see above) will be released and **paid** to the coordinator (in accordance with the rules governing the Mechanism).

The final payment (or part of it) may be offset (without the beneficiaries’ consent) against amounts owed by a beneficiary to the granting authority — up to the amount due to that beneficiary.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, offsetting may also be done against amounts owed to other Commission services or executive agencies.

Payments will not be made if the payment deadline or payments are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30).

If — despite the release of the Mutual Insurance Mechanism contribution — the balance is **negative**, it will be **recovered** in accordance with the following procedure:

The granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the coordinator:

- formally notifying the intention to recover, the final grant amount, the amount to be recovered and the reasons why
- requesting a report on the distribution of payments to the beneficiaries within 30 days of receiving notification and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If no observations are submitted (or the granting authority decides to pursue recovery despite the observations it has received) and the coordinator has submitted the report on the distribution of payments, it will calculate the **share of the debt per beneficiary**, by:

- (a) identifying the beneficiaries for which the amount calculated as follows is negative:

$$\left\{ \left\{ \text{total accepted EU contribution for the beneficiary} \right. \right.$$

$$\text{divided by}$$

$$\text{total accepted EU contribution for the action} \left. \right\}$$

$$\text{multiplied by}$$

$$\text{final grant amount for the action} \left. \right\},$$

$$\text{minus}$$

$$\left\{ \text{prefinancing and interim payments received by the beneficiary (if any)} \right\} \left. \right\}$$

and

(b) dividing the debt:

$$\left\{ \text{amount calculated according to point (a) for the beneficiary concerned} \right.$$

$$\text{divided by}$$

$$\text{the sum of the amounts calculated according to point (a) for all the beneficiaries identified according to point (a)} \left. \right\}$$

$$\text{multiplied by}$$

$$\text{the amount to be recovered} \left. \right\}.$$

and confirm the amount to be recovered from each beneficiary concerned (**confirmation letter**), together with **debit notes** with the terms and date for payment.

The debit notes for beneficiaries will include the amounts calculated for their affiliated entities (if any).

If the coordinator has not submitted the report on the distribution of payments, the granting authority will **recover** the full amount from the coordinator (**confirmation letter** and **debit note** with the terms and date for payment).

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the granting authority will **enforce recovery** in accordance with Article 22.4.

22.3.5 Audit implementation after final payment — Revised final grant amount — Recovery

If — after the final payment (in particular, after checks, reviews, audits or investigations; see Article 25) — the granting authority rejects lump sum contributions (see Article 27) or reduces the grant (see Article 28), it will calculate the **revised final grant amount** for the beneficiary concerned.

The **beneficiary revised final grant amount** will be calculated in the following step:

Step 1 — Calculation of the revised total accepted EU contribution

Step 1 — Calculation of the revised total accepted EU contribution

The granting authority will first calculate the ‘revised accepted EU contribution’ for the beneficiary, by calculating the ‘revised accepted contributions’.

After that, it will take into account grant reductions (if any). The resulting ‘revised total accepted EU contribution’ is the beneficiary revised final grant amount.

If the revised final grant amount is lower than the beneficiary’s final grant amount (i.e. its share in the final grant amount for the action), it will be **recovered** in accordance with the following procedure:

The **beneficiary final grant amount** (i.e. share in the final grant amount for the action) is calculated as follows:

$$\left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{total accepted EU contribution for the beneficiary} \\ \text{divided by} \\ \text{total accepted EU contribution for the action} \end{array} \right\} \times \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \text{multiplied by} \\ \text{final grant amount for the action} \end{array} \right\}.$$

The granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to recover, the amount to be recovered and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If no observations are submitted (or the granting authority decides to pursue recovery despite the observations it has received), it will confirm the amount to be recovered (**confirmation letter**), together with a **debit note** with the terms and the date for payment.

Recoveries against affiliated entities (if any) will be handled through their beneficiaries.

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the granting authority will **enforce recovery** in accordance with Article 22.4.

22.4 Enforced recovery

If payment is not made by the date specified in the debit note, the amount due will be recovered:

- (a) by offsetting the amount — without the coordinator or beneficiary’s consent — against any amounts owed to the coordinator or beneficiary by the granting authority.

In exceptional circumstances, to safeguard the EU financial interests, the amount may be offset before the payment date specified in the debit note.

For grants where the granting authority is the European Commission or an EU executive agency, debts may also be offset against amounts owed by other Commission services or executive agencies.

- (b) financial guarantee(s): not applicable
- (c) joint and several liability of beneficiaries: not applicable
- (d) by holding affiliated entities jointly and severally liable (if any, see Data Sheet, Point 4.4)
- (e) by taking legal action (see Article 43) or, provided that the granting authority is the European

Commission or an EU executive agency, by adopting an enforceable decision under Article 299 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU) and Article 100(2) of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509.

If the Mutual Insurance Mechanism was called on by the granting authority to intervene, recovery will be continued in the name of the Mutual Insurance Mechanism. If two debit notes were sent, the second one (in the name of the Mutual Insurance Mechanism) will be considered to replace the first one (in the name of the granting authority). Where the MIM intervened, offsetting, enforceable decisions or any other of the above-mentioned forms of enforced recovery may be used *mutatis mutandis*.

The amount to be recovered will be increased by **late-payment interest** at the rate set out in Article 23.5, from the day following the payment date in the debit note, up to and including the date the full payment is received.

Partial payments will be first credited against expenses, charges and late-payment interest and then against the principal.

Bank charges incurred in the recovery process will be borne by the beneficiary, unless Directive 2015/2366¹⁷ applies.

For grants where the granting authority is an EU executive agency, enforced recovery by offsetting or enforceable decision will be done by the services of the European Commission (see also Article 43).

22.5 Consequences of non-compliance

22.5.1 If the granting authority does not pay within the payment deadlines (see above), the beneficiaries are entitled to **late-payment interest** at the reference rate applied by the European Central Bank (ECB) for its main refinancing operations in euros, plus the percentage specified in the Data Sheet (Point 4.2). The ECB reference rate to be used is the rate in force on the first day of the month in which the payment deadline expires, as published in the C series of the *Official Journal of the European Union*.

If the late-payment interest is lower than or equal to EUR 200, it will be paid to the coordinator only on request submitted within two months of receiving the late payment.

Late-payment interest is not due if all beneficiaries are EU Member States (including regional and local government authorities or other public bodies acting on behalf of a Member State for the purpose of this Agreement).

If payments or the payment deadline are suspended (see Articles 29 and 30), payment will not be considered as late.

Late-payment interest covers the period running from the day following the due date for payment (see above), up to and including the date of payment.

Late-payment interest is not considered for the purposes of calculating the final grant amount.

¹⁷ Directive (EU) 2015/2366 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 25 November 2015 on payment services in the internal market, amending Directives 2002/65/EC, 2009/110/EC and 2013/36/EU and Regulation (EU) No 1093/2010, and repealing Directive 2007/64/EC (OJ L 337, 23.12.2015, p. 35).

22.5.2 If the coordinator breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the grant may be reduced (see Article 28) and the grant or the coordinator may be terminated (see Article 32).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 23 — GUARANTEES

Not applicable

ARTICLE 24 — CERTIFICATES

Not applicable

ARTICLE 25 — CHECKS, REVIEWS, AUDITS AND INVESTIGATIONS — EXTENSION OF FINDINGS

25.1 Granting authority checks, reviews and audits

25.1.1 Internal checks

The granting authority may — during the action or afterwards — check the proper implementation of the action and compliance with the obligations under the Agreement, including assessing lump sum contributions, deliverables and reports.

25.1.2 Project reviews

The granting authority may carry out reviews on the proper implementation of the action and compliance with the obligations under the Agreement (general project reviews or specific issues reviews).

Such project reviews may be started during the implementation of the action and until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6). They will be formally notified to the coordinator or beneficiary concerned and will be considered to start on the date of the notification.

If needed, the granting authority may be assisted by independent, outside experts. If it uses outside experts, the coordinator or beneficiary concerned will be informed and have the right to object on grounds of commercial confidentiality or conflict of interest.

The coordinator or beneficiary concerned must cooperate diligently and provide — within the deadline requested — any information and data in addition to deliverables and reports already submitted. The granting authority may request beneficiaries to provide such information to it directly. Sensitive information and documents will be treated in accordance with Article 13.

The coordinator or beneficiary concerned may be requested to participate in meetings, including with the outside experts.

For **on-the-spot visits**, the beneficiary concerned must allow access to sites and premises (including to the outside experts) and must ensure that information requested is readily available.

Information provided must be accurate, precise and complete and in the format requested, including electronic format.

On the basis of the review findings, a **project review report** will be drawn up.

The granting authority will formally notify the project review report to the coordinator or beneficiary concerned, which has 30 days from receiving notification to make observations.

Project reviews (including project review reports) will be in the language of the Agreement, unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

25.1.3 Audits

The granting authority may carry out audits on the proper implementation of the action and compliance with the obligations under the Agreement.

Such audits may be started during the implementation of the action and until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6). They will be formally notified to the beneficiary concerned and will be considered to start on the date of the notification.

The granting authority may use its own audit service, delegate audits to a centralised service or use external audit firms. If it uses an external firm, the beneficiary concerned will be informed and have the right to object on grounds of commercial confidentiality or conflict of interest.

The beneficiary concerned must cooperate diligently and provide — within the deadline requested — any information (including complete accounts, individual salary statements or other personal data) to verify compliance with the Agreement. Sensitive information and documents will be treated in accordance with Article 13.

For **on-the-spot** visits, the beneficiary concerned must allow access to sites and premises (including for the external audit firm) and must ensure that information requested is readily available.

Information provided must be accurate, precise and complete and in the format requested, including electronic format.

On the basis of the audit findings, a **draft audit report** will be drawn up.

The auditors will formally notify the draft audit report to the beneficiary concerned, which has 30 days from receiving notification to make observations (contradictory audit procedure).

The **final audit report** will take into account observations by the beneficiary concerned and will be formally notified to them.

Audits (including audit reports) will be in the language of the Agreement, unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2).

25.2 European Commission checks, reviews and audits in grants of other granting authorities

Where the granting authority is not the European Commission, the latter has the same rights of checks, reviews and audits as the granting authority.

25.3 Access to records for assessing simplified forms of funding

The beneficiaries must give the European Commission access to their statutory records for the periodic assessment of simplified forms of funding which are used in EU programmes.

25.4 OLAF, EPPO and ECA audits and investigations

The following bodies may also carry out checks, reviews, audits and investigations — during the action or afterwards:

- the European Anti-Fraud Office (OLAF) under Regulations No 883/2013¹⁸ and No 2185/96¹⁹
- the European Public Prosecutor's Office (EPPO) under Regulation 2017/1939
- the European Court of Auditors (ECA) under Article 287 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU) and Article 263 of EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509.

If requested by these bodies, the beneficiary concerned must provide full, accurate and complete information in the format requested (including complete accounts, individual salary statements or other personal data, including in electronic format) and allow access to sites and premises for on-the-spot visits or inspections — as provided for under these Regulations.

To this end, the beneficiary concerned must keep all relevant information relating to the action, at least until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (Point 6) and, in any case, until any ongoing checks, reviews, audits, investigations, litigation or other pursuits of claims have been concluded.

25.5 Consequences of checks, reviews, audits and investigations — Extension of findings

25.5.1 Consequences of checks, reviews, audits and investigations in this grant

Findings in checks, reviews, audits or investigations carried out in the context of this grant may lead to rejections (see Article 27), grant reduction (see Article 28) or other measures described in Chapter 5.

Rejections or grant reductions after the final payment will lead to a revised final grant amount (see Article 22).

Findings in checks, reviews, audits or investigations during the action implementation may lead to a request for amendment (see Article 39), to change the description of the action set out in Annex 1.

Checks, reviews, audits or investigations that find systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or breach of obligations in any EU grant may also lead to consequences in other EU grants awarded under similar conditions ('extension to other grants').

Moreover, findings arising from an OLAF or EPPO investigation may lead to criminal prosecution under national law.

25.5.2 Extension from other grants

¹⁸ Regulation (EU, Euratom) No 883/2013 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 11 September 2013 concerning investigations conducted by the European Anti-Fraud Office (OLAF) and repealing Regulation (EC) No 1073/1999 of the European Parliament and of the Council and Council Regulation (Euratom) No 1074/1999 (OJ L 248, 18/09/2013, p. 1).

¹⁹ Council Regulation (Euratom, EC) No 2185/96 of 11 November 1996 concerning on-the-spot checks and inspections carried out by the Commission in order to protect the European Communities' financial interests against fraud and other irregularities (OJ L 292, 15/11/1996, p. 2).

Findings of checks, reviews, audits or investigations in other grants may be extended to this grant, if:

- (a) the beneficiary concerned is found, in other EU grants awarded under similar conditions, to have committed systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant and
- (b) those findings are formally notified to the beneficiary concerned — together with the list of grants affected by the findings — within the time-limit for audits set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6).

The granting authority will formally notify the beneficiary concerned of the intention to extend the findings and the list of grants affected.

If the extension concerns **rejections of lump sum contributions**: the notification will include:

- (a) an invitation to submit observations on the list of grants affected by the findings
- (b) the request to submit revised financial statements for all grants affected
- (c) the correction rate for extrapolation, established on the basis of the systemic or recurrent errors, to calculate the amounts to be rejected, if the beneficiary concerned:
 - (i) considers that the submission of revised financial statements is not possible or practicable or
 - (ii) does not submit revised financial statements.

If the extension concerns **grant reductions**: the notification will include:

- (a) an invitation to submit observations on the list of grants affected by the findings and
- (b) the **correction rate for extrapolation**, established on the basis of the systemic or recurrent errors and the principle of proportionality.

The beneficiary concerned has **60 days** from receiving notification to submit observations, revised financial statements or to propose a duly substantiated **alternative correction method/rate**.

On the basis of this, the granting authority will analyse the impact and decide on the implementation (i.e. start rejection or grant reduction procedures, either on the basis of the revised financial statements or the announced/alternative method/rate or a mix of those; see Articles 27 and 28).

25.6 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, lump sum contributions insufficiently substantiated will be ineligible (see Article 6) and will be rejected (see Article 27), and the grant may be reduced (see Article 28).

Such breaches may also lead to other measures described in Chapter 5.

ARTICLE 26 — IMPACT EVALUATIONS

26.1 Impact evaluation

The granting authority may carry out impact evaluations of the action, measured against the objectives and indicators of the EU programme funding the grant.

Such evaluations may be started during implementation of the action and until the time-limit set out in the Data Sheet (see Point 6). They will be formally notified to the coordinator or beneficiaries and will be considered to start on the date of the notification.

If needed, the granting authority may be assisted by independent outside experts.

The coordinator or beneficiaries must provide any information relevant to evaluate the impact of the action, including information in electronic format.

26.2 Consequences of non-compliance

If a beneficiary breaches any of its obligations under this Article, the granting authority may apply the measures described in Chapter 5.

CHAPTER 5 CONSEQUENCES OF NON-COMPLIANCE

SECTION 1 REJECTIONS AND GRANT REDUCTION

ARTICLE 27 — REJECTION OF CONTRIBUTIONS

27.1 Conditions

The granting authority will — at interim payment, final payment or afterwards — reject any lump sum contributions which are ineligible (see Article 6), in particular following checks, reviews, audits or investigations (see Article 25).

The rejection may also be based on the extension of findings from other grants to this grant (see Article 25).

Ineligible lump sum contributions will be rejected.

27.2 Procedure

If the rejection does not lead to a recovery, the granting authority will formally notify the coordinator or beneficiary concerned of the rejection, the amounts and the reasons why. The coordinator or beneficiary concerned may — within 30 days of receiving notification — submit observations if it disagrees with the rejection (payment review procedure).

If the rejection leads to a recovery, the granting authority will follow the contradictory procedure with pre-information letter set out in Article 22.

27.3 Effects

If the granting authority rejects lump sum contributions, it will deduct them from the lump sum contributions declared and then calculate the amount due (and, if needed, make a recovery; see Article 22).

ARTICLE 28 — GRANT REDUCTION

28.1 Conditions

The granting authority may — at beneficiary termination, final payment or afterwards — reduce the grant for a beneficiary, if:

- (a) the beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.), or
- (b) the beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5).

The amount of the reduction will be calculated for each beneficiary concerned and proportionate to the seriousness and the duration of the errors, irregularities or fraud or breach of obligations, by applying an individual reduction rate to their accepted EU contribution.

28.2 Procedure

If the grant reduction does not lead to a recovery, the granting authority will formally notify the coordinator or beneficiary concerned of the reduction, the amount to be reduced and the reasons why. The coordinator or beneficiary concerned may — within 30 days of receiving notification — submit observations if it disagrees with the reduction (payment review procedure).

If the grant reduction leads to a recovery, the granting authority will follow the contradictory procedure with pre-information letter set out in Article 22.

28.3 Effects

If the granting authority reduces the grant, it will deduct the reduction and then calculate the amount due (and, if needed, make a recovery; see Article 22).

SECTION 2 — SUSPENSION AND TERMINATION

ARTICLE 29 — PAYMENT DEADLINE SUSPENSION

29.1 Conditions

The granting authority may — at any moment — suspend the payment deadline if a payment cannot be processed because:

- (a) the required report (see Article 21) has not been submitted or is not complete or additional information is needed
- (b) there are doubts about the amount to be paid (e.g. ongoing extension procedure, queries about eligibility, need for a grant reduction, etc.) and additional checks, reviews, audits or investigations are necessary, or
- (c) there are other issues affecting the EU financial interests.

29.2 Procedure

The granting authority will formally notify the coordinator of the suspension and the reasons why.

The suspension will **take effect** the day the notification is sent.

If the conditions for suspending the payment deadline are no longer met, the suspension will be **lifted** — and the remaining time to pay (see Data Sheet, Point 4.2) will resume.

If the suspension exceeds two months, the coordinator may request the granting authority to confirm if the suspension will continue.

If the payment deadline has been suspended due to the non-compliance of the report and the revised report is not submitted (or was submitted but is also rejected), the granting authority may also terminate the grant or the participation of the coordinator (see Article 32).

ARTICLE 30 — PAYMENT SUSPENSION

30.1 Conditions

The granting authority may — at any moment — suspend payments, in whole or in part for one or more beneficiaries, if:

- (a) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed or is suspected of having committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.), or
- (b) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5).

If payments are suspended for one or more beneficiaries, the granting authority will make partial payment(s) for the part(s) not suspended. If suspension concerns the final payment, the payment (or

recovery) of the remaining amount after suspension is lifted will be considered to be the payment that closes the action.

30.2 Procedure

Before suspending payments, the granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to suspend payments and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If the granting authority does not receive observations or decides to pursue the procedure despite the observations it has received, it will confirm the suspension (**confirmation letter**). Otherwise, it will formally notify that the procedure is discontinued.

At the end of the suspension procedure, the granting authority will also inform the coordinator.

The suspension will **take effect** the day after the confirmation notification is sent.

If the conditions for resuming payments are met, the suspension will be **lifted**. The granting authority will formally notify the beneficiary concerned (and the coordinator) and set the suspension end date.

During the suspension, no prefinancing will be paid to the beneficiaries concerned. For interim payments, the periodic reports for all reporting periods except the last one (see Article 21) must not contain any financial statements from the beneficiary concerned (or its affiliated entities). The coordinator must include them in the next periodic report after the suspension is lifted or — if suspension is not lifted before the end of the action — in the last periodic report.

ARTICLE 31 — GRANT AGREEMENT SUSPENSION

31.1 Consortium-requested GA suspension

31.1.1 Conditions and procedure

The beneficiaries may request the suspension of the grant or any part of it, if exceptional circumstances — in particular *force majeure* (see Article 35) — make implementation impossible or excessively difficult.

The coordinator must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with:

- the reasons why
- the date the suspension takes effect; this date may be before the date of the submission of the amendment request and
- the expected date of resumption.

The suspension will **take effect** on the day specified in the amendment.

Once circumstances allow for implementation to resume, the coordinator must immediately request another **amendment** of the Agreement to set the suspension end date, the resumption date (one day

after suspension end date), extend the duration and make other changes necessary to adapt the action to the new situation (see Article 39) — unless the grant has been terminated (see Article 32). The suspension will be **lifted** with effect from the suspension end date set out in the amendment. This date may be before the date of the submission of the amendment request.

During the suspension, no prefinancing will be paid. Moreover, no work may be done. Ongoing work packages must be interrupted and no new work packages may be started.

31.2 EU-initiated GA suspension

31.2.1 Conditions

The granting authority may suspend the grant or any part of it, if:

- (a) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed or is suspected of having committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.), or
- (b) a beneficiary (or a person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5)
- (c) other:
 - (i) linked action issues: not applicable
 - (ii) the action has lost its scientific or technological relevance, for EIC Accelerator actions: the action has lost its economic relevance, for challenge-based EIC Pathfinder actions and Horizon Europe Missions: the action has lost its relevance as part of the Portfolio for which it has been initially selected

31.2.2 Procedure

Before suspending the grant, the granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the coordinator:

- formally notifying the intention to suspend the grant and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If the granting authority does not receive observations or decides to pursue the procedure despite the

observations it has received, it will confirm the suspension (**confirmation letter**). Otherwise, it will formally notify that the procedure is discontinued.

The suspension will **take effect** the day after the confirmation notification is sent (or on a later date specified in the notification).

Once the conditions for resuming implementation of the action are met, the granting authority will formally notify the coordinator a **lifting of suspension letter**, in which it will set the suspension end date and invite the coordinator to request an amendment of the Agreement to set the resumption date (one day after suspension end date), extend the duration and make other changes necessary to adapt the action to the new situation (see Article 39) — unless the grant has been terminated (see Article 32). The suspension will be **lifted** with effect from the suspension end date set out in the lifting of suspension letter. This date may be before the date on which the letter is sent.

During the suspension, no prefinancing will be paid. Moreover, no work may be done. Ongoing work packages must be interrupted and no new work packages may be started.

The beneficiaries may not claim damages due to suspension by the granting authority (see Article 33).

Grant suspension does not affect the granting authority's right to terminate the grant or a beneficiary (see Article 32) or reduce the grant (see Article 28).

ARTICLE 32 — GRANT AGREEMENT OR BENEFICIARY TERMINATION

32.1 Consortium-requested GA termination

32.1.1 Conditions and procedure

The beneficiaries may request the termination of the grant.

The coordinator must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with:

- the reasons why
- the date the consortium ends work on the action ('end of work date') and
- the date the termination takes effect ('termination date'); this date must be after the date of the submission of the amendment request.

The termination will **take effect** on the termination date specified in the amendment.

If no reasons are given or if the granting authority considers the reasons do not justify termination, it may consider the grant terminated improperly.

32.1.2 Effects

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit a **periodic report** (for the open reporting period until termination).

The granting authority will calculate the final grant amount and final payment on the basis of the report submitted and taking into account the lump sum contributions for activities implemented before

the end of work date (see Article 22). Partial lump sum contributions for work packages that were not completed (e.g. due to technical reasons) may exceptionally be taken into account.

If the granting authority does not receive the report within the deadline, only lump sum contributions which are included in an approved periodic report will be taken into account (no contributions if no periodic report was ever approved).

Improper termination may lead to a grant reduction (see Article 28).

After termination, the beneficiaries' obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

32.2 Consortium-requested beneficiary termination

32.2.1 Conditions and procedure

The coordinator may request the termination of the participation of one or more beneficiaries, on request of the beneficiary concerned or on behalf of the other beneficiaries.

The coordinator must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with:

- the reasons why
- the opinion of the beneficiary concerned (or proof that this opinion has been requested in writing)
- the date the beneficiary ends work on the action ('end of work date')
- the date the termination takes effect ('termination date'); this date must be after the date of the submission of the amendment request.

If the termination concerns the coordinator and is done without its agreement, the amendment request must be submitted by another beneficiary (acting on behalf of the consortium).

The termination will **take effect** on the termination date specified in the amendment.

If no information is given or if the granting authority considers that the reasons do not justify termination, it may consider the beneficiary to have been terminated improperly.

32.2.2 Effects

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit:

- (i) a **report on the distribution of payments** to the beneficiary concerned
- (ii) a **termination report** from the beneficiary concerned, for the open reporting period until termination, containing an overview of the progress of the work
- (iii) a second **request for amendment** (see Article 39) with other amendments needed (e.g. reallocation of the tasks and the estimated budget of the terminated beneficiary; addition of a new beneficiary to replace the terminated beneficiary; change of coordinator, etc.).

The granting authority will calculate the amount due to the beneficiary on the basis of the reports submitted in previous interim payments (i.e. beneficiary's lump sum contributions for completed and approved work packages).

Lump sum contributions for ongoing/not yet completed work packages will have to be included in the periodic report for the next reporting periods when those work packages have been completed.

If the granting authority does not receive the report on the distribution of payments within the deadline, it will consider that:

- the coordinator did not distribute any payment to the beneficiary concerned and that
- the beneficiary concerned must not repay any amount to the coordinator.

If the second request for amendment is accepted by the granting authority, the Agreement is **amended** to introduce the necessary changes (see Article 39).

If the second request for amendment is rejected by the granting authority (because it calls into question the decision awarding the grant or breaches the principle of equal treatment of applicants), the grant may be terminated (see Article 32).

Improper termination may lead to a reduction of the grant (see Article 31) or grant termination (see Article 32).

After termination, the concerned beneficiary's obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

32.3 EU-initiated GA or beneficiary termination

32.3.1 Conditions

The granting authority may terminate the grant or the participation of one or more beneficiaries, if:

- (a) one or more beneficiaries do not accede to the Agreement (see Article 40)
- (b) a change to the action or the legal, financial, technical, organisational or ownership situation of a beneficiary is likely to substantially affect the implementation of the action or calls into question the decision to award the grant (including changes linked to one of the exclusion grounds listed in the declaration of honour)
- (c) following termination of one or more beneficiaries, the necessary changes to the Agreement (and their impact on the action) would call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants
- (d) implementation of the action has become impossible or the changes necessary for its continuation would call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants
- (e) a beneficiary (or person with unlimited liability for its debts) is subject to bankruptcy

proceedings or similar (including insolvency, winding-up, administration by a liquidator or court, arrangement with creditors, suspension of business activities, etc.)

- (f) a beneficiary (or person with unlimited liability for its debts) is in breach of social security or tax obligations
- (g) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has been found guilty of grave professional misconduct
- (h) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed fraud, corruption, or is involved in a criminal organisation, money laundering, terrorism-related crimes (including terrorism financing), child labour or human trafficking
- (i) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) was created under a different jurisdiction with the intent to circumvent fiscal, social or other legal obligations in the country of origin (or created another entity with this purpose)
- (j) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed:
 - (i) substantial errors, irregularities or fraud or
 - (ii) serious breach of obligations under this Agreement or during its award (including improper implementation of the action, non-compliance with the call conditions, submission of false information, failure to provide required information, breach of ethics or security rules (if applicable), failure to cooperate with checks, reviews, audits and investigations, etc.)
- (k) a beneficiary (or person having powers of representation, decision-making or control, or person essential for the award/implementation of the grant) has committed — in other EU grants awarded to it under similar conditions — systemic or recurrent errors, irregularities, fraud or serious breach of obligations that have a material impact on this grant (extension of findings; see Article 25.5)
- (l) despite a specific request by the granting authority, a beneficiary does not request — through the coordinator — an amendment to the Agreement to end the participation of one of its affiliated entities or associated partners that is in one of the situations under points (d), (f), (e), (g), (h), (i) or (j) and to reallocate its tasks, or
- (m) other:
 - (i) linked action issues: not applicable
 - (ii) the action has lost its scientific or technological relevance, for EIC Accelerator actions: the action has lost its economic relevance, for challenge-based EIC Pathfinder actions and Horizon Europe Missions: the action has lost its relevance as part of the Portfolio for which it has been initially selected

32.3.2 Procedure

Before terminating the grant or participation of one or more beneficiaries, the granting authority will send a **pre-information letter** to the coordinator or beneficiary concerned:

- formally notifying the intention to terminate and the reasons why and
- requesting observations within 30 days of receiving notification.

If the granting authority does not receive observations or decides to pursue the procedure despite the observations it has received, it will confirm the termination and the date it will take effect (**confirmation letter**). Otherwise, it will formally notify that the procedure is discontinued.

For beneficiary terminations, the granting authority will — at the end of the procedure — also inform the coordinator.

The termination will **take effect** the day after the confirmation notification is sent (or on a later date specified in the notification; ‘termination date’).

32.3.3 Effects

(a) for **GA termination**:

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit a **periodic report** (for the last open reporting period until termination).

The granting authority will calculate the final grant amount and final payment on the basis of the report submitted and taking into account the lump sum contributions for activities implemented before termination takes effect (see Article 22). Partial lump sum contributions for work packages that were not completed (e.g. due to technical reasons) may exceptionally be taken into account.

If the grant is terminated for breach of the obligation to submit reports, the coordinator may not submit any report after termination.

If the granting authority does not receive the report within the deadline, only lump sum contributions which are included in an approved periodic report will be taken into account (no contributions if no periodic report was ever approved).

Termination does not affect the granting authority’s right to reduce the grant (see Article 28) or to impose administrative sanctions (see Article 34).

The beneficiaries may not claim damages due to termination by the granting authority (see Article 33).

After termination, the beneficiaries’ obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

(b) for **beneficiary termination**:

The coordinator must — within 60 days from when termination takes effect — submit:

- (i) a **report on the distribution of payments** to the beneficiary concerned

- (ii) a **termination report** from the beneficiary concerned, for the open reporting period until termination, containing an overview of the progress of the work
- (iii) a **request for amendment** (see Article 39) with any amendments needed (e.g. reallocation of the tasks and the estimated budget of the terminated beneficiary; addition of a new beneficiary to replace the terminated beneficiary; change of coordinator, etc.).

The granting authority will calculate the amount due to the beneficiary on the basis of the reports submitted in previous interim payments (i.e. beneficiary's lump sum contributions for completed and approved work packages).

Lump sum contributions for ongoing/not yet completed work packages will have to be included in the periodic report for the next reporting periods when those work packages have been completed.

If the granting authority does not receive the report on the distribution of payments within the deadline, it will consider that:

- the coordinator did not distribute any payment to the beneficiary concerned and that
- the beneficiary concerned must not repay any amount to the coordinator.

If the request for amendment is accepted by the granting authority, the Agreement is **amended** to introduce the necessary changes (see Article 39).

If the request for amendment is rejected by the granting authority (because it calls into question the decision awarding the grant or breaches the principle of equal treatment of applicants), the grant may be terminated (see Article 32).

After termination, the concerned beneficiary's obligations (in particular Articles 13 (confidentiality and security), 16 (IPR), 17 (communication, dissemination and visibility), 21 (reporting), 25 (checks, reviews, audits and investigations), 26 (impact evaluation), 27 (rejections), 28 (grant reduction) and 42 (assignment of claims)) continue to apply.

SECTION 3 OTHER CONSEQUENCES: DAMAGES AND ADMINISTRATIVE SANCTIONS

ARTICLE 33 — DAMAGES

33.1 Liability of the granting authority

The granting authority cannot be held liable for any damage caused to the beneficiaries or to third parties as a consequence of the implementation of the Agreement, including for gross negligence.

The granting authority cannot be held liable for any damage caused by any of the beneficiaries or other participants involved in the action, as a consequence of the implementation of the Agreement.

33.2 Liability of the beneficiaries

The beneficiaries must compensate the granting authority for any damage it sustains as a result of the implementation of the action or because the action was not implemented in full compliance with the Agreement, provided that it was caused by gross negligence or wilful act.

The liability does not extend to indirect or consequential losses or similar damage (such as loss of profit, loss of revenue or loss of contracts), provided such damage was not caused by wilful act or by a breach of confidentiality.

ARTICLE 34 — ADMINISTRATIVE SANCTIONS AND OTHER MEASURES

Nothing in this Agreement may be construed as preventing the adoption of administrative sanctions (i.e. exclusion from EU award procedures and/or financial penalties) or other public law measures, in addition or as an alternative to the contractual measures provided under this Agreement (see, for instance, Articles 137 to 148 EU Financial Regulation 2024/2509 and Articles 4 and 7 of Regulation 2988/95²⁰).

SECTION 4 FORCE MAJEURE

ARTICLE 35 — FORCE MAJEURE

A party prevented by force majeure from fulfilling its obligations under the Agreement cannot be considered in breach of them.

‘Force majeure’ means any situation or event that:

- prevents either party from fulfilling their obligations under the Agreement
- was unforeseeable, exceptional situation and beyond the parties’ control
- was not due to error or negligence on their part (or on the part of other participants involved in the action) and
- proves to be inevitable in spite of exercising all due diligence.

Any situation constituting force majeure must be formally notified to the other party without delay, stating the nature, likely duration and foreseeable effects.

The parties must immediately take all the necessary steps to limit any damage due to force majeure and do their best to resume implementation of the action as soon as possible.

CHAPTER 6 FINAL PROVISIONS

ARTICLE 36 — COMMUNICATION BETWEEN THE PARTIES

36.1 Forms and means of communication — Electronic management

EU grants are managed fully electronically through the EU Funding & Tenders Portal (‘Portal’).

²⁰ Council Regulation (EC, Euratom) No 2988/95 of 18 December 1995 on the protection of the European Communities financial interests (OJ L 312, 23.12.1995, p. 1).

All communications must be made electronically through the Portal in accordance with the Portal Terms and Conditions and using the forms and templates provided there (except if explicitly instructed otherwise by the granting authority).

Communications must be made in writing and clearly identify the grant agreement (project number and acronym).

Communications must be made by persons authorised according to the Portal Terms and Conditions. For naming the authorised persons, each beneficiary must have designated — before the signature of this Agreement — a ‘legal entity appointed representative (LEAR)’. The role and tasks of the LEAR are stipulated in their appointment letter (see Portal Terms and Conditions).

If the electronic exchange system is temporarily unavailable, instructions will be given on the Portal.

36.2 Date of communication

The sending date for communications made through the Portal will be the date and time of sending, as indicated by the time logs.

The receiving date for communications made through the Portal will be the date and time the communication is accessed, as indicated by the time logs. Formal notifications that have not been accessed within 10 days after sending, will be considered to have been accessed (see Portal Terms and Conditions).

If a communication is exceptionally made on paper (by e-mail or postal service), general principles apply (i.e. date of sending/receipt). Formal notifications by registered post with proof of delivery will be considered to have been received either on the delivery date registered by the postal service or the deadline for collection at the post office.

If the electronic exchange system is temporarily unavailable, the sending party cannot be considered in breach of its obligation to send a communication within a specified deadline.

36.3 Addresses for communication

The Portal can be accessed via the Europa website.

The address for paper communications to the granting authority (if exceptionally allowed) is the official mailing address indicated on its website.

For beneficiaries, it is the legal address specified in the Portal Participant Register.

ARTICLE 37 — INTERPRETATION OF THE AGREEMENT

The provisions in the Data Sheet take precedence over the rest of the Terms and Conditions of the Agreement.

Annex 5 takes precedence over the Terms and Conditions.

The Terms and Conditions take precedence over the Annexes other than Annex 5.

Annex 2 takes precedence over Annex 1.

ARTICLE 38 — CALCULATION OF PERIODS AND DEADLINES

In accordance with Regulation No 1182/71²¹, periods expressed in days, months or years are calculated from the moment the triggering event occurs.

The day during which that event occurs is not considered as falling within the period.

‘Days’ means calendar days, not working days.

ARTICLE 39 — AMENDMENTS

39.1 Conditions

The Agreement may be amended, unless the amendment entails changes to the Agreement which would call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants.

Amendments may be requested by any of the parties.

39.2 Procedure

The party requesting an amendment must submit a request for amendment signed directly in the Portal Amendment tool.

The coordinator submits and receives requests for amendment on behalf of the beneficiaries (see Annex 3). If a change of coordinator is requested without its agreement, the submission must be done by another beneficiary (acting on behalf of the other beneficiaries).

The request for amendment must include:

- the reasons why
- the appropriate supporting documents and
- for a change of coordinator without its agreement: the opinion of the coordinator (or proof that this opinion has been requested in writing).

The granting authority may request additional information.

If the party receiving the request agrees, it must sign the amendment in the tool within 45 days of receiving notification (or any additional information the granting authority has requested). If it does not agree, it must formally notify its disagreement within the same deadline. The deadline may be extended, if necessary for the assessment of the request. If no notification is received within the deadline, the request is considered to have been rejected.

An amendment **enters into force** on the day of the signature of the receiving party.

An amendment **takes effect** on the date of entry into force or other date specified in the amendment.

²¹ Regulation (EEC, Euratom) No 1182/71 of the Council of 3 June 1971 determining the rules applicable to periods, dates and time-limits (OJ L 124, 8/6/1971, p. 1).

ARTICLE 40 — ACCESSION AND ADDITION OF NEW BENEFICIARIES

40.1 Accession of the beneficiaries mentioned in the Preamble

The beneficiaries which are not coordinator must accede to the grant by signing the accession form (see Annex 3) directly in the Portal Grant Preparation tool, within 30 days after the entry into force of the Agreement (see Article 44).

They will assume the rights and obligations under the Agreement with effect from the date of its entry into force (see Article 44).

If a beneficiary does not accede to the grant within the above deadline, the coordinator must — within 30 days — request an amendment (see Article 39) to terminate the beneficiary and make any changes necessary to ensure proper implementation of the action. This does not affect the granting authority's right to terminate the grant (see Article 32).

40.2 Addition of new beneficiaries

In justified cases, the beneficiaries may request the addition of a new beneficiary.

For this purpose, the coordinator must submit a request for amendment in accordance with Article 39. It must include an accession form (see Annex 3) signed by the new beneficiary directly in the Portal Amendment tool.

New beneficiaries will assume the rights and obligations under the Agreement with effect from the date of their accession specified in the accession form (see Annex 3).

Additions are also possible in mono-beneficiary grants.

ARTICLE 41 — TRANSFER OF THE AGREEMENT

In justified cases, the beneficiary of a mono-beneficiary grant may request the transfer of the grant to a new beneficiary, provided that this would not call into question the decision awarding the grant or breach the principle of equal treatment of applicants.

The beneficiary must submit a request for **amendment** (see Article 39), with

- the reasons why
- the accession form (see Annex 3) signed by the new beneficiary directly in the Portal Amendment tool and
- additional supporting documents (if required by the granting authority).

The new beneficiary will assume the rights and obligations under the Agreement with effect from the date of accession specified in the accession form (see Annex 3).

ARTICLE 42 — ASSIGNMENTS OF CLAIMS FOR PAYMENT AGAINST THE GRANTING AUTHORITY

The beneficiaries may not assign any of their claims for payment against the granting authority to

any third party, except if expressly approved in writing by the granting authority on the basis of a reasoned, written request by the coordinator (on behalf of the beneficiary concerned).

If the granting authority has not accepted the assignment or if the terms of it are not observed, the assignment will have no effect on it.

In no circumstances will an assignment release the beneficiaries from their obligations towards the granting authority.

ARTICLE 43 — APPLICABLE LAW AND SETTLEMENT OF DISPUTES

43.1 Applicable law

The Agreement is governed by the applicable EU law, supplemented if necessary by the law of Belgium.

Special rules may apply for beneficiaries which are international organisations (if any; see Data Sheet, Point 5).

43.2 Dispute settlement

If a dispute concerns the interpretation, application or validity of the Agreement, the parties must bring action before the EU General Court — or, on appeal, the EU Court of Justice — under Article 272 of the Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU).

For non-EU beneficiaries (if any), such disputes must be brought before the courts of Brussels, Belgium — unless an international agreement provides for the enforceability of EU court judgements.

For beneficiaries with arbitration as special dispute settlement forum (if any; see Data Sheet, Point 5), the dispute will — in the absence of an amicable settlement — be settled in accordance with the Rules for Arbitration published on the Portal.

If a dispute concerns administrative sanctions, offsetting or an enforceable decision under Article 299 TFEU (see Articles 22 and 34), the beneficiaries must bring action before the General Court — or, on appeal, the Court of Justice — under Article 263 TFEU.

For grants where the granting authority is an EU executive agency (see Preamble), actions against offsetting and enforceable decisions must be brought against the European Commission (not against the granting authority; see also Article 22).

ARTICLE 44 — ENTRY INTO FORCE

The Agreement will enter into force on the day of signature by the granting authority or the coordinator, depending on which is later.

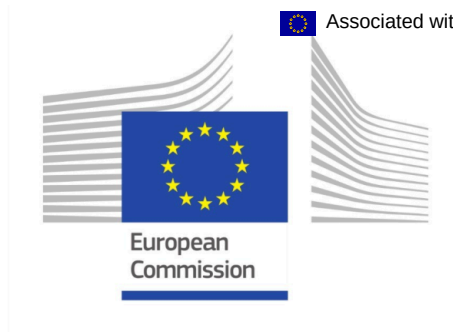
SIGNATURES

For the coordinator

Serena Scarselli with ECAS id nscarsse signed in the Participant Portal on 13/05/2026 at 11:57:52 (transaction id SigId-14095-9y3LjFqO7zyInzvnsD41VzKd8oy9PvpTTPD1qVbBhRoman8NGD86LH3F3h02fLXtVe8b8Lg7MhzaQ72tZ9wv5TO-R2zIpfT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-cfkr3sunfHvKPwzlzT9kvW6ncfRFo4IFXP1gQ2vOO0IUyLlj8yCzyrwABigtzjgqsiQPyKA3cw8Rhmwq3fpzj4M). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.13 11:58:00 CEST

For the granting authority

Signed by Bart VAN CAENEGEM with ECAS id caeneba as an authorised representative on 13-05-2026 19:21:09 (transaction id SigId-17738-mlGv5lqS2Xzrg7eqLEvP3pe74es7ybQtKkVid5RYJrKfwkj06Tfvbd7WXdAQfPYPzjIPyDMGmauIJYT4ztw6xaDG-R2zIpfT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-rwgBADxQbSwPbBTxiOMmzLteHd2sdsZNrPOe78h6l1DzL0j9ihq9dyeIEy6stgUMOh5KB1xLDzlkbbOsoQUhv2G) 2026.05.13 19:21:14 CEST



ANNEX 1



Horizon Europe (HORIZON)

Description of the action (DoA)

Part A

Part B

DESCRIPTION OF THE ACTION (PART A)

COVER PAGE

Part A of the Description of the Action (DoA) must be completed directly on the Portal Grant Preparation screens.

PROJECT	
Grant Preparation (General Information screen) — Enter the info.	
Project number:	101286806
Project name:	Making Sense of EU Enlargement for, with and by Citizens
Project acronym:	CitiSense
Call:	HORIZON-CL2-2025-01
Topic:	HORIZON-CL2-2025-01-DEMOCRACY-03
Type of action:	HORIZON-RIA
Service:	REA/C/01
Project starting date:	fixed date: 1 October 2026
Project duration:	36 months

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List of work packages	5
Staff effort	19
List of deliverables	21
List of milestones (outputs/outcomes)	34
List of critical risks	34
Project reviews	37

PROJECT SUMMARY

Project summary

Grant Preparation (General Information screen) — Provide an overall description of your project (including context and overall objectives, planned activities and main achievements, and expected results and impacts (on target groups, change procedures, capacities, innovation etc)). This summary should give readers a clear idea of what your project is about.

Use the project summary from your proposal.

How can the EU pursue a more effective and resilient enlargement policy by fostering understanding of its security, economic, and societal impacts among citizens? CitiSense – Making Sense of EU Enlargement for, with and by Citizens – addresses this challenge through an innovative threefold approach: "for citizens" by producing clear evidence on the costs and benefits of enlargement and non-enlargement; "with citizens" by systematically analysing public attitudes, perceptions, and concerns; and "by citizens" by creating direct opportunities to participate in debates and co-design solutions. CitiSense's novelty lies in treating citizens not as passive recipients of knowledge but as co-creators of evidence, dialogue, and policy recommendations.

CitiSense brings together 16 consortium partners – universities, think tanks, and CSOs – to investigate the security, economic, and societal dimensions of enlargement in both member states and candidate countries. It builds on previous Horizon projects adapting and scaling up proven formats like Youth Labs, Civil Society Networks, and Expert Hubs. It advances earlier research by contributing new methods and original data. The project employs a multimethod research design. CitiSense will generate a wide range of outputs: multidimensional toolboxes for policymakers, administrators, educators, and civil society, integrating public opinion data, cost–benefit analyses, and foresight scenarios with manuals for participatory mechanisms such as Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies, and Youth Labs. It will also deliver a digital guidebook of “30 FAQs on Enlargement”, a Europe-wide collection of student-authored country reports, educational resources for schools, and multimedia formats (podcasts, Instagram reels, and interactive art exhibition). Together, these outputs provide accessible, user-friendly, and transferable resources that promote transparent communication and inclusive policymaking, and inform public debate on EU enlargement.

LIST OF PARTICIPANTS

PARTICIPANTS

Grant Preparation (Beneficiaries screen) — Enter the info.

Number	Role	Short name	Legal name	Country	PIC
1	COO	EUI	EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE	IT	999902385
2	BEN	UM	UNIVERSITEIT MAASTRICHT	NL	999975911
3	BEN	ICDS	SIHTASUTUS RAHVUSVAHELINE KAITSEUURINGUTE KESKUS	EE	998833251
4	BEN	I.A.I.	ISTITUTO AFFARI INTERNAZIONALI	IT	999694708
5	BEN	CEU	CEU GMBH	AT	901064817
6	BEN	UDE	UNIVERSITAET DUISBURG-ESSEN	DE	999843312
7	BEN	IEP	INSTITUT FUR EUROPAISCHE POLITIK EV	DE	951217309
8	BEN	EPD	EUROPEAN PARTNERSHIP FOR DEMOCRACY	BE	907381457
9	BEN	SU	STOCKHOLMS UNIVERSITET	SE	999885022
10	BEN	TEPSA	TRANS EUROPEAN POLICY STUDIES ASSOCIATION	BE	997222081
11	BEN	CUB	UNIVERZITA KOMENSKEHO V BRATISLAVE	SK	999841566

PARTICIPANTS*Grant Preparation (Beneficiaries screen) — Enter the info.*

Number	Role	Short name	Legal name	Country	PIC
12	BEN	USWPS	UNIWERSYTET SWPS	PL	999884634
13	BEN	ISU	ILIA STATE UNIVERSITY	GE	999612937
14	BEN	KMU	NATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF KYIV-MOHYLA ACADEMY	UA	955856431
15	BEN	IPRE	ASOCIATIA OBSTEASCA INSTITUTUL PENTRU POLITICI SI REFORME EUROPENE	MD	894698610
16	BEN	IDSCS	INSTITUT ZA DEMOKRATIJA SOCIETAS CIVILIS SKOPJE	MK	942478773

LIST OF WORK PACKAGES

Work packages <i>Grant Preparation (Work Packages screen) — Enter the info.</i>						
Work Package No	Work Package name	Lead Beneficiary	Effort (Person-Months)	Start Month	End Month	Deliverables
WP1	Conceptual Framing, Stocktaking, Synthesis	2 - UM	40.90	1	35	D1.1 – Research Report: Conceptual and Methodological Framework D1.2 – Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement D1.3 – Policy Paper: Motivations, Challenges, EU Support D1.4 – Policy Paper: Key Chapter Reform Process D1.5 – Research Report: Synthesis of Key Findings
WP2	Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements	9 - SU	18.00	1	18	D2.1 – Survey and Survey Experiment Data
WP3	Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements – data analyses	9 - SU	16.00	18	34	D3.1 – Research Report: Drivers and Obstacles of Support D3.2 – Two Policy Papers: Motivations and Framing Strategies
WP4	Piloting EU Enlargement: Driven by Citizens, Designed with and for Citizens	8 - EPD	19.50	10	30	D4.1 – Research Report: Solutions Produced by Hackathons and Assemblies D4.2 – Research Report: Feedback from experience sharing with democracy stakeholders D4.3 – Policy Paper: Citizen Engagement Tools
WP5	Security Dimensions of Enlargement	3 - ICDS	30.00	3	24	D5.1 – Policy Paper: Security Costs and Benefits of Enlargement vs. Non-Enlargement

Work packages						
<i>Grant Preparation (Work Packages screen) — Enter the info.</i>						
Work Package No	Work Package name	Lead Beneficiary	Effort (Person-Months)	Start Month	End Month	Deliverables
						D5.2 – Research Report: Security Lessons from Previous Enlargements D5.3 – Policy Paper: Security-related Reforms
WP6	Economic Dimensions of Enlargement	12 - USWPS	30.00	7	24	D6.1 – Policy Paper: Ambiguities in Economic Cost-Benefit Analysis D6.2 – Policy Paper: Patterns of Regional Exclusion and Inclusion D6.3 – Research Report: Popular Perceptions of Socio-Economic Developments D6.4 – Policy Paper: Adaptive Approaches to Economic Integration and Enlargement
WP7	Societal Dimensions of Enlargement	11 - CUB	39.50	4	30	D7.1 – Research Report: Societal Impact of Past Enlargements D7.2 – Policy Paper: Enhancing Social Cohesion in Future Enlargements
WP8	Feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement	7 - IEP	10.50	1	14	D8.1 – Policy Paper: Differentiated (Dis)Integration and the Future of EU Enlargement
WP9	Anticipating Futures of Enlargement	1 - EUI	20.50	6	36	D9.1 – Policy Paper: Alternative Future Scenarios for EU Enlargement
WP10	Toolboxes for Policy-Community and for Citizen Education and Civil Society	6 - UDE	45.50	1	36	D10.1 – Toolbox for Policymakers D10.2 – Toolbox for Education and Civil Society D10.3 – Policy Report: CitiSense Youth Labs

Work packages						
<i>Grant Preparation (Work Packages screen) — Enter the info.</i>						
Work Package No	Work Package name	Lead Beneficiary	Effort (Person-Months)	Start Month	End Month	Deliverables
						D10.4 – Edited Collection of Short Country Reports ('Europe Next')
WP11	Communication, Dissemination, and Exploitation	10 - TEPSA	47.50	1	36	D11.1 – Communications, Dissemination, and Exploitation Plan D11.2 – Recommendations Digest D11.3 – Digest of Public-Oriented Communications Products
WP12	Management and Steering	1 - EUI	23.00	1	36	D12.1 – Consortium Project Plan (incl. Risk Assessment and Ethics) D12.2 – Data Management Plan D12.3 – Reports from Kick-off, Mid-term, and Final Conferences
WP13	Ethics requirements	1 - EUI	0.00	1	36	D13.1 – H - POPD - Requirement No. 1

Work package WP1 – Conceptual Framing, Stocktaking, Synthesis

Work Package Number	WP1	Lead Beneficiary	2 - UM
Work Package Name	Conceptual Framing, Stocktaking, Synthesis		
Start Month	1	End Month	35

Objectives
O1.1 Develop the CitiSense analytical framework for a citizen-centred study of enlargement by, for, and with citizens. O1.2. Compare previous EU enlargement waves to generate evidence-based insights for adaptive enlargement strategies and citizens' support. O1.3 Compare existing and potential CCs using insights and leveraging lessons from past enlargements for the development of future EU policies. O1.4 Synthesise consortium findings on enlargement 'by, for, and with' citizens and develop actionable policy recommendations.

Description
T1.1 Conceptual framing (Lead: UM, EUI; partners: ISU, UKMA, IPRE, IDSCS; M1-M24) Design and elaborate the CitiSense analytical framework based on the logics of enlargement 'for, with and by' citizens, defining analytical categories and benchmarks to guide the project's research activities and ensure internal coherence across all WPs. Review pre-existing conceptual and methodological tools for assessing citizen perceptions of the enlargement process and for measuring the societal costs and benefits of enlargement versus non-enlargement, as well as tools for citizen engagement developed in previous/ ongoing Horizon projects (e.g. EMBRACE, InvigoratEU, SHAPEDEM, EUIDEA, EU3D, InDivEU or DICE) to inform analytical frameworks of WPs 2-9. Validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub. Leads to D1.1. T1.2 Lessons from past enlargements (Lead: EUI, UM; partners: ISU, UKMA, IPRE, IDSCS; M1-M24) Conduct comparative historical research on previous enlargement waves using EU and national archives, public opinion databases already in use, citizen-focused cost/benefit analysis (e.g. economic modelling of wage/employment trends pre/post-accession, social cohesion indicators) and motivation mapping comparing geopolitical, economic, and security drivers. Conceptualise and design new survey and survey experiments on current motivations of EU citizens and CCs members (with WP2 analyse and map different models of staged accession and flexible integration in past and ongoing enlargements (desk research). Leads to D1.2. T1.3 Candidate countries (Lead: UM, EUI; partners: ISU, UKMA, IPRE, IDSCS; M6-M24) Conduct research with partners from Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia, and the WB6 countries to prepare a comparative analysis on the history, political, social and economic situation in (potential) CCs, motivations of these countries to join the EU, costs and benefits of enlargement vs non-enlargement for these countries, obstacles/drivers of reforms (geopolitical & domestic factors, including enlargement fatigue and euroscepticism, role of the EU), views on differentiated enlargement, conditionality & transition periods (drawing on desk research, elite semi-structured interviews, survey data), prepare policy recommendations on how the EU can support the reform process in these countries and/or learn from their existing reforms, and how the EU can better communicate enlargement in (potential) CCs. Leads to D1.3. T1.4. Key reforms (Lead: UM; partners: EUI: ISU; UKMA; IPRE; IDSCS; M6-M24) Conduct joint research with partners from Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia, and the WB6 on a comparative analysis on how the EU can support the reform process of CCs and/or learn from their existing reforms regarding Chapter 10 (Information Society and Media), Chapter 23 (Judiciary and Fundamental Rights), Chapter 24 (Justice Freedom and Security) and Chapter 34 (Institutions) (drawing on desk research and semi-structured interviews), prepare policy recommendations for a flexible and adaptive approach to enlargement, taking into account geopolitical/ security challenges facing CCs. Leads to D1.4. T1.5 Findings and recommendations (Lead: UM, EUI; M22-M35) Integrate research findings from all WPs into a comprehensive synthesis report. This includes analyzing citizen-based challenges to democratisation, rule of law, and EU value alignment in CCs, and translating insights into actionable recommendations for EU and national public authorities. Validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub. Leads to D1.5.

Work package WP2 – Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements

Work Package Number	WP2	Lead Beneficiary	9 - SU
Work Package Name	Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements		
Start Month	1	End Month	18

Objectives
O2.1 Generate theoretical expectations on the predictors of public support for enlargement.
O2.2 Collect data in select EU MS and neighbouring countries.

Description
T2.1 Systematic literature review and survey design (Lead: SU, partners: EUI, IPRE; M1-M6) Theory development will be conducted in close collaboration with WP1, including a review of previous Horizon project findings, ensuring that survey questions help address key research areas of the project (cost-benefit analysis, as well as security, economic, societal, and the rule of law implications of enlargement). The theoretical framework will address how citizens' attitudes about past enlargement affect their opinion on future enlargement, as such, and in the case of individual MS and accession countries. T2.2 Pilot survey (Lead: SU, partner: all; M6- M10) Conduct a pilot survey in select countries to refine questions and translations to national languages and identify potential issues. T2.3 Data collection (Lead: SU; M10- M16) Collect individual-level data (a representative sample of the surveyed counties' populations) using survey and survey experiment methodology. The data collection process will be conducted by employing independent research organisations specializing in opinion polls to administer online surveys, which will be combined in some countries with telephone interviews to improve the representability of the samples (especially, in Eastern Europe). Using sociological companies, we will administer surveys in multiple languages. T2.4 Data cleaning (Lead: SU; M16- M18) Perform data cleaning using statistical software (e.g., Stata, R) to prepare for analysis. Leads to D2.1.

Work package WP3 – Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements – data analyses

Work Package Number	WP3	Lead Beneficiary	9 - SU
Work Package Name	Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements – data analyses		
Start Month	18	End Month	34

Objectives
O3.1 Test theoretical expectations, generating scholarly insights and policy recommendations

Description
T3.1 Data analysis (Lead: SU; partners: EUI, UM, IPRE; M18- M34) Using the data collected, conduct a statistical analysis identifying significant associations between individuals' beliefs and their support for enlargement and assessing how adoption of various communicative strategies affects individuals' support for enlargement. Leads to D3.1 T3.1 Policy recommendations (Lead: SU, IPRE; partner: UM, EUI; M28-M30) Based on the data collected and statistical analysis, generate policy-relevant recommendations for practitioners on how

to effectively communicate enlargement to diverse publics and engage citizens in the process. Validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and Expert Hub. Leads to D3.2.

Work package WP4 – Piloting EU Enlargement: Driven by Citizens, Designed with and for Citizens

Work Package Number	WP4	Lead Beneficiary	8 - EPD
Work Package Name	Piloting EU Enlargement: Driven by Citizens, Designed with and for Citizens		
Start Month	10	End Month	30

Objectives

- O4.1 Design and test innovative digital tools to foster broader citizen participation, especially among younger people, in the EU enlargement process, ensuring informed, transparent, and inclusive discussions.
- O4.2 Increase awareness among citizens in EU MS and CCs about the social, economic, and political consequences of EU enlargement and non-enlargement, to foster citizens' acceptance and strengthen the credibility of the enlargement process.
- O4.3 Demonstrate the use of innovative and digital tools among EU and MS authorities to promote educational opportunities on enlargement through targeted briefings, democracy dialogues, and manuals on interactive participation tools.
- O4.4 Assess the effectiveness of innovative citizen participation tools and build synergies with other EU programs fostering people to people exchanges across the EU MS and CCs.

Description

T4.1 Design and test Democracy Hackathons (Lead: EPD; M10-M28)

Organise 18 hours of fully online discussion in Belgium and France facilitated by a dedicated digital platform, where randomly selected citizens, especially youth are tasked with developing a solution to an identified key challenge identified by WP2 related to social, economic, and political consequence of EU enlargement. The hackathon will include a series of facilitated discussions and involve digital tools including Mentimeter and Kahoot! foster development of solution to the set problem. Both hackathons will be executed by M18, in line with Milestone 3. Leads to D4.1.

T4.2 Design and test Citizen Assemblies (Lead: EPD; M10-M28)

Design a structured democratic process involving 20 citizens in Germany and the Czech Republic selected through sortition to learn about, deliberate on, and make recommendations regarding specific challenges related to EU enlargement, including the use of digital tools (Mentimeter, Kahoot!). Each assembly will focus on one of the most pressing issues identified through public opinion surveys conducted by WP2. To ensure a strong educational component, the CitiSense consortium will engage with and invite representatives from Erasmus+, the European Solidarity Corps, Interreg, or the Civil Society Facility. Depending on the topic of discussion, these representatives, together with CitiSense experts, will provide a topic-specific presentation to kick-start the assembly to ensure informed and evidence-based deliberation. Both assemblies will be executed by M18, in line with Milestone 3. Leads to D4.1.

T4.3 Organisation of four practitioner's briefings (Lead: EPD; M10-M28)

To ensure that the authorities in EU and MS have better understanding of citizen participation tools, organise briefings with officials responsible for the enlargement portfolio in France, Germany, Belgium and Czechia to inform of the outcomes, lessons learned, and recommendations generated by citizens, as well as explain innovative approaches and methodologies for engaging with citizens. Validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub. Leads to D4.2.

T4.4 Organisation of Democracy Dialogue (Lead: EPD; M10-M28)

Organise an off-the-record discussion in Brussels, gathering 30 stakeholders, including a diverse mix of policymakers, civil society representatives, journalists, and researchers. CitiSense consortium members from Moldova, Ukraine, Georgia, and the Western Balkans share insights on citizen participation tools used in CCs in the context of EU enlargement. An EPD representative will share insights from the pilot to ensure mutual learning, experience-sharing and effective communication of recommendations to policymakers. Leads to D4.2.

T4.5 Synthesise lessons from CitiSense pilot initiatives (Lead: EPD; M24-M30)

Assess the effectiveness of various citizen participation tools used in France, Germany, Belgium, and Czechia, along with insights from CCs, focusing on key findings and challenges related to citizen participation in the EU enlargement process, to develop policy recommendations for public authorities. Leads to D4.3.

Work package WP5 – Security Dimensions of Enlargement

Work Package Number	WP5	Lead Beneficiary	3 - ICDS
Work Package Name	Security Dimensions of Enlargement		
Start Month	3	End Month	24

Objectives
O51 Analyse the costs and benefits of enlargement vs non-enlargement with respect to the security dimension for the EU, MS, and CCs. O5.2 Assess and draw thematic lessons from previous EU enlargements (with specific focus on the cases of Estonia and Slovakia), with implications for the security dimension. O5.3 Evaluate the EU's institutional and policy readiness for further enlargement and its ability to address citizens' concerns related to the impact of enlargement on security. O5.4 Synthesise findings into actionable, adaptive policy recommendations for a flexible and adaptive approach to enlargement, responsive to geopolitical dynamics and regional challenges, and responsive to regional and national differences.

Description
T5.1 Cost-benefit analysis (Lead: ICDS; Partners: EUI, UM, IAI, ISU, UKMA, IDSCS; M3-M18) Analyse security-related aspects of current enlargement and non-enlargement scenarios using a qualitative approach including recommendations on how to effectively communicate these costs and benefits (narratives), drawing on the case studies of Georgia, North Macedonia, Ukraine; and Estonia and France. Case selection is based on the following criteria: CCs facing hard security challenge (Ukraine), hybrid security challenge (Georgia), and no direct security challenge (North Macedonia); and EU MS – one representing a Western, older, and influential member (France), and one representing an Eastern, newer, and relatively small member (Estonia). This research involves reviewing policy reports and assessments, and conducting expert interviews, to identify security-related advantages/benefits and disadvantages/challenges. Compare these findings with public attitudes (see WP2) to inform recommendations on effective communication of security narratives in different national contexts, thereby supporting the 'for citizens' logic of CitiSense. Leads to D5.1. T5.2 Lessons from past enlargements (Lead: ISU, Partners: ICDS, EUI, UM, IAI; M3-M18) Analyse the security-related drivers of past enlargements and identify lessons learned, with a focus on citizens' security concerns, by conducting a comparative analysis of accession treaty terms and conditions (particularly those related to security), as well as security concerns of citizens in the context of enlargement, identifying relevant parallels with current CCs. This analysis highlights the cases of Estonia and Slovakia and includes a thorough literature review of academic publications and policy reports, and an investigation into the role of security in shaping public opinion on enlargement – examining how security concerns influenced citizen attitudes. The analysis also integrates insights from previous projects (e.g. EU JOINT, REDEMOS, REUNIR, EMBRACE, InvigoratEU). Leads to D5.2. T5.3 Readiness and reforms (Lead: ISU, Partners: ICDS, UKMA, IDSCS, UM; M6-M22) Analyse security-related reforms in light of differing threat perceptions, security guarantees, and overall EU security. Identify thematic lessons and patterns relevant to current CCs based on a comprehensive review of academic literature and policy assessments and examine how security-related reforms within the EU and the staged integration of CCs into EU security and defence policies can enhance the effectiveness of the enlargement process. This task includes a targeted analysis of the importance of improved institutional readiness to address citizens' security concerns about EU enlargement, thereby supporting the 'for citizens' logic of CitiSense. Leads to D5.3. T5.4 Policy recommendations (Lead: ICDS; Partners: ISU, UKMA, IDSCS, UM; M18-M24) Synthesise findings into actionable, adaptive policy recommendations for future enlargement, responsive to regional and national differences, validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and Expert Hub. Leads to D5.3.

Work package WP6 – Economic Dimensions of Enlargement

Work Package Number	WP6	Lead Beneficiary	12 - USWPS
Work Package Name	Economic Dimensions of Enlargement		

Start Month	7	End Month	24
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Objectives
O6.1 Conduct a comprehensive analysis of the economic costs and benefits of enlargement and non-enlargement for the EU, its MS, and CCs. O6.2 Identify and apply political-economic lessons from previous EU enlargements as they might be relevant for existing CCs. O6.3 Assess the long-term economic impact of EU enlargement and post-accession developments in their relationship with political attitudes and behaviour across MS. O6.4 Examine variation in the governance of EU funds, with special attention to differences within and between MS and CCs at the level of subnational regional development. O6.5 Synthesise findings to provide adaptive, flexible policy recommendations for future enlargement, ensuring responsiveness to regional, national, and EU-level economic challenges and opportunities.

Description
T6.1 Literature review (Lead: CEU, partner: USWPS; M7-M18) Systematic review of the literature review including a review of previous Horizon project findings, with a focus on (a) the limitations on the static quantitative assessments of the economic costs and benefits of enlargement for the EU, MS, and CCs, and (b) economic terms and conditions of accession treaties (e.g., transition periods, funding arrangements, freedom of movement of workers/persons, real-estate acquisition), and (c) comparison of the key elements of the integration strategies during the Southern enlargement, the previous wave of Eastern enlargement and the recent wave. The analysis also integrates insights from previous projects (e.g. REDEMOS, REUNIR, EMBRACE, InvigoratEU). Leads to D6.1. T6.2 Inclusion and exclusion at the regional level (Lead: CEU, partner: USWPS, ISU, UKMA; M13-M24) Analyse regional and subnational variations in the governance of EU funding, with particular attention to Hungary and Poland. Explore patterns of citizen inclusion and exclusion in the EU accession process based on fieldwork (case studies) in two Ukraine regions. Leads to D6.2 T6.3 Perceptions, attitudes, and behaviour (Lead: USWPS, partner: CEU, ISU, UKMA, IPRE; M13-M24) Design a longitudinal and comparative analytical strategy to capture citizens' perceptions of the enlargement process and socio-economic developments in post-accession periods using absolute and relative indicators (growth, decline, stagnation). Analyse long-term post-accession socio-economic developments and their relationship to political attitudes and behaviour, with a focus on Hungary and Poland. Compare absolute and relative socio-economic changes (national/EU averages) and their impact on political divides and attitudes toward EU integration, further supporting the 'with citizens' logic of CitiSense. Leads to D6.3 T6.4 Policy recommendations (Lead: USWPS, partner: CEU, ISU, UKMA; M7-M24) Synthesise findings into actionable, adaptive policy recommendations for future enlargement, responsive to regional and national differences, validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and Expert Hub. Leads to D6.4.

Work package WP7 – Societal Dimensions of Enlargement

Work Package Number	WP7	Lead Beneficiary	11 - CUB
Work Package Name	Societal Dimensions of Enlargement		
Start Month	4	End Month	30

Objectives
O7.1: Provide a historical and comparative analysis of the societal dimension of EU enlargement that can be applied to future enlargements to enhance inclusivity and effectiveness. O7.2 Conduct Cost-Benefit Analysis of enlargement for society both in the EU and in CCs. O7.3: Develop policy recommendations and communication strategies to address societal concerns and improve public understanding, raise societal awareness, and potentially strengthen the consensus on enlargement.

Description

T7.1 Collection of societal lessons (lead: CUB; partners: IAI, CEU, ISU, UKMA, IPRE, IDSCS; M4-M22)

Through a historical-comparative approach grounded in selected case studies from both current and past enlargement rounds, identify similarities and differences in how societies – both within the EU and in CCs – have experienced and responded to enlargement processes. The analysis will go beyond descriptive accounts to examine the underlying motivations, values, and narratives that shape public attitudes. Particular attention will be paid to how these attitudes intersect with issues such as social cohesion, democratic legitimacy, and institutional trust, and how they have shifted over time. By situating societal perspectives within broader historical and political developments, the research will assess how societal factors influence the EU's capacity to function effectively and uphold core values such as democracy and the rule of law. It will also examine how these factors relate to challenges such as democratic backsliding, Euroscepticism, and enlargement fatigue. The analysis also integrates insights from previous projects (e.g. REDEMOS, REUNIR, EMBRACE, InvigoratEU). Leads to D7.1.

T7.2. Cost-benefit analysis of the societal impact of enlargement (Lead: CUB, partners: IAI, CEU; M23-M27)

Conduct a cost-benefit analysis to assess the expected societal impact of enlargement or non-enlargement for the CCs and compare with ex-post cost-benefit analysis on selected EU states to verify the accuracy of the initial predictions and/or to monitor the effects and promote policy learning systematically evaluating outcomes of the accession, whether potentially positive, such as strengthening in institutional capacities, civic engagement and social trust against potential social costs, such as institutional strain, rise of disinformation and disruptions in social cohesion. Quantify all the impacts (direct and indirect) revolving around social aspects of enlargement (e.g., institutional capacities, civic engagement, social trust, disinformation) as costs and benefits during a specific timeframe of the accession process (for CCs) and after accession (for EU countries). Leads to D7.2.

T7.3 Policy recommendations (Lead: IAI; partners: CUB, ISU, UKMA, IPRE, IDSCS; M28-M30)

Undertake a comprehensive analysis of societal factors to formulate practical, evidence-based recommendations on enlargement to inform EU and national policymakers. Focus on designing flexible and adaptive approaches to enlargement that are responsive to societal expectations and concerns based on the case studies and evaluation of effectiveness of flexible approach to institutional integration and their impact on societal readiness. Propose effective communication strategies tailored to different national and regional contexts to raise awareness about the societal implications of enlargement, counter illiberal narratives and Euroscepticism, and strengthen public engagement with the enlargement process. Validate actionable policy recommendations by actively involving the CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub. Leads to D7.2.

Work package WP8 – Feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement

Work Package Number	WP8	Lead Beneficiary	7 - IEP
Work Package Name	Feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement		
Start Month	1	End Month	14

Objectives

O8.1 Inform Scenarios for the future of EU enlargement.

Description**T8.1 Mapping and evaluate existing ideas of EU Enlargement and differentiated integration (lead: IEP; partner: EUI; M1-M12)**

Conduct an expert assessment exercise, based on a state-of-the-art literature review, to evaluate the feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement to inform T7.2's alternative futures scenarios development. This task starts with a three dimensional mapping exercise: first it structures concepts of differentiation, flexibility and differentiated (dis)integration used in academic and political debates according to the effects that they have on European integration and the internal or external dimension they refer to; second, it assesses the different legal forms of differentiation and flexibility within EU law; third, it maps the state of differentiation already existent in European integration interrelating with WPs 4-5-6 to discuss the state of play in security, economy and society. Extending research from previous Horizon projects (e.g. EUIDEA, EU3D, InDivEU or DICE) on differentiated integration, T7.1 will conduct a series of stakeholder interviews to assess a) how the understanding of and perception on differentiated integration have evolved since the EU revitalised its enlargement policy and b) how understandings and perceptions differ between political parties, societal groups as well as MS and CCs. Leads to D8.1.

Work package WP9 – Anticipating Futures of Enlargement

Work Package Number	WP9	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Work Package Name	Anticipating Futures of Enlargement		
Start Month	6	End Month	36

Objectives

O9.1 Develop four alternative scenarios for the future of EU enlargement based on the analysis of global and European trends, strategic uncertainties, actors and systemic constellations, socio-cultural-historical framings and contexts as well as public opinion data (short-term horizons to 2030 and long-term horizons to 2060).

O9.2 Test alternative futures scenarios for EU enlargement through the active involvement of academic experts, practitioners, and citizens to assess their social, cultural, and political acceptability and feasibility.

Description

T9.1 Alternative futures scenarios (lead: EUI; partners: IEP, IPRE; M6-M28)

Identify global and European socio-cultural-historical, technological, environmental, economic and political factors (STEPP) to inform four alternative EU enlargement futures scenarios. These scenarios will tap into projected, plausible, probable, possible, preposterous and preferable spheres to outline future continuity, differentiation, disruption and transformation trajectories of EU enlargement and non-enlargement. Scenario descriptions will summarise different future trajectories for EU enlargement in ten-year intervals until 2060. Leads to D9.1 (Milestone 5).

T9.2 Participatory testing of alternative futures (lead: EUI, partner: IEP; M29-M36).

In line with WP8's Task 8.1, open the research to public scenario testing. Assess the acceptability of the alternative futures scenarios developed in T7.2. First, test the scenarios in an internal workshop involving project partners to gather academic expert feedback. Second, engage external academic experts, from the CitiSense Expert Hub and beyond, practitioners and citizens to foster ownership and involvement in long-term thinking about EU enlargement. For this, WP7 conducts two strategic foresight workshops (one in Berlin and one in Brussels) to test the socio-cultural-political acceptability of the alternative scenarios for future EU enlargements. In these co-creational sessions, diverse groups of actors engaged in EU enlargement-related societal activities and policymaking (i.e., politicians, public officials, civil society organisations & citizens from the IEP's local network, corporate actors) mobilise their expertise to contextualise and prioritise the scenarios based on their institutional practices. The results of this participatory engagement will inform the finalisation of the alternative futures scenarios. Leads to D9.1

Work package WP10 – Toolboxes for Policy-Community and for Citizen Education and Civil Society

Work Package Number	WP10	Lead Beneficiary	6 - UDE
Work Package Name	Toolboxes for Policy-Community and for Citizen Education and Civil Society		
Start Month	1	End Month	36

Objectives

O10.1 Create a toolbox for policymakers at the European, national, and – where applicable – regional level with context-sensitive policy recommendations that will serve as a practical resource for policymakers, providing them with evidence-based strategies, communication tools, and proposals for participatory mechanisms to enhance the effectiveness and public acceptance of the enlargement process.

O10.2 Create a toolbox for civil society and actors in the field of citizenship education (including schoolteachers) with a set of educational tools to learn about the lessons learnt, options, visions and scenarios in view of EU's future enlargement and strengthening defensible young citizens who respect and protect the values of our EU treaty.

O10.3 Involve European youth and citizens to participate in discussions addressing the future of EU enlargement via Youth Labs.

O10.4 Involve pan-European post-graduate students specializing on the future of EU enlargement from the College of Europe.

O10.5 Cooperate with members of the Civil Society Network in co-developing the toolboxes for policymakers and for citizen education and civil society.

Description

T10.1 Toolbox for policymakers (Lead: UDE, UM; partners: EUI, ICDS, IAI, CEU, UDE, EPD, SU, CUB, USWPS, ISU, UKMA, IDSCS; M22-M36)

Co-create tools for policy makers, public administration in MS, CCs and European institutional level to deepen our understanding of the political, social, security and economic consequences of enlargement versus non-enlargement. This toolbox will include a Digital Guidebook ('30 FAQs on Enlargement'). The toolbox will include communication strategies to help policymakers explain the benefits and challenges of enlargement and non-enlargement. It will incorporate insights from the public opinion surveys, as well as the economic, security, and societal analysis to provide policymakers with a nuanced understanding of citizens' perspectives, concerns, and expectations regarding enlargement. The toolbox will include participatory mechanisms and digital tools to offer policymakers innovative ways to involve citizens directly in the enlargement process. Leads to D10.1.

T10.2 Toolbox for civil society and citizenship education (Lead: UDE; partners: all; M22-36)

Co-create teaching resources for schoolteachers and other citizenship education actors to build concrete knowledge on future enlargement. Leads to D10.2.

T10.3 Youth Labs (Lead: UDE, partners: UM, EUI, ICDS, IAI, CEU, EPD, SU, CUB, USWPS, ISU, UKMA, IDSCS; M12- M32)

Organizing and consultation of Youth Labs targeting young European citizens to communicate and test CitiSense research results, as well as co-creating policy recommendations. They take place in cities of our consortium members, which include EU and non-EU capitals in the target regions, and medium-sized cities across Europe. Leads to D10.3.

T10.4. National views (Lead: UDE, UM, partners: EUI, ICDS, IAI, CEU, EPD, SU, CUB, USWPS, ISU, UKMA, IDSCS; M13-M36)

Recruit post-graduate students from the College of Europe to write short country reports ('Europe Next') on a variety of aspects offering national views from EU MS and CCs based on CitiSense newly generated data to understand commonalities and particular differences across Europe. Leads to D10.4.

T10.5 Civil Society Network (Lead: UDE; partners: UM, EUI; M1-M32)

Organise and consult members of the Civil Society Network in co-developing the toolkits for citizen education and civil society (e.g. CSO implementation kit) and schoolteachers (considering specific geographical regional, generational and gender-related features based on research outputs from other WPs). Leads to D10.1 and D10.2.

Work package WP11 – Communication, Dissemination, and Exploitation

Work Package Number	WP11	Lead Beneficiary	10 - TEPSA
Work Package Name	Communication, Dissemination, and Exploitation		
Start Month	1	End Month	36

Objectives

O11.1. Developing and enhancing relationships with key stakeholders to learn from the varied experiences of MS, CCs, policymaking, and research from previous enlargement rounds, and in doing so foster the development of well-informed, effective, and innovative EU enlargement policymaking.

O11.2. Fostering broad societal awareness of EU enlargement, its process, consequences, and the costs of non-enlargement, by informing citizens specifically about the benefits of EU enlargement while addressing key concerns identified in public opinion research (WP2) and pilot studies (WP4) and involving them in transparent communicative processes. WP11 applies a segmented approach, tailoring communication to MS, CCs, and potential CCs, and differentiating between policymakers, administrations, CSOs, youth, and media audiences.

Description

T11.1 External communication (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M1-M36)

Establish and maintain external and internal communication structures. The project's external communications, managed by the Steering Group, will operate via a website and on social media within a consistent visual identity. Project

researchers will be trained in strategic communication, and innovative tools will be systematically integrated into the project's functioning. Leads to D11.1.

T11.2 EU Enlargement Expert Hub (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M1-M36)

Continue and widen TEPSA's active EU Enlargement Expert Hub. This already-existing core group of high-level policymakers will offer a forum for structured dialogue with researchers and be enriched with new members. A biannual EU Enlargement Observatory as well as a mailing list will act as forums for multi-directional exchanges on project results. Six closed-door meetings in Brussels will gather this group to discuss results under the Chatham House rule and build relationships.

T11.3 Public panel discussions (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M18-M36)

Organise two panel discussions at TEPSA Pre-Presidency Conferences ahead of new rotating presidencies of the Council of the EU. Three online public panel discussions gathering sister projects to develop mutual understandings, with a specific individual focus on democracy, rule of law, and governance.

T11.4 Targeted training activities. (Lead: TEPSA; M18-M36)

Organise a four-day seminar in Brussels gathering 15 early-career civil servants and researchers and 15 representatives of Local and Regional Authorities from EU and CCs. Social and intercultural learning practices will be foregrounded in the implementation of both trainings to ensure the sustainable creation of knowledge multipliers.

T11.5 Policy briefs (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M1-M36)

Assemble and publish a series of policy briefs building on the discussions taking place within each closed-door meeting. Leads to D11.2.

T11.6 National briefings (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M1-M36)

Coordinate decentralised briefings with national policymakers organised by each consortium partner in their national contexts to discuss policy recommendations.

T11.7 Major project conferences (Lead: TEPSA; M16-M36)

Organise a Mid-term conference (in Florence or Georgia) and a Final Conference in Brussels providing consortium members with platforms to discuss preliminary findings and final recommendation for policymakers from EU and CCs, as well as with sister projects, in light of developments in EU enlargement.

T11.8 Infographics and animations (Lead: TEPSA; Infographics: M1-1M8; Animations: M19-M36)

Design a series of infographics communicating the benefits and costs of EU enlargement/non-enlargement for citizens and another showcasing the results of the public opinion survey. Publish six animated videos communicating project findings, via the TEPSA YouTube Channel and Instagram Reels. Leads to D11.3.

T11.9 Podcasts (Lead: TEPSA; M1-M18)

Publish six podcast discussions with researchers and policymakers on the security, societal, and economic implications of EU enlargement. Leads to D11.3.

T11.10 Traditional media (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M1-M36)

Coordinate outreach to traditional media, including the Publication of op-eds by project researchers in leading EU and/or national legacy media outlets. Leads to D11.3.

T11.11 Social media survey (Lead: TEPSA; M1-M4)

Launch a social media survey conducted online to critically engage a broad audience in questions of EU enlargement. This will provide policymakers with a digest of expert lessons learned from past enlargement rounds, as well as top priorities for future enlargement.

T11.12 Video engagement (Lead: TEPSA; partners: all; M1-M18)

Launch a series of short participatory videos giving citizens the opportunity to ask questions directly to project researchers. Leads to D11.3.

T11.13 Art exhibition (Lead UM; M12-M32)

Stage and curate a Citizens' Art Exhibition in Maastricht, inviting the general public to display their artworks on the theme of 'Framing an EU with 30+ Members', including an interactive workshop. Leads to D11.3.

T11.14 Dissemination (Lead: TEPSA; M1-M36)

Systematically disseminate project outputs to research institutes in all EU MS and CCs. Leads to D11.3.

Work package WP12 – Management and Steering

Work Package Number	WP12	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Work Package Name	Management and Steering		
Start Month	1	End Month	36

Objectives
O12.1 Ensure the overall administrative, legal and financial management of the consortium's activities. O12.2 Plan and run project governance meetings and conferences; record decisions and actions. O12.3 Coordinate external advisory input to access project outputs and progress. O12.4 Ensure scientific coordination, cross-WP consistency of concepts, methods and outputs, and overall scientific quality. O12.5 Monitor ethics compliance and implement the Data Management Plan and open-science practices. O12.6 Facilitate collaboration and knowledge exchange with sister projects funded under the same/related calls. O12.7 Promote gender equality and diversity in governance, participation, research content and project monitoring, aligned with partners' Gender Equality Plans (GEPs) and Horizon Europe gender objectives.
Description
T12.1 Manage financial and administrative activities (Lead: EUI, partners: all; M1-M36) Manage the daily operations of the Consortium including planning and monitoring budget expenses; managing financial records; coordinating cost claim submissions; checking individual claims; preparing consolidated cost statements; monitoring and following up on payments; and preparing payment summaries and overviews. Manage contracts and legal issues, including IPR-related actions and contract amendments; oversee administrative and financial interactions with the European Commission. Deliver a comprehensive Consortium Project Plan (incl. Risk Assessment and Ethics) detailing roles, procedures, communication flows, quality assurance, and mitigation strategies. Align project-level practices with the Gender Equality Plans of consortium partners. Leads to D12.1. T12.2 Data management and Ethics (Lead: EUI, partners: all; M1-M36) Prepare the Data Management Plan (DMP) at start up, update it regularly and deliver as scheduled. Apply FAIR and Open Access principles while complying with GDPR and ethics requirements. Define for each dataset: purpose, ownership, consent, anonymisation/pseudonymisation, access level (public/restricted) and retention/archiving after the project. Prepare templates (consent, information sheets, data logs), maintain a data/ethics register, and obtain any required approvals. Provide guidance and reminders to WP leads; coordinate with T12.4 (consistency checks) and T12.3 (reporting). Leads to D12.2. T12.3 Coordinate project governance and progress (Lead: EUI; partners: all; M1-36) Lead overall project management, monitor progress, and reporting: Periodic & final technical reports (compilation, formatting, submission) and continuous reporting (deliverables, milestones, risks) in the Portal. Deliverable submissions and review management (agenda, evidence packs, responses to review comments). Amendments and ethics/data compliance in coordination with T12.2 and T12.4. Financial reporting coordination (partner inputs, validation, consolidation), timelines, and reminders. Monitor and report on gender balance in leadership, teams, workshops, and panels. Implement risk management and remedial measures. Liaise with the European Commission and establish formal links with sister projects. Organise the Kick-off conference, alongside all other internal meetings, including the cross-WP workshops (M18, M24, M36), report on all three conferences and internal meetings. Leads to D12.3. T12.4 Ensure scientific quality and integration (Lead: UM; partners: all; M1-36) Closely monitor the progress on research, milestones and deliverables for all WPs, ensuring quality control, and making sure that all Commission requirements are respected and implemented. Ensure that all work packages use consistent concepts, clear methods, and common terminology, and that outputs fit together. We will: Hold a coordination check-in with WP leads at the kick-off, mid-term and final conferences to check consistency of concepts, clarity of methods, attention to gender/ethics, readability for non-experts, and correct use of agreed terms; track issues in a simple action log until they are resolved; work with T10.2 so that data, documents and materials are shared as promised in the DMP; bring key points to the Steering Committee and reflect Advisory Board comments where relevant; add a brief quality note to each submitted deliverable and include summaries in project reports (D12.3). T12.5 Steering Committee (SC) and scientific leadership (Lead: UM, EUI; partners: all; M1-36) Organise the SC (composed of the Coordinator, Scientific Lead and all Work Package Leads). Coordinate activities across WPs, set scientific priorities; validate milestones; track risks; provide inputs (text, figures, decisions) for reports in T12.3; and ensure timely contributions from WP leads. T12.6 Guide Advisory Board (AB) and Civil Society Network (CSN) engagement (Lead: EUI, UM; M1-36) Establish AB and CSN liaison (M1) with a short Terms of Reference (roles, confidentiality, conflict-of-interest). Hold three structured consultations (online) (M3, M18, M30) plus light quarterly updates. Circulate 2-page briefs two weeks in advance; collect written comments within two weeks; log actions and responses. The AB and CSN review key outputs, assess scientific quality (AB) and policy relevance, validate recommendations for policymakers and stakeholders (MS/CC/potential CC), and advise on translating research into practical toolboxes and messages.

Work package WP13 – Ethics requirements

Work Package Number	WP13	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Work Package Name	Ethics requirements		
Start Month	1	End Month	36

Objectives
The objective is to ensure compliance with the 'ethics requirements' set out in this work package.

Description
This work package sets out the 'ethics requirements' that the project must comply with.

STAFF EFFORT

Staff effort per participant <i>Grant Preparation (Work packages - Effort screen) — Enter the info.</i>											
Participant	WP1	WP2	WP3	WP4	WP5	WP6	WP7	WP8	WP9	WP10	Total Person-Months
1 - EUI	17.00	0.50	1.00		4.00			1.00	15.00	2.00	57.00
2 - UM	16.90	0.50	0.50		2.00					10.00	35.90
3 - ICDS		1.00			13.00					1.00	16.00
4 - I.A.I.		1.00			2.00		15.00			1.00	20.00
5 - CEU						12.50	1.00			0.50	15.00
6 - UDE										23.00	24.00
7 - IEP								9.00	5.00		15.00
8 - EPD				19.50						0.50	21.00
9 - SU		12.00	13.50							0.50	27.00
10 - TEP SA											31.00
11 - CUB		1.00					16.00			1.00	19.00
12 - USWPS		1.00				10.00				1.00	13.00
13 - ISU	3.00				3.00	3.00	2.00			1.00	15.00
14 - KMU	2.00				3.00	3.00	1.00			1.00	12.00
15 - IPRE	1.00	1.00	1.00			1.50	1.50	0.50	0.50	1.00	9.00
16 - IDSCS	1.00				3.00		3.00			2.00	11.00
Total Person-Months	40.90	18.00	16.00	19.50	30.00	30.00	39.50	10.50	20.50	45.50	340.90

Staff effort per participant <i>Grant Preparation (Work packages - Effort screen) — Enter the info.</i>				
Participant	WP11	WP12	WP13	Total Person-Months
1 - EUI	4.50	12.00		57.00
2 - UM	5.00	1.00		35.90
3 - ICDS	0.50	0.50		16.00
4 - I.A.I.	0.50	0.50		20.00
5 - CEU	0.50	0.50		15.00
6 - UDE	0.50	0.50		24.00
7 - IEP	0.50	0.50		15.00
8 - EPD	0.50	0.50		21.00
9 - SU	0.50	0.50		27.00
10 - TEPSA	30.00	1.00		31.00
11 - CUB	0.50	0.50		19.00
12 - USWPS	0.50	0.50		13.00
13 - ISU	1.00	2.00		15.00
14 - KMU	1.00	1.00		12.00
15 - IPRE	0.50	0.50		9.00
16 - IDSCS	1.00	1.00		11.00
Total Person-Months	47.50	23.00	0.00	340.90

LIST OF DELIVERABLES

Deliverables <i>Grant Preparation (Deliverables screen) — Enter the info.</i> <i>The labels used mean:</i> <i>Public — fully open ( automatically posted online)</i> <i>Sensitive — limited under the conditions of the Grant Agreement</i> <i>EU classified —RESTREINT-UE/EU-RESTRICTED, CONFIDENTIEL-UE/EU-CONFIDENTIAL, SECRET-UE/EU-SECRET under Decision 2015/444</i>						
Deliverable No	Deliverable Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Type	Dissemination Level	Due Date (month)
D1.1	Research Report: Conceptual and Methodological Framework	WP1	2 - UM	R — Document, report	PU - Public	6
D1.2	Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement	WP1	1 - EUI	DATA — data sets, microdata, etc	PU - Public	24
D1.3	Policy Paper: Motivations, Challenges, EU Support	WP1	2 - UM	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D1.4	Policy Paper: Key Chapter Reform Process	WP1	2 - UM	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D1.5	Research Report: Synthesis of Key Findings	WP1	2 - UM	R — Document, report	PU - Public	35
D2.1	Survey and Survey Experiment Data	WP2	9 - SU	DATA — data sets, microdata, etc	PU - Public	18
D3.1	Research Report: Drivers and Obstacles of Support	WP3	9 - SU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	34
D3.2	Two Policy Papers: Motivations and Framing Strategies	WP3	9 - SU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	30
D4.1	Research Report: Solutions Produced by Hackathons and Assemblies	WP4	8 - EPD	R — Document, report	PU - Public	28
D4.2	Research Report: Feedback from experience sharing with democracy stakeholders	WP4	8 - EPD	R — Document, report	PU - Public	28

Deliverables

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Deliverable No	Deliverable Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Type	Dissemination Level	Due Date (month)
D4.3	Policy Paper: Citizen Engagement Tools	WP4	8 - EPD	R — Document, report	PU - Public	30
D5.1	Policy Paper: Security Costs and Benefits of Enlargement vs. Non-Enlargement	WP5	3 - ICDS	R — Document, report	PU - Public	18
D5.2	Research Report: Security Lessons from Previous Enlargements	WP5	3 - ICDS	R — Document, report	PU - Public	22
D5.3	Policy Paper: Security-related Reforms	WP5	3 - ICDS	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D6.1	Policy Paper: Ambiguities in Economic Cost-Benefit Analysis	WP6	5 - CEU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D6.2	Policy Paper: Patterns of Regional Exclusion and Inclusion	WP6	12 - USWPS	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D6.3	Research Report: Popular Perceptions of Socio-Economic Developments	WP6	12 - USWPS	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D6.4	Policy Paper: Adaptive Approaches to Economic Integration and Enlargement	WP6	5 - CEU	R — Document, report	PU - Public	24
D7.1	Research Report: Societal Impact of Past Enlargements	WP7	11 - CUB	R — Document, report	PU - Public	22
D7.2	Policy Paper: Enhancing Social Cohesion in Future Enlargements	WP7	4 - I.A.I.	R — Document, report	PU - Public	30
D8.1	Policy Paper: Differentiated (Dis)Integration and the Future of EU Enlargement	WP8	7 - IEP	R — Document, report	PU - Public	12

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Deliverable No	Deliverable Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Type	Dissemination Level	Due Date (month)
D9.1	Policy Paper: Alternative Future Scenarios for EU Enlargement	WP9	1 - EUI	R — Document, report	PU - Public	28
D10.1	Toolbox for Policymakers	WP10	2 - UM	DEM — Demonstrator, pilot, prototype	PU - Public	32
D10.2	Toolbox for Education and Civil Society	WP10	6 - UDE	DEM — Demonstrator, pilot, prototype	PU - Public	36
D10.3	Policy Report: CitiSense Youth Labs	WP10	6 - UDE	R — Document, report	PU - Public	32
D10.4	Edited Collection of Short Country Reports ('Europe Next')	WP10	6 - UDE	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D11.1	Communications, Dissemination, and Exploitation Plan	WP11	10 - TEPSA	R — Document, report	SEN - Sensitive	4
D11.2	Recommendations Digest	WP11	10 - TEPSA	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D11.3	Digest of Public-Oriented Communications Products	WP11	10 - TEPSA	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36
D12.1	Consortium Project Plan (incl. Risk Assessment and Ethics)	WP12	1 - EUI	OTHER	SEN - Sensitive	6
D12.2	Data Management Plan	WP12	1 - EUI	DMP — Data Management Plan	SEN - Sensitive	6
D12.3	Reports from Kick-off, Mid-term, and Final Conferences	WP12	1 - EUI	R — Document, report	PU - Public	36

Deliverables

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Deliverable No	Deliverable Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Type	Dissemination Level	Due Date (month)
D13.1	H - POPD - Requirement No. 1	WP13	1 - EUI	ETHICS	SEN - Sensitive	18

Deliverable D1.1 – Research Report: Conceptual and Methodological Framework

Deliverable Number	D1.1	Lead Beneficiary	2 - UM
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Conceptual and Methodological Framework		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP1

Description
Original work and review of existing methodologies to serve as basis for empirical analysis in WP2-7.

Deliverable D1.2 – Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement

Deliverable Number	D1.2	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Deliverable Name	Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement		
Type	DATA — data sets, microdata, etc	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP1

Description
Map of security drivers, economic interdependencies, and public sentiment across CCs.

Deliverable D1.3 – Policy Paper: Motivations, Challenges, EU Support

Deliverable Number	D1.3	Lead Beneficiary	2 - UM
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Motivations, Challenges, EU Support		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP1

Description
Analyses motivations, challenges, and role of EU support in candidates' path to membership.

Deliverable D1.4 – Policy Paper: Key Chapter Reform Process

Deliverable Number	D1.4	Lead Beneficiary	2 - UM
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Key Chapter Reform Process		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP1

Description
Examines reform process in CCs regarding key acquis chapters and EU response.

Deliverable D1.5 – Research Report: Synthesis of Key Findings

Deliverable Number	D1.5	Lead Beneficiary	2 - UM
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Synthesis of Key Findings		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	35	Work Package No	WP1

Description
Integrates findings from all WPs to make recommendations for policymakers at all levels.

Deliverable D2.1 – Survey and Survey Experiment Data

Deliverable Number	D2.1	Lead Beneficiary	9 - SU
Deliverable Name	Survey and Survey Experiment Data		
Type	DATA — data sets, microdata, etc	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP2

Description
Data from select EU and CCs

Deliverable D3.1 – Research Report: Drivers and Obstacles of Support

Deliverable Number	D3.1	Lead Beneficiary	9 - SU
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Drivers and Obstacles of Support		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	34	Work Package No	WP3

Description
Examines drivers and obstacles to support to explore influence of different frames for communication.

Deliverable D3.2 – Two Policy Papers: Motivations and Framing Strategies

Deliverable Number	D3.2	Lead Beneficiary	9 - SU
Deliverable Name	Two Policy Papers: Motivations and Framing Strategies		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	30	Work Package No	WP3

Description
Develops strategies to deploy different communicative frames in different national contexts.

Deliverable D4.1 – Research Report: Solutions Produced by Hackathons and Assemblies

Deliverable Number	D4.1	Lead Beneficiary	8 - EPD
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Solutions Produced by Hackathons and Assemblies		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	28	Work Package No	WP4

Description
Highlights challenges and solutions identified through popular participatory co-creation.

Deliverable D4.2 – Research Report: Feedback from experience sharing with democracy stakeholders

Deliverable Number	D4.2	Lead Beneficiary	8 - EPD
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Feedback from experience sharing with democracy stakeholders		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	28	Work Package No	WP4

Description
Reports lessons learned and recommendations from the Practitioner's Briefings and Democracy Dialogue

Deliverable D4.3 – Policy Paper: Citizen Engagement Tools

Deliverable Number	D4.3	Lead Beneficiary	8 - EPD
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Citizen Engagement Tools		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	30	Work Package No	WP4

Description
Identifies lessons and challenges from citizen pilots and makes policy recommendations.

Deliverable D5.1 – Policy Paper: Security Costs and Benefits of Enlargement vs. Non-Enlargement

Deliverable Number	D5.1	Lead Beneficiary	3 - ICDS
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Security Costs and Benefits of Enlargement vs. Non-Enlargement		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP5

Description
Provides empirical analysis to support tailored communication strategies on security issues based on analysis of five countries

Deliverable D5.2 – Research Report: Security Lessons from Previous Enlargements

Deliverable Number	D5.2	Lead Beneficiary	3 - ICDS
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Security Lessons from Previous Enlargements		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	22	Work Package No	WP5

Description
Draws upon previous enlargements to identify similarities and differences with current candidates.

Deliverable D5.3 – Policy Paper: Security-related Reforms

Deliverable Number	D5.3	Lead Beneficiary	3 - ICDS
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Security-related Reforms		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP5

Description
Focuses on role and prospect for institutional reform.

Deliverable D6.1 – Policy Paper: Ambiguities in Economic Cost-Benefit Analysis

Deliverable Number	D6.1	Lead Beneficiary	5 - CEU
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Ambiguities in Economic Cost-Benefit Analysis		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP6

Description
Analyses how the governance of enlargement can alter costs and benefits to make recommendations.

Deliverable D6.2 – Policy Paper: Patterns of Regional Exclusion and Inclusion

Deliverable Number	D6.2	Lead Beneficiary	12 - USWPS
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Patterns of Regional Exclusion and Inclusion		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP6

Description
Compares current with previous enlargements to focus on regional economic impact.

Deliverable D6.3 – Research Report: Popular Perceptions of Socio-Economic Developments

Deliverable Number	D6.3	Lead Beneficiary	12 - USWPS
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Popular Perceptions of Socio-Economic Developments		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP6

Description
Uses examples from Hungary and Poland to examine how attitudes relate to economic performance.

Deliverable D6.4 – Policy Paper: Adaptive Approaches to Economic Integration and Enlargement

Deliverable Number	D6.4	Lead Beneficiary	5 - CEU
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Adaptive Approaches to Economic Integration and Enlargement		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	24	Work Package No	WP6

Description
Provides actionable economic recommendations for future enlargement responsive to regional and national differences

Deliverable D7.1 – Research Report: Societal Impact of Past Enlargements

Deliverable Number	D7.1	Lead Beneficiary	11 - CUB
Deliverable Name	Research Report: Societal Impact of Past Enlargements		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	22	Work Package No	WP7

Description
Uses four case countries to analyse the social impact of enlargement under different national conditions.

Deliverable D7.2 – Policy Paper: Enhancing Social Cohesion in Future Enlargements

Deliverable Number	D7.2	Lead Beneficiary	4 - I.A.I.
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Enhancing Social Cohesion in Future Enlargements		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	30	Work Package No	WP7

Description
Provides actionable recommendations for stakeholders at all levels to mitigate social impact.

Deliverable D8.1 – Policy Paper: Differentiated (Dis)Integration and the Future of EU Enlargement

Deliverable Number	D8.1	Lead Beneficiary	7 - IEP
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Differentiated (Dis)Integration and the Future of EU Enlargement		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	12	Work Package No	WP8

Description
Analyses the evolution of proposals and support for differentiated integration providing a comprehensive assessment of prospects for the coming enlargement.

Deliverable D9.1 – Policy Paper: Alternative Future Scenarios for EU Enlargement

Deliverable Number	D9.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Deliverable Name	Policy Paper: Alternative Future Scenarios for EU Enlargement		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	28	Work Package No	WP9

Description
Develops plausible future trajectories for enlargement for participatory testing and engagement.

Deliverable D10.1 – Toolbox for Policymakers

Deliverable Number	D10.1	Lead Beneficiary	2 - UM
Deliverable Name	Toolbox for Policymakers		
Type	DEM — Demonstrator, pilot, prototype	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	32	Work Package No	WP10

Description
Offers evidence-based, actionable policy recommendations, communication materials and strategies, including participatory mechanisms.

Deliverable D10.2 – Toolbox for Education and Civil Society

Deliverable Number	D10.2	Lead Beneficiary	6 - UDE
Deliverable Name	Toolbox for Education and Civil Society		
Type	DEM — Demonstrator, pilot, prototype	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP10

Description

Teaching materials for schoolteachers and other actors in education to foster informed debate.

Deliverable D10.3 – Policy Report: CitiSense Youth Labs

Deliverable Number	D10.3	Lead Beneficiary	6 - UDE
Deliverable Name	Policy Report: CitiSense Youth Labs		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	32	Work Package No	WP10

Description

Synthesises recommendations from Youth Labs.

Deliverable D10.4 – Edited Collection of Short Country Reports (‘Europe Next’)

Deliverable Number	D10.4	Lead Beneficiary	6 - UDE
Deliverable Name	Edited Collection of Short Country Reports (‘Europe Next’)		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP10

Description

Reports by post-graduate students from the College of Europe (et al.) reflecting national perspectives.

Deliverable D11.1 – Communications, Dissemination, and Exploitation Plan

Deliverable Number	D11.1	Lead Beneficiary	10 - TEPSA
Deliverable Name	Communications, Dissemination, and Exploitation Plan		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	4	Work Package No	WP11

Description

CDE plan including key performance indicators.

Deliverable D11.2 – Recommendations Digest

Deliverable Number	D11.2	Lead Beneficiary	10 - TEPSA
Deliverable Name	Recommendations Digest		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP11

Description

Brings together recommendations from all policy papers produced within the consortium

Deliverable D11.3 – Digest of Public-Oriented Communications Products

Deliverable Number	D11.3	Lead Beneficiary	10 - TEPSA
Deliverable Name	Digest of Public-Oriented Communications Products		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP11

Description
Surveys public-oriented communications products from CitiSense to compare with sister projects.

Deliverable D12.1 – Consortium Project Plan (incl. Risk Assessment and Ethics)

Deliverable Number	D12.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Deliverable Name	Consortium Project Plan (incl. Risk Assessment and Ethics)		
Type	OTHER	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP12

Description
Outlines procedures, structure, risk management, quality control, gender and ethics.

Deliverable D12.2 – Data Management Plan

Deliverable Number	D12.2	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Deliverable Name	Data Management Plan		
Type	DMP — Data Management Plan	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	6	Work Package No	WP12

Description
Follows principles of Open Access; ensures protection of personal data and privacy issues.

Deliverable D12.3 – Reports from Kick-off, Mid-term, and Final Conferences

Deliverable Number	D12.3	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Deliverable Name	Reports from Kick-off, Mid-term, and Final Conferences		
Type	R — Document, report	Dissemination Level	PU - Public
Due Date (month)	36	Work Package No	WP12

Description
Evaluate progress of WPs, scientific integration, gender, ethics, and output quality.

Deliverable D13.1 – H - POPD - Requirement No. 1

Deliverable Number	D13.1	Lead Beneficiary	1 - EUI
Deliverable Name	H - POPD - Requirement No. 1		
Type	ETHICS	Dissemination Level	SEN - Sensitive
Due Date (month)	18	Work Package No	WP13

Description
Ethics report including necessary ethics approvals and ethics compliance for the project to be provided for the ethics check recommended in month 18 (as requested in the ethics screening). This is necessary because the proposal will gather high number of personal data and does not provide information regarding the procedure of appointing the Data Protection Officer nor its embedment in the project, which are relevant factors to ensure GDPR conformity and common procedures for data security in the partnership with 16 beneficiaries and a large geographical scope.

LIST OF MILESTONES

Milestones					
<i>Grant Preparation (Milestones screen) — Enter the info.</i>					
Milestone No	Milestone Name	Work Package No	Lead Beneficiary	Means of Verification	Due Date (month)
1	CitiSense Website Online	WP1, WP11	1 - EUI	Live website with active link	1
2	Kick-off Conference (Florence)	WP12	1 - EUI	Conference held; report published and shared with consortium and EC.	3
3	Completion of All Four Pilots (2xHackathons & 2xCitizen Assemblies)	WP4	1 - EUI	Execution of all four pilots completed by M18.	18
4	Mid-term Conference (Florence or Tblisi)	WP12, WP11	1 - EUI	Conference held; mid-term report and recommendations published.	18
5	Policy Paper: Alternative Future Scenarios for EU Enlargement	WP9	1 - EUI	Policy Paper delivered (D7.2).	28
6	Final Conference (Brussels)	WP12, WP11	1 - EUI	Conference held; final policy recommendation and toolkits presented; final recommendation delivered to EC and stakeholders	36

LIST OF CRITICAL RISKS

Critical risks & risk management strategy			
<i>Grant Preparation (Critical Risks screen) — Enter the info.</i>			
Risk number	Description	Work Package No(s)	Proposed Mitigation Measures
1	State of war or escalation of conflict in territory	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Integrate contingency planning and alternative data collection methods into the Data Management Plan; shift surveys online or replace with expert interviews if fieldwork

Critical risks & risk management strategy <i>Grant Preparation (Critical Risks screen) — Enter the info.</i>			
Risk number	Description	Work Package No(s)	Proposed Mitigation Measures
	of consortium members (e.g., Georgia, Moldova, Ukraine)		is unsafe; conduct research only in areas designated as safe by national authorities.
2	Withdrawal or bankruptcy of a consortium partner	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Mitigate through provisions in the Consortium Agreement; prepare an exit strategy: seek a new partner, redistribute roles to remaining partners, or hire key personnel to maintain capacity
3	Risks to safety of interview partners, local partners, and researchers in the field	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Develop a field manual with security protocols and scenario-specific mitigation measures; ensure anonymity and protection of interviewees; postpone or cancel high-risk activities; exclude sensitive data if necessary
4	Lack of common objective among consortium partners	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Maintain shared goals through early consensus-building in the proposal phase; organise three cross-WP workshops (M18, M24, M36) and conferences; ensure all partners are actively involved across WPs.
5	Partner unable to deliver work on time	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Monitor progress regularly through the Project Coordinator; take early remedial action by assigning additional staff, redistributing tasks, or amending the Grant Agreement to adjust responsibilities.
6	Inadequate resources to perform project activities	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Ensure careful budgeting from the outset; conduct periodic resource risk assessments; address gaps quickly through reallocation of funds or staff.
7	Low participation or engagement in participatory activities (Hackathons, Youth Labs, Civil Society Network)	WP3	Engage stakeholders early; offer incentives (visibility, certification); adapt formats for online/hybrid delivery; co-design activities to ensure relevance for participants.
8	Difficulty integrating findings across WPs leading to incoherent outputs	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Hold cross-WP workshops at key milestones (M18, M24, M36); appoint integration focal points in each WP; use the CitiSense analytical framework as a shared reference.
9	Ethics or data protection noncompliance	WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Implement an Ethics Monitoring Protocol from M1; appoint a Data Protection Officer; ensure GDPR compliance in all data workflows; conduct regular ethics and data protection training.
10	Data not complying with GDPR or data protection standards	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Explicitly embed GDPR obligations in the Consortium Agreement; conduct compliance checks at all data collection and storage stages; ensure all personnel receive relevant training.

Critical risks & risk management strategy <i>Grant Preparation (Critical Risks screen) — Enter the info.</i>			
Risk number	Description	Work Package No(s)	Proposed Mitigation Measures
11	Conflict within the consortium	WP1, WP3, WP6, WP2, WP5, WP4	Resolve disputes informally where possible; escalate to Project Coordinator for mediation; if unresolved, bring to the General Assembly for decision.
12	Insufficient dissemination or uptake of results		Develop targeted dissemination plans for different audiences; involve stakeholders in co-creation; monitor engagement metrics and adapt strategies as needed. Consult Advisory Board for strategic guidance

PROJECT REVIEWS

Project Reviews			
Grant Preparation (Reviews screen) — Enter the info.			
Review No	Timing (month)	Location	Comments
RV1	18	tbd	
RV2	36	tbd	

CitiSense History of change

No.	Change description	Section	Page number of Part B
1.	Watch dog MD withdrawal from the consortium due to personal reasons of the main academic.	Part A Part B	
2.	Additon of the new partner – Institute for European Policies and Reforms	Part A Part B	
3.	Split of WP2 into 2 sperate work packages - The separation between WP2 and WP3 reflects both a scientific distinction and a functional necessity for the coordination of interdependent work packages. At the scientific level, WP2 produces validated, comparable, cross-national data, while WP3 performs theory testing, causal inference, and policy translation. These are distinct phases of the research pipeline and must be sequenced to ensure validity. Combining data collection and analysis into a single work package would have otherwise collapsed measurement and inference into one pipeline, introducing unnecessary methodological risks. Separating data collection (WP2) from data analysis (WP3) ensures a rigorous and transparent research pipeline by clearly distinguishing measurement from inference. This structure prevents endogeneity in measurement decisions, as survey design and data construction are developed independently of analytical expectations, thereby reinforcing methodological discipline. It also safeguards cross-national comparability, allowing dedicated attention to linguistic, cultural, and sampling equivalence across countries before any substantive analysis is conducted. Finally, it enhances transparency and replicability by establishing a clear, auditable sequence from data production to analysis, ensuring that the resulting dataset is robust, reusable, and credible. WP2 also plays a foundational role for multiple downstream work packages, which require access to a stable and harmonized dataset to integrate into their own research activities.	Part A Part B	
4.	Split of WP7 into 2 separate work packages - The separation between WP8 and WP9 reflects both a scientific distinction and a functional necessity for the coordination of interdependent work packages.	Part A Part B	
5.	Changing the numbering of the WPs.	Part A Part B	
6.	Additon of the WP13 Ethics	Part A	
7.	Changing the numbering of tasks to fit the new numbering of WPs.	Part A Part B	
8.	Changing the numbering of tasks to fit the new numbering of WPs.	Part A Part B	
9.	Change of the end date for WP10. Extending duration to M36 will enable presentation of the toolboxes during the final conference	Part A Part B	
10.	D8.2 Toolbox for Education and Civil Society Teaching materials for schoolteachers and other actors in education to foster informed debate. (new deadline: M36 instead of M32, since the toolbox has to be ready for the final conference taking into account all findings across WPs)	Part A Part B	
	D8.4 Edited Collection of Short Country Reports ('Europe Next') Reports by post-graduate students from the College of Europe (et al.) reflecting national perspectives. (new deadline: M36 instead of M33. Since this deliverable will be linked to teaching at the College and our students at the OCs during the 2 nd semester, and the starting date of	Part A Part B	

	Citisense being 1.10.2026, moving it to the end of the 2 nd semester of the College's academic year)		
11.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information re. building on the previous projects	Part B	Page 6
12.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on case selection, participant inclusion	Part B	Page 8
13.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on participatory mechanism, interviews	Part B	Page 12
14.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on the IPR	Part B	Page 17
15.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on the Civil Society involvement	Part B	Page 20
16.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on the operationalise risk management under the impact section	Part B	Page 22-23
17.	Revised Figure 3.1a project structure to reflect the new numbering of the work packages	Part B	Page 29
18.	Revision of the Gantt Chart. There were no additional changes than adaptations reflecting the changes already mentioned (deliverables DDL and numbers).	Part B	Page 30-31
19.	Inclusion of the expertise for new partner and Dr Iulian Groza	Part B	Page 36
20.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on post-project ownership, hosting responsibilities and data sustainability/platforms and digital toolboxes	Part B	Page 36
21.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on administrative and ethical risks	Part B	Page 33-34
22.	Change of the summary of staff effort table to fit the new work package structure	Part A	
23.	Addition of text based on the evaluator's comments – extra information on the sustainability of platforms	Part B	Page 40-41
24.	Section 4 Ethics self-assessment added	Part B	Page 41-42
25.	Budget reduction: please note that TEPSA received the operating grant for 2026. We have reduced 3 months of the indirect from their overall budget (€6,873.33).	Part B	
26.	Budget reallocation: please note that travel budget under WP12 was increased for each partner to allow 1 person from each institution to manage their own travel for the consortium interim meeting (€850 per institution incl. 25% indirect). The EUI budget was reduced by €12.750 to allow the transferred of partners travel fund for mid-term conference.	Part A	

Making Sense of EU Enlargement *for, with and by* Citizens – *CitiSense*

#@APP-FORM-HERIAIA@#

List of participants

Participant No. *	Participant organisation name	Country
1 (Coordinator)	European University Institute (EUI)	Italy
2 (Scientific Lead)	Maastricht University (UM)	The Netherlands
3	International Centre for Defence and Security (ICDS)	Estonia
4	Institute for International Affairs (IAI)	Italy
5	Democracy Institute, Central European University (CEU)	Austria
6	University of Duisburg-Essen (UDE)	Germany
7	Institute for European Politics (IEP)	Germany
8	European Partnership for Democracy (EPD)	Belgium
9	Stockholm University (SU)	Sweden
10	Trans-European Policy Studies Association (TEPSA)	Belgium
11	Comenius University Bratislava (CUB)	Slovakia
12	University of Social Sciences and Humanities Warsaw (USWPS)	Poland
13	Ilia State University (ISU)	Georgia
14	National University 'Kyiv-Mohyla Academy' (UKMA)	Ukraine
15.	Institute for European Policies and Reforms (IPRE)	Moldova
-	-	-
16	Institute for democracy Societas Civilis Skopje (IDSCS)	North Macedonia

* Please use the same participant numbering and name as that used in the administrative proposal forms.

1. Excellence #@REL-EVA-RE@#

EU enlargement has been central to the European project, shaping its political evolution, economic cohesion, and global role.¹ As the EU prepares to expand beyond 30 members, it must navigate the accession process amid rising geopolitical instability, democratic backsliding, and renewed strains on European security and transatlantic relations. Policymakers face the dual challenge of **making enlargement work in practical terms** – enhancing security, prosperity, and institutional stability – while also fostering public understanding and support. In this context, enlargement is not only a geostrategic imperative but also a process of institutional reform and societal transformation. Yet research has so far paid limited attention to how citizens' perceptions shape the acceptability and resilience of the enlargement process.

This project, **CitiSense (Making Sense of EU Enlargement for, with and by citizens)**, addresses the current gap by fostering understanding of the security, economic, and societal impacts of EU enlargement through an innovative, citizen-centred approach. At its core is the CitiSense analytical framework which conceptualises enlargement *for* citizens (by calculating its costs and benefits), *with* citizens (by taking public attitudes and concerns into account), and *by citizens* (through co-creation and participatory engagement). *CitiSense* combines citizens and sense-making to ensure that a flexible and adaptive enlargement is not only intelligible but meaningful for people: policies for citizens must be shaped with citizens and co-created by citizens.

For EU citizens, enlargement shapes labour markets, economic prospects, migration flows, and security – affecting both daily life and long-term opportunities. For candidate and potential candidate countries (CCs), it offers the prospect of peace, political stability, and economic growth, while demanding far-reaching reforms in governance, the rule of law, economic institutions, and social policy. As enlargement transforms political, economic, and societal landscapes across the continent, public understanding and engagement are essential to **fostering the credibility, legitimacy, and resilience of the process**.² Public acceptability cannot be taken for granted: it depends on citizens perceiving enlargement as fair, transparent, and beneficial.³ Historical episodes of treaty rejection in national referenda highlight the risks of citizen disengagement, while misperceptions and unaddressed concerns continue to undermine support in both Member States (MS) and CCs.⁴ Low levels of public trust and awareness can delay ratification, stall reforms, and erode the long-term viability of EU integration. These challenges – geopolitical, institutional, and societal – demand a rethinking of **how policy-makers assess, communicate, and implement enlargement across existing MS and CCs**.⁵ As stressed in the 2023 and 2024 Enlargement Packages and the Mission Letter to Marta Kos as Commissioner for EU Enlargement, a citizen-centred approach is essential.⁶

¹ Anghel, V. / Jones E. (2024): The Geopolitics of Enlargement: From Club to Commons, *Survival*, 66:4, pp. 101-114; Schimmelfennig, F. (2003): Strategic Action in a Community Environment: The Decision to Enlarge the European Union to the East, *Comparative Political Studies*, 36(1-2), 156-183; Schimmelfennig, F. / Sedelmeier, U. (2019): The Europeanisation of Eastern Europe: the external incentives model revisited, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 27.

² Bosse, G. (2025): Citizens Missing: Why Participation in EU Enlargement Matters Now More Than Ever, *European Democracy Hub*; Schwarzer, D. (2024): Growing Pains: EU Enlargement Must Not Endanger the Rule of Law and Capacity to Act, *Bertelsmann Stiftung*; Tallberg, J. / Zürn, M. (2019): The Legitimacy and Legitimation of International Organisations: Introduction and Framework, *Review of International Organisations*, 14, p.581-606.

³ Kortenska, E.G./ Sircar, I. / Steunenberg, B. (2016): Public-Elite Gap on European Integration: The Missing Link between Discourses about EU Enlargement among Citizens and Elites in Serbia, *Journal of European Integration*, 42(6), 873–888; Habermas, J. (2012): The Crisis of the European Union in the Light of a Constitutionalisation of International Law, *European Journal of International Law*, 23 (2), pp. 335-348; Nissen, S. (2003): Who Wants Enlargement of the EU? Support for Enlargement among Elites and Citizens in the European Union, *Czech Sociological Review*, 39(2).

⁴ Hobolt, S. B. / de Vries, C. E. (2016): Turning against the union? The impact of the crisis on the Eurosceptic vote in the 2014 European Parliament elections, *Electoral Studies*, 44, pp. 504-514; Kaeding, M./ Pollack J. / Schmidt P. (2024): Enlargement and the Future of Europe – Views from the Capitals, *Wiesbaden: Springer*.

⁵ Bélanger, M. E. / Schimmelfennig, F. (2021): Politicisation and rebordering in EU enlargement: membership discourses in European parliaments, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 28(3), 407–426; Bosse, G. (2024): The EU's Response to the Russian Invasion of Ukraine: Invoking Norms and Values in Times of Fundamental Rupture, *Journal of Common Market Studies*, 62(5); Maier, J. / Rittberger, B. (2008): Shifting Europe's Boundaries: Mass Media, Public Opinion and the Enlargement of the EU, *European Union Politics*, 9(2), 243-267; Raik, K. / Blockmans, S. / Osypchuk, A., / Suslov, A. (2024): EU Policy towards Ukraine: Entering Geopolitical Competition over European Order, *The International Spectator*, 59(1), 39–58.

⁶ European Commission, Directorate-General for Neighborhood and Enlargement Negotiations. (2023): 2023 Communication on EU Enlargement Policy; European Commission, Directorate-General for Neighborhood and Enlargement Negotiation. (2024): 2024

CitiSense responds to that call by placing citizen perceptions, motivations, and understanding at the heart of the enlargement process.

Against this backdrop, CitiSense asks its central question: **How can the European Union pursue a more effective and resilient enlargement policy by fostering understanding of its security, economic, and societal impacts *for, with and by citizens*?** This question reflects CitiSense's commitment to a **citizen-centred approach**, grounded in the understanding that enlargement must not only be strategically sound and institutionally viable, but also socially embedded and publicly understood. Through the *CitiSense* analytical framework, the project translates this vision into practice – developing tools to analyse how enlargement is perceived, contested, and co-created *for, with, and by* citizens across both MS and CCs.

CitiSense has two overarching goals:

- *First*, to **generate integrated, evidence-based insights** into the security, economic, and societal impacts of enlargement and non-enlargement, real and perceived, drawing on historical lessons, comparative analysis, and scenario planning to support inclusive, adaptive, and democracy-enhancing policymaking.
- *Second*, to **develop and deploy innovative policy and educational tools** – including participatory and digital formats – that strengthen public understanding, engagement, and support for enlargement, while reinforcing governance and the rule of law across an expanding EU.

1.1 Objectives and ambition #@PRJ-OBJ-PO@#

In the service of these two overarching goals, CitiSense has **seven key objectives**:

1. Develop an innovative conceptual and methodological framework, CitiSense, integrating citizen-centred research *for, with, and by* citizens, combining conceptual analysis and empirical mapping with participatory piloting, foresight, and policy tool development. This objective includes mapping the historical, security, economic, and societal drivers of enlargement and identifying factors behind Euroscepticism and enlargement fatigue.
2. Assess the costs and benefits of enlargement and non-enlargement, both real and perceived, for MS and CCs, focusing on security, economic, and societal impacts.
3. Inform institutional and policy reforms by synthesizing lessons from past enlargements and examining how internal EU reforms and staged integration can enhance the effectiveness of enlargement, including flexible and adaptive approaches. Particular attention is given to democracy, rule of law, governance, and key *acquis* chapters related to Information Society and Media (10), Judiciary and Fundamental Rights (23), Justice Freedom and Security (24), and Institutions (34), using comparative insights to propose reforms for both EU and CCs.
4. Design and test participatory engagement tools – including Citizen Assemblies, Hackathons, and popular, easy-to-use digital platforms (e.g. Mentimeter, Kahoot!) – in four EU MS, to evaluate innovative and accessible formats for public engagement, intercultural learning, and inclusive dialogue on enlargement.
5. Conduct strategic foresight and scenario planning to explore plausible futures for enlargement in response to geopolitical shifts, regional dynamics, and security-enlargement interdependencies, including the implications of renewed transatlantic uncertainty.
6. Develop dual-use enlargement toolboxes for policymakers and for civil society and education stakeholders, offering manuals, engagement strategies, and communication guidance co-created with the CitiSense Civil Society Network, the EU Enlargement Expert Hub, and 14 Youth Labs.
7. Disseminate findings through innovative and inclusive outreach ensuring that diverse voices are represented and that benefits are clearly conveyed to three core audiences: policymakers and administrators, civil society and youth, and the research community. Provide continuous, audience-specific recommendations on enlargement costs, benefits, and lessons learned from previous accessions.

Communication on EU Enlargement Policy; European Commission, Ursula von der Leyen. (2024): Mission Letter to Marta Kos Commissioner for Enlargement.

Together, these objectives enable CitiSense to contribute not only to evidence-based insights on enlargement but also to the design of a **flexible** and **adaptive** enlargement approach that can withstand evolving geopolitical, economic, and societal challenges. To answer the core research question and achieve its objectives, CitiSense explores four core lines of inquiry:

1. Historical Drivers, Cost-Benefit Analysis & Public Support

How have the strategic, economic, and societal drivers of enlargement evolved since 2004 across MS and CCs? What lessons from past enlargements inform current governance and public attitudes? How do motivations in CCs compare to those in older MS – persisting, strengthening, or declining over time? What are the key costs and benefits of enlargement versus non-enlargement, and how do security, economic, and societal factors shape public support or opposition?

2. Institutional Reforms, Accession Terms & Acquis Compliance

How can staged accession and internal reforms (e.g. qualified majority voting) improve enlargement outcomes? What institutional lessons from past enlargements support rule of law and democratic resilience in CCs? How can the EU address enlargement fatigue and prepare for 30+ members? What challenges arise in implementing Chapters 10, 23, 24, and 34 of the acquis, and how are they affected by geopolitical pressures?

3. Participatory Tools

To what extent can participatory mechanisms – citizen assemblies, hackathons, but also popular, easy-to-access digital tools – be used to enhance awareness and engagement? Which formats best foster inclusive understanding, especially among the youth and across diverse publics?

4. Strategic Foresight & Geopolitical Dynamics

How might geopolitical disruptions (e.g. U.S. disengagement, Russian aggression) or internal trade-offs (e.g. defence vs. enlargement budgets) shape enlargement scenarios? What risks and opportunities lie ahead, and how can foresight and variable geometry approaches strengthen resilience, trust, and public ownership of the process?

These four lines of inquiry⁷ define the CitiSense analytical framework, which marks a conceptual and methodological shift in enlargement research by placing citizen perspectives at the centre of inquiry. Whereas existing studies often prioritise institutional dynamics, geopolitical drivers, or elite-level negotiations, CitiSense responds to the need – both scholarly and policy-driven – to move beyond technocratic, top-down models of inquiry. It offers a **structured, citizen-centred approach capable of producing context-sensitive, policy-relevant evidence on how enlargement is understood, experienced, and contested**. By operationalizing the enlargement process *for citizens* (its tangible impacts), *with citizens* (their perceptions and interpretations), and *by citizens* (their participatory agency), CitiSense generates insights that speak directly to the legitimacy, communication, and public acceptability challenges facing policymakers, administrations, and civil society actors in both Member

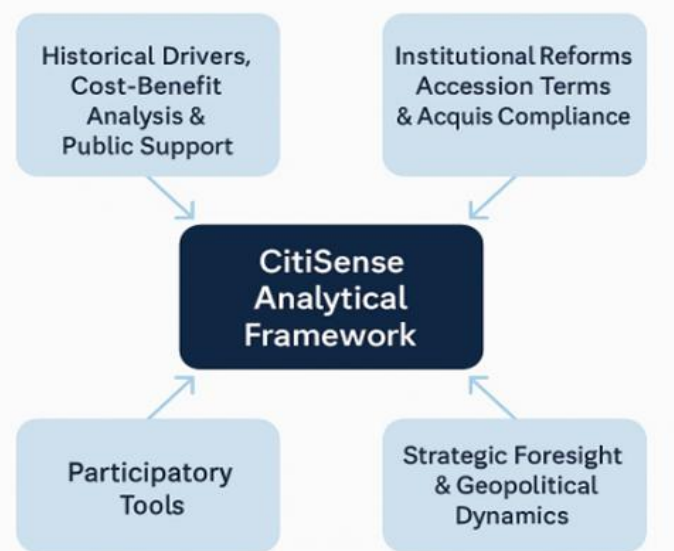


Figure 1: CitiSense Core Lines of Inquiry

⁷ Schimmelfennig, F./ Sedelmeier, U. (2005): The Politics of European Union Enlargement: Theoretical Approaches, *Routledge*; Moravcsik A. / Vachudova M. (2003): National Interests, State Power, and EU Enlargement, *East European Politics and Societies*, 17(1), pp. 42-57; Koval, N. / Vachudova, M. (2024): European Union Enlargement and Geopolitical Power in the Face of War, *Journal of Common Market Studies*, 62.

States and candidate countries. The conceptual boundaries in the CitiSense analytical framework overlap, reflecting the interdependence of these dimensions in fostering a credible and inclusive enlargement process.

This approach enables the project to deliver **a multidimensional evidence base on the costs and benefits of enlargement, the drivers of public support or opposition, and the effectiveness of institutional reforms**, all of which are central to the Horizon Europe call's emphasis on supporting democracy, governance, and the rule of law. Moreover, by integrating comparative analysis, strategic foresight, and innovative but easily accessible communication tools, the project provides actionable recommendations and tailored toolboxes that can be used to increase societal awareness, improve the transparency and credibility of the enlargement process, and support inclusive, future-oriented policymaking across the EU and CCs.

The **Enlargement for Citizens** dimension of CitiSense focuses on shaping an enlargement process that strengthens EU security, economic performance, and institutional functionality, while reinforcing the democratic resilience of CCs. In line with the call HORIZON-CL2-2025-01-DEMOCRACY-03, it equips policymakers and administrators with insights into key challenges, particularly those concerning democracy, rule of law, and governance. CitiSense analyses the historical and strategic drivers of enlargement across both MS and CCs, assessing how evolving dynamics affect its legitimacy and effectiveness. It provides a comprehensive evaluation of the costs and benefits of enlargement and non-enlargement – especially regarding security, prosperity, peacebuilding, and post-war recovery – and examines how internal reforms and staged approaches, including in relation to key chapters of the acquis (10, 23, 24, 34), can improve policy design across sectors.

To anticipate the impact of enlargement, CitiSense conducts strategic foresight and scenario exercises, stress-testing enlargement strategies under different geopolitical and socio-cultural futures. These methods help policymakers and citizens evaluate the feasibility and acceptability of differentiated and inclusive pathways – directly supporting the call's emphasis on adaptive governance. Finally, CitiSense studies how enlargement is framed and communicated by policymakers. These findings inform the project's multidimensional toolboxes for policymakers and educators, designed to support clear, tailored, and accessible public communication and enhance the legitimacy of the enlargement process.

The **Enlargement with Citizens** component examines how people in EU MS and CCs perceive, interpret, and evaluate the enlargement process. CitiSense employs surveys, focus groups, and survey experiments to capture not only what citizens think about enlargement, but why they think it – probing how different framings, narratives, and trade-offs influence public attitudes. This approach allows the project to move beyond static opinion snapshots toward a deeper understanding of the cognitive, emotional, and contextual factors shaping support or opposition. The findings contribute to the Horizon call's goal of increasing societal awareness through a deep analysis of the political, economic, and social consequences of enlargement as perceived by diverse publics. These insights will directly inform the development of tailored communication strategies that enhance credibility and engagement across different societal groups and national contexts.

The **Enlargement by Citizens** dimension of CitiSense recognises that passive engagement is insufficient for building lasting public support for EU enlargement and the reforms it requires. It promotes direct citizen participation in shaping enlargement policies, engaging individuals in the security, economic, and societal implications of both enlargement and non-enlargement. Aligned with the Horizon call, this component prioritises participatory and transparent processes, using digital tools and formats such as citizen assemblies, hackathons, and strategic foresight exercises to foster inclusive dialogue and co-creation of policy ideas. CitiSense ensures the continuity of compatible participatory tools developed in previous Horizon projects, thus further investing in keeping and expanding insights already generated by citizens. This approach moves beyond awareness-raising, enabling citizens to take ownership of enlargement as a shared political project.⁸ Strengthening civic agency and belonging in this way is essential to

⁸ Anghel, V. / Jones E. (2024): The Geopolitics of Enlargement: From Club to Commons, *Survival*, 66:4, pp. 101-114; Bosse, G. (2025): Citizens Missing: Why Participation in EU Enlargement Matters Now More Than Ever, *European Democracy Hub*; Pirozzi, N., / Bonomi, M. (2022): Differentiation and EU Governance: Key Elements and Impact, *The International Spectator*, 57(1), 160–178.

countering enlargement fatigue, addressing Euroscepticism, and supporting a credible and democratically grounded enlargement strategy.

What are the four key characteristics of CitiSense?

1. **CitiSense is innovative.** Its analytical framework moves beyond top-down analyses to focus on the acceptability of enlargement among diverse publics across MS and CCs. The project systematically examines historical drivers, costs and benefits, and lessons from past enlargements, with a focus on democracy, governance, and the rule of law. Civil society and citizens – especially the youth – are involved from the start and throughout (T1.1, D1.1; T3.1, D3.1; T10.3, D10.3). CitiSense generates original empirical data through large-scale public opinion surveys, survey experiments (WP2: T2.1-T2.4; D2.1; WP3:T3.1), and fieldwork, including elite interviews and comparative case studies (WPs 5-7), to assess the impacts of enlargement versus non-enlargement, both real and perceived. Multidimensional toolboxes for policymakers, civil society, and educators translate findings into actionable recommendations (T10.1-T10.2, D10.1-10.2), including tailored communication strategies for different national contexts (D5.1, D6.4, D7.2, D10.1, D11.3). CitiSense also pilots scalable participatory formats – Youth Labs, Citizen Assemblies, Democracy Hackathons, and a Citizens’ Art Exhibition (T4.1-T4.2, T9.2, T10.3, T11.13) – alongside easy-to-use digital tools like Mentimeter and Kahoot! (T3.1-T3.2). Additional outputs include a Digital Guidebook (‘30 FAQs on Enlargement’) (T10.1), an edited Collection of Short Country Reports ‘Europe Next’ written for a wider audience by graduate students based on CitiSense data (T10.4, D10.4), educational tools for schoolteachers and civil society (T10.2, D10.2), Instagram Reels (T11.8), five public panel discussions (T11.3), and a social media survey (T11.11), all designed to test new ways of informing, engaging, and gathering input from citizens – especially the youth. Participatory mechanisms also include social dialogues (T4.4, T11.12), fostering intercultural learning, peer-to-peer exchange, and collaborative problem-solving. These formats challenge stereotypes, counter misperceptions, and build deeper understanding and ownership of the enlargement process (D4.1-D4.3; D10.3; D11.3).
2. **CitiSense is pluralist, collaborative, and builds systematically on prior EU funded projects.** It conducts research across the EU and CCs through a purposefully large yet integrated consortium that includes partners from Ukraine, Georgia, Moldova, and the Western Balkans. These partners contribute regional expertise, co-lead work packages, and play an active role in case studies and cross-cutting research. CitiSense is interdisciplinary (see Section 1.3), bridges academic and think tank communities, and fosters strong transnational networks. It builds on and advances the conceptual frameworks, findings, and tools of previous projects. Several consortium members participated in EMBRACE, InvigoratEU, SHAPEDEM, REDEMOS, EU JOINT, and REUNIR. Advisory Board members include the leads of EMBRACE and SHAPEDEM, and a representative of the EU Neighbors EAST programme. Successful pilots from InvigoratEU (Civil Society Network, EU Enlargement Expert Hub, Youth Labs) and RECLAIM (Citizens’ Art Exhibition) are continued and further developed in CitiSense, with multiple work packages drawing on and extending insights from these and related initiatives (e.g. T1.1, T5.2, T6.1, T7.1, T8.1). The CitiSense coordination strategy includes collaboration with the other winning tenders of call HORIZON-CL2-2025-01-DEMOCRACY-03 (T11.3, T12.3).

While CitiSense builds on methodological insights from previous Horizon projects, it advances beyond them by integrating these strands into a unified citizen-centred analytical framework that systematically links cost-benefit analysis, participatory co-creation, and strategic foresight within enlargement research for the first time.

3. **CitiSense is inclusive, co-creational, and broad in reach.** Citizens, civil society actors, and other stakeholders are engaged not just as recipients of findings, but as active partners – through the CitiSense Civil Society Network (T1.1, T1.5, T2.3, T4.5, T5.4, T6.4, T7.3, T10.5), the EU Enlargement Expert Hub (T1.1, T1.5, T2.3, T4.5, T5.4, T6.4, T7.3, T10.2), and participatory video formats where citizens pose questions to researchers (T11.12). CitiSense prioritises youth engagement via a four-day seminar for young professionals in Brussels (T11.4) and the co-creation of educational tools, including the edited student written collection of short country reports ‘Europe Next’ (D10.4). The project ensures gender inclusivity through a balanced consortium and mainstreams gender sensitivity across all research, communication, and dissemination activities. Leveraging the TEPSA network, CitiSense ensures broad outreach to policymakers and public administrations across all EU MS, CCs, and EU institutions – embedding its findings in decision-making at every level. The consortium ensures a

purposeful presence across all candidate states. The Institute for Democracy Societas Civilis Skopje (IDSCS) connects CitiSense to all Western Balkan CCs via its Cooperation Instrument for the Western Balkans Think Tanks, THINK BALKANS. Ilia State University, the Kyiv-Mohyla Academy, and the Institute for European Politics and Reforms (IPRE) are in Georgia, Ukraine, and Moldova (respectively).

4. **CitiSense is a transparent and open science project.** It recognises the good practice of research, aims for open-access publications only, commits to transparent data storage, and makes data available to the public, fully complying with FAIR and open science principles.

Prior project	Key findings / outputs	CitiSense uptake & advance
InvigoratEU	Civil society networks; youth labs; alerts on shrinking civic space.	Extends CSO network & Youth Labs to CCs/potential CCs; adds resilience focus.
EMBRACE	Differentiated integration debates; citizen attitudes.	Builds foresight scenarios combining DI options with survey & pilot data.
SHAPEDEM-EU	Democratic resilience research; foresight tools.	Reuses participatory foresight methods; adds enlargement lens.
ENLARGE	Economic CBAs; regional inequality insights.	Feeds WP5 regional mapping & adaptive economic approaches.
Visegrad/other regional studies	Societal impacts of past enlargements.	Extended in WP7 case studies on cohesion/reform.

#§PRJ-OBJ-PO§#

1.2 Methodology #@CON-MET-CM@# #@COM-PLE-CP@#

The CitiSense analytical framework fuses ‘citizen’ and ‘sense-making’, highlighting the project’s **commitment to understanding and co-creating knowledge about EU enlargement**. During CitiSense’s three-year project lifetime, the consortium’s research activities take place within three interconnected working blocks that collectively deliver on the project’s mission to analyse and make recommendations for how the EU can pursue an inclusive, effective and adaptive enlargement policy that strengthens institutional functionality, fosters public engagement, and builds sustainable support for European integration.

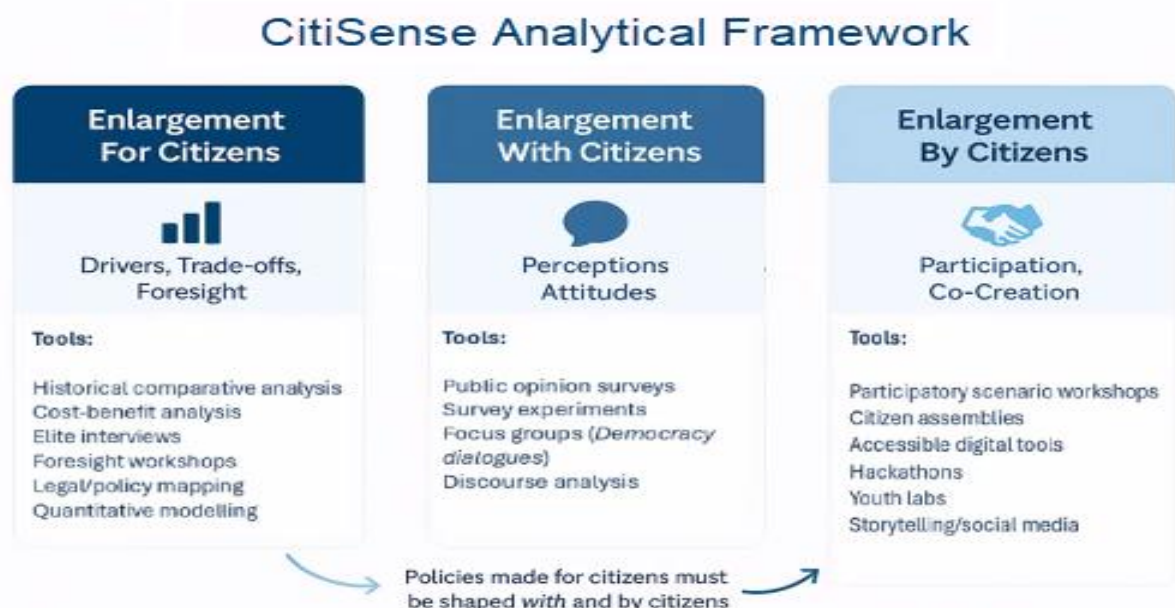


Figure 2: *CitiSense* at a glance

The **first working block** focuses on conceptualisation (M1-M12), laying the theoretical and analytical foundations for a citizen-centred study of enlargement. It develops its innovative analytical framework and the tools grounded in the logics of enlargement *for*, *with*, and *by* citizens. The **second working block** (M3-M24) is dedicated to analysis and piloting, based on empirical research (WPs 2,3, 5, 6,7) with participatory mechanisms tested in WP4. This phase addresses enlargement *for* and *with* citizens through surveys, survey experiments, interviews, and case studies, and develops an understanding of enlargement *by* citizens through Democracy Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies, and other digital tools. The **third working block** (M22-M36) centres on strategic foresight and toolbox development: WP8-9 develops future scenarios *for* and *by* citizens, while WP10 translates research and engagement into a multidimensional toolbox for policymakers, educators, and civil society – delivering tailored, actionable recommendations. By embedding stakeholder engagement throughout, this analytical framework ensures CitiSense combines scientific excellence with societal relevance for an inclusive and adaptive enlargement policy.

Case selection: CitiSense ensures broad case coverage across WPs to generate robust comparative insights. This design ensures systematic inclusion of perspectives from MS and CCs, allowing CitiSense to generate insights tailored to the specific needs of each group. WPs 1 and 8 encompass all MS and all categories of CCs, enabling a full-spectrum analysis of historical drivers and forward-looking scenarios. WP2 and 3 capture public opinion across nine countries, with a balanced mix of ‘older’ and ‘newer’ MS and current CCs. WPs 5-7 together cover six MS, including four former CCs (joined in 2004), and four current CCs, for in-depth comparative analysis, *inter alia* capturing different enlargement experiences and security perceptions, and historical, political, economic and societal diversity.⁹

The selection of countries in CitiSense follows a structured comparative design aimed at maximising analytical variation while ensuring policy relevance and feasibility. Countries were chosen to represent different positions within the enlargement architecture, including ‘older’ Member States, ‘newer’ Member States with accession experience since 2004, and current Candidate Countries at different stages of the negotiation process. This variation allows the project to capture differences in enlargement memory, institutional adaptation, and contemporary reform trajectories. In addition, countries were selected to reflect variation in geopolitical exposure, security threat environments, and documented levels of public support or scepticism toward enlargement. This ensures that the analysis encompasses both supportive and contested enlargement contexts. Practical feasibility considerations were also taken into account, including the presence of strong local research partners, reliable data infrastructure, and the capacity to conduct participatory pilots in line with ethical and methodological standards. Taken together, these criteria ensure balanced representation across Member States and Candidate Countries while maintaining analytical leverage.

The case study selection in WPs 5-7 follows a comparative most-different systems design to examine the security, economic and societal dimensions of enlargement. Cases were selected to reflect variation in accession timing, democratic resilience trajectories, exposure to geopolitical pressure, economic convergence patterns, and social cohesion dynamics. Selection further considered relevance to key acquis chapters under analysis (Chapters 10, 23, 24 and 34), availability of high-quality policy and statistical data, and the potential for meaningful cross-case comparison. This design enables the project to draw lessons from past enlargements while systematically comparing them with current candidate trajectories, thereby strengthening the robustness and transferability of findings.

Participant inclusion criteria are clearly defined across data collection instruments. For the WP2 and 3 public opinion surveys, respondents are drawn from nationally representative adult populations (18+), using stratified sampling procedures based on age, gender, education and region. Post-stratification weighting is applied to ensure representativeness. Where necessary, mixed-mode data collection enhances inclusion of underrepresented groups. Inclusion and exclusion criteria, weighting procedures, and data validation protocols will be fully documented in the Data Management Plan and accompanying methodological annexes.

1.2.1 Conceptual Framework

⁹ CitiSense also acknowledges that, according to current national ambitions, **Montenegro could join the EU as the 28th Member State by 2028 and Albania as the 29th by 2029**, which would overlap with the project’s duration. This context-sensitive horizon reinforces the urgency of the project’s contribution to a flexible and adaptive enlargement approach.

Citisense delivers on **Objective 1 – Develop an innovative conceptual and methodological framework** (WP1), which defines benchmarks and analytical categories to guide the project’s research activities and ensure coherence across all empirical work packages (WPs 2-8). This framework is also informed by a systematic review of relevant conceptual and methodological tools developed in previous relevant Horizon projects, including EMBRACE, SHAPEDEM-EU, InvigoratEU, EUIDEA, EU3D, InDivEU or DICE. The resulting Conceptual and Methodological Framework Report (D1.1) ensures theoretical and methodological alignment across the consortium and serves as a common reference point for all empirical activities. It ensures that CitiSense perspectives are systematically integrated into all phases of the research, informing both survey and qualitative instruments used across WPs 2-7, and feeding directly into the outreach and communication activities in WPs 10 and 11.

In Task 1.2, WP1 conducts comparative socio-historical research across enlargement waves. Drawing on EU and national archives, public opinion data, and modelling tools, this task maps the geopolitical, economic, and societal motivations for enlargement, as well as the consequences for social cohesion and democratic participation. These findings are compiled in an innovative Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement (D1.2), which visualises patterns of public sentiment, security alignment, and economic interdependence across MS and CCs, including manifestations of enlargement fatigue and Euroscepticism. In Task 1.5, WP1 integrates findings from across the consortium to produce the Synthesis of Key Findings (D1.5). This report highlights how enlargement affects democratisation and rule of law in both real and perceived ways and formulates actionable policy recommendations for EU and national authorities to dispel misunderstanding and better inform the citizens. The synthesis phase includes structured validation through the CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub, reinforcing the participatory ethos embedded in the project’s conceptual framework.

1.2.2 Empirical research on enlargement *for, with and by* citizens

The research phase of CitiSense systematically addresses **Objectives 2 and 3** through a comprehensive mixed-methods approach, with each work package targeting specific research questions aligned with the citizen-centred framework.

For Objective 2 – Assess the costs and benefits of enlargement and non-enlargement, real and perceived – the project seeks to answer what security, economic, and societal costs and benefits arise from enlargement versus non-enlargement, and how these differ across MS and CCs. Which factors – economic, security, societal – most significantly influence public opposition or support, and how do different framings of the process alter perceptions? WP2 and 3 are central to CitiSense’s empirical research, providing large-scale comparative data on public attitudes toward EU enlargement across five EU MS (Estonia, Slovenia, France, Netherlands, Spain) and four CCs (Ukraine, Moldova, North Macedonia, Serbia). Grounded in the CitiSense approach, WP2 and 3 investigate the historical, geopolitical, identity-based, socio-economic, and cost-benefit factors shaping support for or opposition to enlargement. It combines **survey and survey experiment techniques** to assess how citizens interpret the enlargement process and how different framings of enlargement influence their views (T2.1-T3.2). The survey work begins with a systematic literature review and survey design (T2.1), followed by a pilot phase in select countries to refine questions and translations (T2.2). Full-scale surveys are then implemented online, with telephone interviews in some cases to enhance representativeness (T2.3). The data is cleaned and processed using statistical software (T2.4) and analysed using multilevel regression models to explore how demographic factors and narrative framings affect public support (T3.1). Based on these findings, WP3 formulates concrete, policy-relevant recommendations on how to communicate enlargement more effectively and engage citizens meaningfully in the process (T3.2). The findings are reported through three main deliverables: a harmonised dataset from the nine surveyed countries (D2.1), a comprehensive research report on the drivers of public opinion and the impact of information exposure (D3.1), and two policy papers – one comparing cross-country attitudes and another outlining the most effective communication strategies (D3.2). These outputs also inform the cost-benefit analyses in WPs 4-6 and contribute to the development of narratives and educational resources in WP10 toolboxes. In doing so, WP3 ensure that the voices of citizens – within and beyond the EU – inform the design of enlargement policy, strategy, and communication across the CitiSense project.

WPs 5, 6 and 7 each conduct a targeted cost-benefit assessment combining qualitative and quantitative research methods, supporting the *for citizens* logic within CitiSense. WP5, focusing on the security dimension, conducts qualitative cost-benefit analyses (T5.1) by reviewing academic and policy literature, conducting expert interviews, and analysing policy documents to assess how enlargement affects national and EU-level security. It compares perceptions and realities of security-related costs and benefits in five case studies – Ukraine, Georgia, North Macedonia, Estonia, and France – selected to reflect a spectrum of threat environments and EU membership experiences. These findings are synthesised in a policy paper (D5.1), which also includes tailored communication recommendations. Task 5.2 extends the analysis by extracting lessons from past enlargements, with a focus on the security dimensions of Estonia and Slovakia's accession experiences, and how public security concerns influenced attitudes toward EU integration (D5.2). Methodologically, this task combines a literature review with comparative analysis of accession treaty terms and public opinion trends, supported by inputs from WP2 and 3. To examine the EU's institutional readiness and the potential of staged integration into EU security and defence policy, T5.3 and T5.4 apply a forward-looking analysis based on policy document review and stakeholder interviews, culminating in a policy paper on security-related institutional reforms (D5.3). Across all tasks, WP5 integrates behavioural and constructivist theories to assess how security narratives are constructed and communicated, and how they influence public and elite perspectives.

WP6 focusing on the economic dimension, conducts a multi-layered assessment of the economic costs and benefits of enlargement through historical and contemporary lenses. Task 6.1 conducts a systematic review of literature and past Horizon project findings to assess the economic dimensions of EU enlargement. It examines the limits of static cost-benefit analyses, the economic terms of accession treaties (e.g. transition periods, funding), and compares integration strategies across Southern, Eastern, and recent enlargement waves (D6.1). This comparative institutional analysis integrates findings from prior Horizon projects (e.g., EU JOINT, EMBRACE, REDEMOS). Regional disparities and patterns of citizen inclusion or exclusion are addressed in Task 6.2, which maps subnational variation in EU fund absorption and investigates the political economy geography of enlargement, with particular attention to Hungary, Poland, and selected regions in Ukraine (D6.2). Task 6.3 uses survey data (including from WPs 2 and 3) to examine how socio-economic perceptions, trust in governance, and satisfaction with EU institutions shape political attitudes (D6.3). Task 6.4 synthesises the findings into actionable and adaptive policy recommendations, validated through iterative engagement with stakeholders from the CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub (D6.4).

WP7, analysing the societal dimension, applies a historical-comparative approach (T7.1) to examine how past and current enlargements have affected social cohesion, public perceptions, and democratic resilience. The research focuses on four case studies – Austria, Slovakia, Moldova, and North Macedonia – selected for their diverse enlargement trajectories and societal profiles. Desk research and content analysis are combined with data from WP2-3 to assess how enlargement processes interact with institutional trust, democratic backsliding, and Euroscepticism. These findings are synthesised in a comprehensive research report (D7.1), which also includes a cost-benefit analysis of societal impacts (T7.2), ranging from civic engagement and social trust to institutional strain and disinformation. The work package employs cost-benefit analysis methodology grounded in welfare and behavioural economics, while also drawing on social constructivist insights into how societal narratives are formed and evolve. Task 7.3 uses these insights to develop policy recommendations and a policy paper (D7.2) that outlines flexible communication strategies and tools to address societal concerns, strengthen public support, and foster social cohesion in future enlargements. This includes the development of educational guidelines and promising practices for public engagement, feeding directly into the WP10 communication toolkit.

For Objective 3 – Inform institutional and policy reforms by synthesizing lessons from past enlargements – the research in WPs 1, 5, 6 and 7 addresses how staged accession approaches enhance enlargement effectiveness across security, economic, and societal dimensions; what lessons from past enlargements strengthen democracy and the rule of law in CCs, and how CCs can implement critical *acquis* reforms (Chapters 10, 23, 24, 34) amid geopolitical and domestic challenges. This includes lessons learned from *acquis* adoption in the domains of security and the economy. To support this analysis, two comparative policy reports developed in WP1 based on the contributions from partners from Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia and the WB6 countries provide foundational insights (D1.3, D1.4). The first, *Comparative policy report on motivations, challenges, and the role of EU support in CCs' paths to membership* (D1.3), explores the political and economic conditions in (potential) CCs, their motivations to join the

EU, and the implications of enlargement versus non-enlargement. It also assesses obstacles and drivers of reform – including domestic factors, geopolitical pressures, enlargement fatigue, and euroscepticism – along with views on differentiated integration and conditionality. It concludes with recommendations on how the EU can better support reforms and communicate enlargement in these contexts. The second, *Comparative policy report on the reform process in candidate countries regarding Chapters 10, 23, 24 and 34 (D1.4)*,¹⁰ focuses specifically on how the EU can assist or learn from reform trajectories in these fundamental areas, offering recommendations for a flexible and adaptive enlargement approach that considers prevailing geopolitical and security challenges. Reform dynamics are analysed through theoretical lenses such as modernisation¹¹ and Europeanisation,¹² as well as drawing on findings from prior Horizon projects (EMBRACE, SHAPED-EM-EU, etc.) addressing democratisation and broader modernisation processes in the EU's neighbourhood. CitiSense assesses the impact of geopolitical factors through different analytical frameworks (e.g., securitisation)¹³ and conceptual insights from InvigoratEU on balancing modernisation and geopolitical imperatives. The analysis (T1.2, T1.3, T1.4) involves extensive desk research, semi-structured interviews with policymakers from the EU and CCs, and expert interviews.

WP5 addresses Objective 3 by analysing the security-related components of past and current accession processes. Task 5.2 provides a comparative analysis of security provisions in past accession treaties and draws parallels with current CCs, while Task 5.3 evaluates how phased integration into EU security structures – such as PESCO or CFSP – could respond to citizens' security concerns. These tasks explore the relevance of institutional reforms for staged accession, producing a critical reflection of policy readiness in D5.2 and D5.3. WP6 examines the economic terms and institutional conditions in past treaties (T6.1, T6.2) and their post-accession impacts, particularly in Hungary and Poland, and selected regions of Ukraine. This includes a comparative evaluation of relative and absolute socio-economic changes and their effects on trust and political alignment (T6.3). By contrasting these with current candidate trajectories, WP6 identifies pathways and pitfalls in aligning economic integration with democratic resilience. Deliverables D6.2 and D6.3 provide the comparative basis for policy recommendations on institutional adaptation and sequencing (D6.4). WP7 focuses on societal readiness for enlargement and institutional resilience. Task 7.1 investigates how societal factors – such as social trust, civic participation, and cultural integration – have historically affected the success of EU accessions. Task 7.2 compares societal costs and benefits between CCs and EU members, while Task 7.3 assesses how flexible institutional integration could reduce societal disruption and reinforce democratic norms. These analyses culminate in the D7.2 policy paper, which offers models for assessing societal readiness and recommendations on managing social impacts through staged or adaptive approaches. WPs 5-7 coordinate the methods they use to ensure robust and context-sensitive insights. This includes the integration of desk research, survey data (via WPs 2 and 3), expert and stakeholder interviews, and comparative case studies. The outputs of WPs 4-6 feed directly into WP10 toolkits and WP4 and WP11 stakeholder dialogues (T4.4; T11.3-T11.7), ensuring that citizen perspectives and practical lessons shape the future design of EU enlargement policy. All three WPs actively engage the CitiSense Civil Society Network and Youth Labs (WP10) and the EU Enlargement Expert Hub (WP11) throughout the research process, ensuring that stakeholder input and policymaker relevance are embedded across all stages of analysis from day one.

WP4 directly addresses **Objective 4 – Design and test participatory engagement tools** – by piloting Democracy Hackathons and Citizen Assemblies in France, Belgium, Germany, and Czechia. These formats engage citizens in co-creating solutions to enlargement challenges, ensuring they help shape – rather than just understand – the process (T4.1, T4.2). Key research questions include: To what extent do participatory formats like Hackathons and Citizen Assemblies – enhanced by user-friendly digital tools (Mentimeter, Kahoot!) – increase awareness and engagement?

¹⁰ This includes a comparative study of those countries that are engaged in active accession negotiations with the EU, including Montenegro, Serbia, Albania, North Macedonia, Moldova and Ukraine, excluding countries with paused or suspended talks.

¹¹ Lipset, S. M. (1959): Some Social Requisites of Democracy: Economic Development and Political Legitimacy, *American Political Science Review*, 53(1), 69-105.

¹² Schimmelfennig, F./ Sedelmeier, U. (2005): The Politics of European Union Enlargement: Theoretical Approaches, *Routledge*; Lippert, B. | Umbach, G. (2005): Pressures of Europeanisation. From post-communist state administrations towards normal players in the EU system, Baden-Baden.

¹³ Farinha, R. / Youngs, R. (2025): Securitisation and European Democracy Policy, *Carnegie Europe*; Kaunert, C. / Bosse, G. / Vieira A. (2023): Introduction: resilient states versus resilient societies? Whose security does the EU protect through the Eastern Partnership in times of geopolitical crises?, *Journal of Contemporary European Studies*, 31(4), 1048-1057; Orenstein, M. A. (2015): Geopolitics of a Divided Europe, *East European Politics and Societies*, 29(2), 531-540.

How do they promote inclusive learning among youth and marginalised groups? Which tools are most effective in improving understanding of enlargement? Democracy Hackathons (France, Belgium) are fully online, 18-hour events bringing together diverse citizens – especially youth – to address enlargement challenges drawn from WP2-3 data. WP4 selects participants through open calls and targeted outreach to ensure broad demographic representation. Each Hackathon follows three phases: *Framing*, where experts present challenges such as defence-enlargement trade-offs using WP2 insights; *Co-creation*, where interdisciplinary teams develop solutions with support from facilitators and digital tools (Mentimeter for polling and mood-tracking; Kahoot! for gamified learning); *Presentation*, where teams pitch ideas to a panel of experts from the EU Enlargement Expert Hub for feedback and recognition (T4.1, D4.1). Citizen Assemblies (Germany, Czechia) follow OECD/EU best practices. WP4 selects 20 participants via stratified random sampling to ensure demographic representativeness. Held in hybrid format for accessibility, each assembly begins with a learning phase featuring balanced briefings by enlargement experts and programme representatives (Erasmus+, Interreg, etc.), grounded in data from WPs 5-7. Participants deliberate in small groups using inclusive methods like the Fishbowl format. Moderators ensure equitable dialogue. Final recommendations are agreed by consensus or secret ballot and submitted to national and EU parliamentary committees, feeding into WP11's dissemination strategy (T4.2, D4.1). Hackathons and Citizen Assemblies include innovations to enhance inclusion and policy relevance. Hackathons feature 'debunking sprints' to co-create counter-narratives against misinformation. Assemblies enforce gender-responsive design (min. 50% female or non-binary participants) and apply a gender lens throughout (T4.1, T4.2). WP4 selected France, Belgium, Germany, and Czechia for their diversity in geography, political culture, and public sentiment. France and Germany offer high-capacity contexts for testing participatory tools in elite-driven debates. Belgium provides a multilingual, transnational testbed. Czechia contributes recent accession memory and a more contested enlargement discourse. Feasibility, digital infrastructure, and strong partner networks also guided selection, ensuring lessons are grounded and transferable. WP4 will synthesise findings in a final policy paper evaluating effectiveness against democratic innovation literature and benchmarking against EU initiatives like the Conference on the Future of Europe.¹⁴ (T4.5, D4.3).

For participatory mechanisms in WP4, Democracy Hackathons and Citizen Assemblies follow established deliberative democracy standards. Hackathon participants are recruited through open calls combined with targeted outreach to ensure diversity across gender, age, socio-economic background and educational attainment, with particular attention to youth engagement. Citizen Assemblies use stratified random sampling to ensure demographic representativeness across gender, age cohorts, region, education and urban-rural distribution. These procedures follow OECD best practices and are designed to enhance legitimacy, inclusivity and transparency.

Expert interviews conducted across WPs 1 and 5-9 follow purposive sampling criteria based on demonstrable expertise or institutional involvement in enlargement policy or reform processes. Selection ensures institutional diversity across EU institutions, national administrations, civil society and academia, as well as gender balance and representation across Member States and Candidate Countries. Recruitment processes and anonymisation protocols are governed by the project's ethics framework and will be explicitly detailed in the Data Management Plan.

We will incorporate this consolidated selection protocol into the Data Management Plan to ensure systematic oversight and monitoring of representativeness and diversity across work packages. The Data Management Plan will specify sampling frameworks, inclusion and exclusion criteria, documentation procedures, anonymisation measures and data archiving standards in line with FAIR principles and GDPR compliance

WP11 reinforces WP4's participatory goals through citizen-driven dissemination. Initiatives include short videos featuring citizen questions to researchers (T11.12), a Citizens' Art Exhibition and interactive workshop in Maastricht (T11.13), and a social media survey gathering public views on past and future enlargement (T11.11). These formats broaden engagement, humanise the enlargement debate, and ensure citizens contribute directly to CitiSense's outreach and impact strategy.

1.2.5 Strategic Foresight: Security, Economic, and Societal Futures of EU Enlargement

¹⁴ e.g. Fung, A. (2006): Varieties of Participation in Complex Governance, *Public Administration Review*, 66, 66-75; Smith, J.A. / Flower, P. / Larkin, M. (2009): Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis: Theory, Method and Research, 6(4), pp. 346–347

WP8-9 directly addresses **Objective 5 – Conduct strategic foresight and scenario planning** to explore plausible futures for enlargement considering geopolitical shifts, regional dynamics, and security-enlargement interdependencies, including the implications of renewed transatlantic uncertainty. CitiSense embraces forward-looking governance and a future-oriented perspective to help policymakers and citizens prepare for unpredictable developments that may affect the enlargement process.¹⁵ Rather than seeking to predict the future, CitiSense's foresight activities focus on developing plausible, diverse, and context-sensitive scenarios that minimise surprises and expand the strategic options available to decision-makers (T8.2). This approach is also fully aligned with Objective 6, which includes the development of engagement strategies that can inform both immediate and long-term policy responses.

The foresight methodology begins with a comprehensive scoping of key actors, factors, and pressures related to EU enlargement, drawing on systematic literature reviews, evidence synthesis, and concept mapping (T8.1). This foundational analysis is informed by the project's earlier work packages, including WP1's conceptual framework, WPs 2 and 3's public opinion survey data, WP4's engagement insights, and the cost-benefit analyses and reform assessments conducted in WPs 5-7. WP8 applies trend analysis, horizon scanning, and the identification of global and European trends, strategic uncertainties, and systemic constellations that may shape the future of enlargement. Analytical frameworks such as STEEP and SWOT are used to structure this exploration, while narrative policy frameworks and network analysis help to map the evolving landscape of actors, interests, and ideas. Building on this foundation, CitiSense develops a set of alternative futures scenarios for EU enlargement, ranging from projected and plausible to possible and preferable (T9.1). These scenarios are not only constructed by the research team but are also tested and refined through participatory engagement exercises, including two workshops and deliberative settings that involve academic experts, practitioners, and citizens (T9.2). This participatory approach, drawing on the Community of Practice (CoP) methodology, ensures that a broad range of perspectives and expertise informs the assessment of each scenario's socio-cultural, political, and practical acceptability and feasibility. The participatory approach also stress-tests ideas, supports policy innovation, and feeds directly into WP10 toolkits – promoting adaptive, forward-looking governance beyond path dependency. The scenarios will deliberately include not only differentiated pathways of successful enlargement but also at least one trajectory where enlargement is stalled or abandoned. This approach allows assessing the costs of non-enlargement and testing the resilience of EU and national strategies under both positive and adverse futures.

1.2.6 CitiSense Toolboxes for communicating EU Enlargement

WP10 addresses **Objective 6 – Develop dual-use enlargement toolboxes** for policymakers and for civil society and education stakeholders. The CitiSense toolboxes are evidence-based resources that synthesise the project's research, piloting, and foresight activities into actionable outputs for policymakers, educators, civil society actors, and citizens. Building on the project's citizen-centred approach, the toolboxes develop through a process of co-creation, iterative validation, and structured stakeholder engagement. This ensures that all materials are accessible, context-sensitive, and tailored to diverse audiences across the EU and CCs, while also reflecting specific regional, generational, and gender-related features (T10.5).

The CitiSense toolboxes consist of:

- **A policy toolbox** for policy makers and public administration in MS, CCs, and at the European institutional level (T10.1, D10.1). Drawing on insights from WPs 1-9, it provides robust, evidence-based strategies, scenario-based guidance, and tailored communication tools for addressing the security, economic, and societal dimensions of enlargement and non-enlargement. The toolbox incorporates findings from public opinion polls (WPs 2 and 3) and comparative case studies (WPs 5-7) on the costs and benefits of enlargement, and strategic foresight scenarios (WPs 8 and 9), as well as recommendations from WPs 5-7 on how to communicate enlargement narratives in different national and institutional settings. In alignment with CitiSense's threefold framework – *for, with, and by citizens* – the toolbox also includes the recommendations for communication strategies developed in WPs 5-7

¹⁵ Juhola, S. / Käyhkö, J. (2023): Maladaptation as a concept and a metric in national adaptation policy- Should we, would we, could we?, *PLOS Climate*; Umbach, G. (2024): Futures in EU governance: Anticipatory governance, strategic foresight and EU Better Regulation, *European Law Journal*, 30(3).

(D5.3; D6.4; D7.2), informed by public opinion research from WP2-3, and manuals on participatory mechanisms (e.g. Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies) tested in WP3 to engage citizens directly in policymaking processes.

- **A citizen and education toolbox** aimed at civil society organisations, schoolteachers, youth educators, and citizenship education actors (T10.2, D10.2). This toolbox provides comprehensive, user-friendly educational materials – including digital learning modules, and the Citizens' Art Exhibition (T11.13) – designed to foster critical debate, enhance public understanding, and support participatory learning about EU enlargement. CitiSense co-creates these materials with the CitiSense Civil Society Network (T10.5) drawing upon insights from WPs 2-3, 4, 5, 6 and 7 to ensure they address core concerns around democracy, rule of law, identity, security and societal resilience.

To further support the development of these toolkits, WP8 includes:

- The organisation of Youth and Citizens' Labs in cities across EU and non-EU countries (T10.3, D10.3), which serve both as dissemination and co-creation platforms where young people test and respond to CitiSense research outputs and contribute to policy recommendations.
- The compilation of 'Europe Next' (T10.4, D10.4), a collection of concise country reports authored by post-graduate students from the College of Europe and partner institutions. These reports analyse national narratives, reform agendas, and future visions of enlargement based on CitiSense data and offer recommendations to increase societal awareness and strengthen national engagement with the EU's enlargement agenda.

The development of these toolboxes is collaborative and iterative. Insights from WP4 participatory mechanisms (Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies), WPs 8 and 9 foresight scenarios, and continuous consultation with the EU Enlargement Expert Hub (WP11) and CitiSense Civil Society Network (WP10) are integrated throughout the process. To ensure practical relevance and usability, the draft toolboxes are tested and validated in a series of consultation meetings with policymakers, educators, and civil society stakeholders from WPs 1-9. Feedback from these sessions is used to refine content, format, and delivery modes. The final versions of the toolboxes are made available in multiple languages and formats (print, digital, and interactive online resources) through WP11 to ensure maximum accessibility and impact. In sum, the CitiSense toolboxes serve as a central, integrative output of the project – translating research, foresight, and participatory engagement into practical tools and manuals that support transparent communication, inclusive policymaking, and informed public debate on EU enlargement across Europe.

Mapping CitiSense Activities to Key Horizon Call Outcomes

Horizon Call Outcome/Requirement	CitiSense Activity
<i>Policymakers and public administrations are provided with thematic insights on lessons learned from previous enlargements for future policies (focus on democracy...)</i>	Systematic review, synthesis of past enlargements (WPs1,5-7): Provides lessons learned and comparative insights for policymakers. Policy recommendations and toolkits (WP10): Actionable advice based on research findings, tailored for public administrations. Focus on critical acquis chapters (WPs1,5-7).
<i>Societal awareness of the enlargement process is increased (EU and candidate countries), through deeper understanding of political, social, and economic consequences of enlargement vs. non-enlargement...</i>	Public opinion surveys (WP2-3): Capture citizen perceptions and knowledge gaps, comparative CBA in WPs 5-7. Existing/new communication/educational tools (WP4, WP10, WP11): e.g. Youth Labs, Hackathons, art exhibition, Citizen Assemblies, podcasts, Instagram Reels, educational tools for schoolteachers and civil society. Dissemination/engagement strategies (WP11): Reach diverse audiences, including civil society, youth, educators.
<i>EU authorities and public authorities in Member States benefit from better use of existing interactive tools to better inform and promote educational opportunities...</i>	Pilot testing of engagement mechanisms including inter-cultural learning forums (WP4): Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies, (WP11) Art exhibition. Toolboxes for policymakers and educators (WP10): Co-created with civil society, youth, policy-makers, tailored content and recommendations.
<i>Public's ... involvement in enlargement is enhanced through transparent and participatory processes, leveraging digital tools for broader engagement...</i>	Participatory mechanisms (WP4): Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies, both in-person and digital. Deliberative democracy approaches (WP4): Consensus-building, facilitated discussions, secret ballots. Gender and diversity (all WPs): Equitable

	participation in all activities. Continuous feedback loops (WP11): Systematic input from citizens, civil society, experts. Digital engagement tools (WP4, WP11): i.e. Hackathons, Mentimeter, Kahoot!, interactive dashboard, Reels
<i>Support EU citizens and civil society to gain a better understanding of challenges and opportunities related to potential future enlargements...</i>	Socio-historical, legal, and economic research (WPs1,5-7): Deepens understanding of CCs and EU readiness. Comparative analysis (WP1, WPs5-7): Examines drivers, costs, benefits, and reform needs. Citizen-centred approach (all WPs): Research and engagement for, with, and by citizens. Civil Society Network and Expert Hub (WP11): co-creation and validation.
<i>Reflect on previous enlargements, provide thematic insights, identify similarities with candidate countries (democracy, rule of law, governance)...</i>	Lessons learned from past enlargements (WP1, WP, 5, 6,7): Synthesise and apply to current context. Case studies and comparative analysis (WPs 5-7): Identify patterns and policy implications.
<i>Utilise foresight and scenario planning to help EU and Member States anticipate future changes and manage enlargement strategically...</i>	Foresight exercises (WP8-9): Alternative futures scenarios, horizon scanning, trend analysis. Community of Practice approach (WP8-9): Co-creation and validation of foresight outputs.
<i>Conduct comparative analysis of terms and conditions of membership in accession treaties...</i>	Comparative case studies (WPs 5-7): Analyse accession conditions and transition periods. Expert interviews and document analysis (WPs 5-7): Contextualise findings.
<i>Address public support and engagement, consider enlargement fatigue and Euroscepticism...</i>	Surveys and case studies (WP2-3): Measure public support, identify drivers of enlargement fatigue and Euroscepticism. Communication strategies (WPs 5-7, WP10, WP11): Tailored to address concerns and build credibility.
<i>Build concrete knowledge through comparative analysis of motives of candidate countries to join the EU...</i>	Public opinion surveys and focus groups (WP2-3): Identify motivations and perceptions. Comparative analysis (WP1, WPs5-7): Map drivers across countries.
<i>Develop policy recommendations to promote inclusive strategic communication and citizen engagement on EU integration...</i>	Innovative communication tools (WP4, WP11): Digital, participatory, and educational formats. Policy recommendations (WP10): Inclusive, accessible, and actionable. Dissemination strategies (WP11): Reach diverse stakeholders.
<i>Identify effective tools for public administration and policymakers to improve citizens' understanding...</i>	Toolboxes for policymakers and educators (WP10): Co-created, evidence-based, and tested. Pilot testing (WP4): Assess effectiveness of engagement tools.
<i>Leverage emerging digital technologies for communication...</i>	Digital engagement tools (WP4, WP11): i.e. Hackathons, podcasts, social media tools.
<i>Explore how to support the reform process of candidate countries and/or learn from their existing reforms....</i>	Focus on critical acquis chapters (WP1, WPs 5-7): Analyse and propose reforms. Case studies and comparative analysis (WPs 5-7): Identify best practices and challenges.

1.3 Interdisciplinary Dimension

CitiSense is an interdisciplinary consortium of 16 institutional research teams, bringing together a total of 36 researchers (see Part A of the project proposal for names and ORCID IDs) who will collaborate across the project's three-year duration and its ten work packages. While the majority of consortium partners have core expertise in political science and international relations, the project also draws on substantial additional disciplinary strengths, including peace, conflict and security studies, democratisation, diplomacy, econometrics, economics, European law, European studies, history, human rights, political economy, political philosophy, political theory, and public administration. CitiSense systematically integrates socio-historical analysis (WP7), legal and security studies (WP5), economic modelling (WP6), and comparative political science (WPs 1–4, 8,9) into a joint citizen-centred methodology, ensuring that each SSH discipline plays a distinct role in shaping the project's outputs.

The consortium's interdisciplinarity is matched by its breadth of regional expertise, with partners based both within and outside the European Union. Several partners bring direct connections to policy and practitioner networks, including Brussels-based TEPSA and EPD. CitiSense also benefits from deep, context-specific expertise from the EU's neighbourhood. These regionally embedded perspectives ensure that the project's conceptual framework, empirical research, and policy toolkits are fully informed by on-the-ground realities in CCs, reinforcing the project's capacity to produce context-sensitive, actionable recommendations.

1.4. Gender Dimension

Gender considerations will be integrated across all WPs. WP7 will place a key focus on the gender dimension throughout its analysis of societal factors. Gender will also play an essential role in the study of economic (WP6) as well as security (WP5) concerns. Gender issues are important to assess the development of future scenarios for EU enlargement (WP8-9) and the co-creation of a toolkit for both policymakers and educators (WP10). CitiSense will ensure gender-balance in all activities including the composition of its Hackathons and Citizens' Assemblies (WP4), the identification of potential interviewees (WPs 5-7), and the selection of participants for the enlarged CitiSense EU Enlargement Expert Hub (WP11) to prevent male-dominated discussion shaping the project's outputs. For our research outputs, CitiSense scholars will draw from a diverse range of literature to engage with wider subsectors of society and avoid male-dominated literature reviews. Furthermore, the CitiSense project adopts a pro-active gender-sensitive approach across all its research, communication, dissemination and exploitation methodologies. Lastly, the CitiSense consortium represents a gender-balanced team of scholars (16 men, 20 women) with women leading a majority of Work Packages. Building on lessons from Horizon projects such as EMBRACE, SHAPEDEM-EU, and REDEMOS, which have highlighted the gendered dynamics of enlargement reforms and participation, CitiSense integrates gender sensitivity into its data collection and analysis. For example, survey data (WPs 2 and 3) will be disaggregated by gender to identify differences in attitudes towards enlargement, while case studies (WPs 5-7) will systematically examine how gendered experiences shape perceptions of security, economic opportunities, and societal change in MS and CCs. This ensures that gender is systematically embedded in the study of security, economic, and societal dimensions, beyond consortium composition and leadership roles.

1.5 Open Science Practices

CitiSense is fully committed to **upholding Horizon Europe open science standards**, ensuring that research outputs are transparent, accessible, and reusable. The project will **apply FAIR principles** – making data Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, and Re-usable – throughout its lifecycle, as part of its broader management and governance framework (WP12).

All publications – whether scientific articles, datasets, code, or dissemination materials – will be made openly accessible to promote transparency and reproducibility. We will prioritise diamond or gold open access whenever possible and will guarantee at least green open access by sharing preprints in line with copyright agreements. Hybrid publishing models that involve paying article processing fees to subscription-based journals to publish open access will be avoided wherever possible. The European University Institute (coordinator) and Maastricht University will provide guidance on open access routes, support self-archiving, monitor uptake, and deliver training on best practices if needed. Researchers will also be encouraged to use the European Commission's *Open Research Europe* platform.

Data Management Plan (D12.3) – In line with Task 12.2, a detailed first draft Data Management Plan will be prepared for the Kick-off Conference and updated regularly. It will integrate FAIR and open access principles while ensuring personal data protection, compliance with ethics protocols, and respect for intellectual property rights. The plan will specify which datasets will be made public or restricted, outline long-term storage arrangements, and establish a formal Ethics Monitoring Protocol with regular compliance checks.

In applying FAIR principles, CitiSense will prioritise:

1. **Findability** – Assign persistent identifiers to all data types and ensure clear metadata, respecting IPR for collaboratively developed methods and innovations.
2. **Accessibility** – Share open data via the CitiSense project website and trusted repositories such as Cadmus at the EUI, adhering to 'as open as possible, as closed as necessary.'

3. **Interoperability** – Use standardised formats and shared vocabularies to promote compatibility and cross-disciplinary reuse.
4. **Reusability** – Provide thorough documentation, licensing information, and adherence to relevant community standards.

These open science practices are embedded in the project's management, ethics monitoring, and quality assurance processes under WP12, ensuring that outputs are accessible and valuable to the research community, policymakers, and civil society. Moreover, the researchers involved in CitiSense have a traceable record of adhering to FAIR practices.

While the proposal emphasised open science and FAIR data principles, we acknowledge that the governance of intellectual property and result ownership can be described more explicitly.

CitiSense will fully regulate intellectual property rights (IPR), access rights, ownership, and exploitation conditions in the Consortium Agreement (CA), which will be finalised and signed by all partners prior to the project start date. The CA will follow Horizon Europe Model Grant Agreement provisions and established DESCA principles to ensure clarity, legal certainty, and compliance with EU rules.

Ownership of results will follow the standard Horizon Europe principle that results are owned by the beneficiary that generates them. Where results are jointly generated and the respective contributions cannot be separated, joint ownership will apply, with detailed joint ownership arrangements defined in writing. The Consortium Agreement will specify procedures for identifying jointly generated results and regulating their protection, exploitation, and potential revenue-sharing mechanisms, where relevant.

Foreground results will be systematically identified at work package level and reported to the Steering Committee. Each Work Package Leader will ensure that potentially protectable results (e.g., digital tools, survey instruments, methodological toolkits, educational materials, dashboards, or software components) are flagged early and assessed for appropriate protection measures. Decisions regarding protection versus open dissemination will be taken collectively in line with Horizon Europe obligations and the project's open science commitments.

Access rights between beneficiaries will be governed by clearly defined conditions in the CA, ensuring that partners have royalty-free access to results and background necessary for implementing the action. Access rights for exploitation will be defined according to Horizon Europe standards and may include fair and reasonable conditions where appropriate.

Given the nature of CitiSense as an SSH project with a strong open science orientation, most scientific outputs, datasets (appropriately anonymised), and policy toolkits are expected to be made openly accessible.

The Project Management Plan will include a dedicated section on Intellectual Property Governance outlining procedures for result identification, ownership documentation, access rights management, dispute resolution, and compliance monitoring. The Steering Committee will oversee implementation, and the Coordinator will ensure that IPR matters are regularly reviewed during reporting periods

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2. **Impact** #@IMP-ACT-IA@#

2.1 **Project's Pathways Towards Impact**

CitiSense achieves impact *for, with and by citizens* by translating research on security, economic and social consequences of enlargement into co-created tools, dialogues, and policy recommendations. It responds directly to the Horizon Europe Cluster 2 priority – '**Enhancing Democracy and Governance**' – by generating actionable knowledge, participatory frameworks, and adaptive tools that support inclusive, citizen-centred policymaking in times of geopolitical disruption, democratic backsliding, and social polarisation. CitiSense's impact strategy is

explicitly structured around the Horizon call's expected outcomes and scope. It targets three main groups of actors: citizens and civil society organisations (CSOs), policymakers and public administrations, and the research/educational community across MS and (potential) CCs. This focus ensures that impact is directly aligned with the call's ambition to prepare all actors for a flexible and adaptive enlargement approach, ensuring that lessons learned, participatory inputs, and foresight analyses are translated into strategies that remain viable under shifting geopolitical, economic, and societal conditions, while supporting the development of local and regional initiatives led by CSOs. CitiSense ensures the continuity of impactful tools from previous Horizon projects and is engineered for sustainability, its impact designed to extend well beyond the project's duration, building a foundation for long-term democratic engagement, strategic foresight, and evidence-based enlargement policy.

2.1.1 Unique Contribution to Outcomes and Wider Impacts

Scientific Contribution. CitiSense will generate a comparative, empirically grounded knowledge base on the security, economic, and societal effects of enlargement and non-enlargement, both real and perceived, drawing on historical precedents and current challenges. It advances interdisciplinary research on democratic resilience through the CitiSense analytical framework, contributing to both citizen-centred theoretical foundations and the creation of participatory 'sense-making' methodologies. The open-access knowledge generated – via structured synthesis (WP1), data collection through public opinion surveys (WPs 2 and 3), scenario-building (WPs 8 and 9), and cost-benefit modelling (WPs 5-7) – will feed into both policy and academic debates, producing actionable knowledge for political scientists, economists, legal scholars, and practitioners.

Societal Impact. CitiSense empowers citizens – particularly the youth – in EU MS and CCs to participate meaningfully in the enlargement process. The CitiSense civil society-focused toolbox includes 14 Youth Labs, participatory pilots (Democracy Hackathons, Citizen Assemblies), educational materials, podcasts, and accessible visual media. By fostering public understanding of the enlargement's real-world consequences, the project counters misunderstanding of its effects, reduces Euroscepticism, and improves public trust in democratic institutions. CitiSense builds on and scales up proven formats such as the Civil Society Network, EU Enlargement Expert Hub and Youth Labs (initiated in InvigoratEU), Citizens' Art Exhibition (RECLAIM), and gender mainstreaming practices (EMBRACE, SHAPEDEM-EU). These formats are adapted, tested in new contexts, and integrated into the CitiSense toolboxes to ensure their direct transferability to policymakers, CSOs, and educators in MS and (potential) CCs.

Policy Impact. The policy-focused toolbox provides public authorities (administrators and decision-makers) with co-created, empirically tested recommendations for institutional reform, rule of law enhancement, acquis compliance (Chapters 10, 23, 24, 34), and communication strategies. CitiSense validates outputs with policymakers via the TEPSA EU Enlargement Expert Hub, TEPSA's policy dialogues, and targeted engagement with DG ENEST, EEAS, and national ministries. Participatory foresight tools enable decision-makers to adapt enlargement strategies to geopolitical conditions, such as Russian aggression or transatlantic shifts. By tailoring recommendations across MS and (potential) CCs, the toolbox supports differentiated yet coherent strategies as cornerstones of a flexible and adaptive enlargement approach.

Expected Outcome	CitiSense Impact Pathways (Examples)
<i>Thematic insights for policymakers and administrators on democracy, rule of law, and governance</i>	WPs 5-7 provide policy recommendations based on lessons from past enlargements (Southern, Eastern) on democratic reform and institutional adaptation. Policy toolboxes (WP10) deliver user friendly recommendations. Participatory foresight scenarios (WP8-9) help policymakers test responses to geopolitical shocks. Dissemination via the EU Enlargement Expert Hub and TEPSA's Pre-Presidency Conferences targets EU and national institutions (WP11).
<i>Increased societal awareness of the enlargement process</i>	WPs 2 and 3 collect and analyses public opinion data on enlargement attitudes and the sources for misconceptions. WPs 5-7 produce cost-benefit analyses of enlargement vs. non-enlargement, framed for public use. Public-facing outputs include a Digital Guidebook ('30 FAQs on Enlargement') (WP10), Instagram

	Reels, and podcasts (WP11). Youth Labs and Citizen Assemblies stimulate grassroots understanding and dialogue.
<i>Better use of interactive tools to promote educational opportunities</i>	WP10's educator toolbox provides manuals, classroom resources, and digital learning modules. WP4 participatory formats (Youth Labs) serve as living labs for civic and political education. Partnership with Erasmus+ and education ministries supports institutional uptake. Outputs are designed for reuse by teachers, lecturers, and youth leaders beyond the project also using popular online tools (Mentimeter, Kahoot!)
<i>Enhanced public involvement through participatory and digital engagement</i>	14 Youth Labs, Democracy Hackathons, and Citizen Assemblies engage diverse citizens directly in shaping enlargement narratives (WPs 4,10). WP7-8's participatory foresight tools invite citizens to co-create scenarios and test future policy options. Digital engagement via social media, podcasts, and regional broadcast partnerships ensures broad reach. Communication experts and journalists included in the CitiSense Advisory Board and the EU Enlargement Expert Hub provide continuous feedback to tailor content to underserved demographics, enhancing inclusivity.

2.1.2 Identification of Three Main Target Groups During and Beyond CitiSense's Lifetime

1. Policy Community. CitiSense targets a broad spectrum of policy actors at EU, national, and regional levels, including public administrations, institutional stakeholders, and elected officials across MS and (potential) CCs. These actors are engaged through structured co-creation and evidence-sharing mechanisms, notably in the development of the Toolbox for Policymakers (D10.1), which provides actionable, evidence-based recommendations on institutional reform, acquis compliance (especially Chapters 10, 23, 24, and 34), and communication strategies on enlargement. The toolbox synthesises insights from cross-cutting analyses in D5.1-D5.3 (security), D6.1-D6.4 (economic), and D7.1-D7.2 (societal impacts). Structured engagement takes place via the EU Enlargement Expert Hub (WP11/T11.2) and is supported by D11.2 (Recommendations Digest) and D11.3 (Digest of Public-Oriented Communications Products), ensuring sustained dialogue with key actors including DG ENEST, the European External Action Service (EEAS), and national ministries. The TEPSA network, comprising 49 members across 37 countries, facilitates wide dissemination of CitiSense outputs among policy makers and public administrations in each MS and CC and supports exchanges through events such as the TEPSA Pre-Presidency Conferences (e.g. in Vilnius 2026). In addition, the Policy Paper on Alternative Future Scenarios (D9.1) and the Policy Paper on Differentiated (Dis)Integration (D8.1) help policymakers anticipate geopolitical developments and stress-test enlargement strategies, while policy papers on motivations for support (D1.3) and key chapter reform processes (D1.4) contribute specific, comparative insights on reform trajectories and motivation dynamics. Scenario exercises explicitly test how enlargement can remain adaptive across different country categories (MS, CCs), offering policymakers flexible pathways to manage uncertainty while retaining credibility and public trust. The project's Communications and Dissemination Plan (D11.1) ensures that outputs are shared strategically with EU institutions, MS, and relevant policy platforms.

2. Civil Society, Citizens, Teachers, Lecturers, Students, and Young Professionals. CitiSense prioritises inclusive, multigenerational engagement by involving educators, youth, and organised civil society both as knowledge contributors and dissemination multipliers. The project conducts 14 Youth Labs in MS and CCs (D10.3) and participatory pilots such as Democracy Hackathons and Citizen Assemblies (D4.1, D4.2) across four EU MS, generating bottom-up input for the research process and validation of the Toolbox for Education and Civil Society (D10.2). Targeted outreach includes a training seminar in Brussels for early-career diplomats, civil servants, and civil society actors, and the provision of accessible materials such as the '*30 FAQs on Enlargement*', integrated into D10.2. The Policy Paper on Citizen Engagement Tools (D4.3) offers guidance on deploying these mechanisms beyond the project. Public engagement is further amplified through digital formats including Instagram Reels, podcasts, and an art exhibition (part of D11.3). The CitiSense Civil Society Network and partners like TEPSA, EPD and IDSCS ensure outreach to underrepresented communities in EU decision-making and democratic support organisations across Europe. Inclusivity is monitored throughout, in line with partners' Gender Equality Plans, and reinforced in all public-oriented deliverables.

While several engagement formats, such as the Youth Labs, involve carefully curated groups of participants, their scale must be assessed within the project's layered impact architecture.

Over the project's duration, at least ten partner institutions will implement Youth Labs in their respective countries. Each lab will involve approximately 20-30 participants, resulting in an estimated ~300 direct participants across EU member states and candidate countries. These participants will include students, early-career professionals, civil-society actors, and policy-engaged stakeholders, ensuring diversity of perspective and national representation.

Beyond direct participation, each implementing partner is embedded within broader institutional and civil-society ecosystems. Most partner universities and organisations maintain active networks ranging from several hundred to several thousand members, including alumni communities, civil-society networks, and professional associations. Dissemination of outputs through these networks is expected to extend indirect reach to several thousand additional individuals across Europe and candidate countries.

The project will produce a suite of open-access deliverables, including teaching toolkits, civil-society guidance materials, short country reports, and policy briefs. These materials will be disseminated via:

- institutional websites of all consortium partners,
- EU-level academic and policy networks,
- mailing lists with established subscriber bases (often ranging from 500-5,000 recipients per partner),
- social media channels,
- partner communication infrastructures.

Assuming conservative dissemination rates, the cumulative online reach of these materials is expected to exceed 10,000-20,000 individuals over the project lifetime, particularly given the combined communication capacities of ten or more European institutions.

In addition, the project establishes a structured Civil Society Network (CSN), coordinated at EU level, bringing together organisations from member states and candidate countries. Even if initial formal participation remains limited (e.g. 25-40 core organisations), each participating organisation typically represents or connects to significantly broader constituencies at national level. This multiplier logic substantially amplifies impact beyond the immediate project participants.

Engagement activities are also strategically connected to EU-level policy discussions and national enlargement debates. Policy briefs and country reports will be shared directly with relevant national ministries, EU institutions, and Brussels-based networks, ensuring that outputs reach decision-makers and expert communities in addition to civil-society actors.

Rather than relying on single large-scale public events with limited follow-up, CitiSense prioritises sustained engagement, institutional embedding, and multiplier effects. This design ensures that civil-society impact is not only measurable in participant numbers but durable, networked, and policy-relevant.

3. Research Community. CitiSense contributes to cutting-edge research on democracy, EU governance, and enlargement through open access publications, cross-project integration, and the FAIR handling of data. Core outputs for this group include the Research Report on Conceptual and Methodological Framework (D1.1), the Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement (D1.2), and the Synthesis of Key Findings (D1.5). The project aligns with and builds upon previous research conducted in Horizon Europe projects such as EMBRACE, InvigoratEU, and SHAPEDEM-EU. Scholarly outputs are disseminated via academic events in which the consortium partners are active and hold leadership roles (e.g. Council for European Studies [CES], European Union Studies Association [EUSA], European Consortium for Political Research [ECPR], the University Association for Contemporary European Studies [UACES]), TEPSA's research network, and the IDSCS THINK-BALKANS network. TEPSA also oversees targeted dissemination to academic stakeholders (T11.14). Scientific insights are consolidated in the Policy Papers and Research Reports across WPs 2-9, including D3.1 (Drivers and Obstacles of Support), D5.2 (Research

Report: Security Lessons from Previous Enlargements), D6.3 (Socio-Economic Perceptions), and D7.1 (Societal Impacts). The project ensures transparency and traceability through a comprehensive Data Management Plan (D12.2) and reporting through D12.3 (Conference Reports).

2.1.3 Scale and Significance of Impact

Scale.

- **Policy Community Reach:** The project will engage at least 1,000 policymakers during implementation, with further diffusion via 21 policy papers, 4 workshops, and national-level dissemination partners through TEPSA's 49 member institutes in 37 countries, EPD's democracy network, and the IDSCS THINK-BALKANS network. This ensures that outputs are systematically communicated not only in Brussels but also directly to national administrations and policymakers in every MS and (potential) CCs, multiplying the project's reach and impact.
- **Civil Society Engagement:** The 14 Youth Labs (~300 participants), 2 Democracy Hackathons (~60 participants), and 2 Citizen Assemblies (~40 Participants) are expected to directly involve over 400 citizens, including at least 50% youth (under 30) and 50% women or non-binary participants. Dissemination through schools and universities can reach an additional 10,000 learners over five years. Structuring engagement across MS and (potential) CCs ensures that citizens in all three categories co-create knowledge and tools. To achieve impact at scale, CitiSense explicitly treats its participatory pilots as scalable prototypes. The most successful formats, e.g. Youth Labs, Hackathons, and educational toolboxes, are designed for future EU-level funding and expansion. For example, findings can inform the design of high-school exchanges, cross-border civic initiatives, and EU-funded participatory programmes between MS and CCs. By piloting, testing, and evaluating these tools, CitiSense paves the way for their application on a significantly larger scale, with corresponding resources, thereby multiplying their long-term impact.
- **Digital & Media Impact:** With coordinated dissemination (including via the CitiSense dedicated website) through consortium partners' platforms (projected audience: >250,000 followers across social media), podcasts, and multilingual FAQs, the project aims to reach a cumulative audience of >1 million during and after implementation.
- **Scientific Reach:** Open-access publications, joint workshops, a dedicated ECPR 'The Loop' Enlargement Blog Series (already launched by the EUI CitiSense coordinator, with an audience of >1000 readers per post) and panels at ECPR, CES, EUSA, UACES, and other academic events will ensure integration into academic debates, with targeted outputs for high-impact journals and research infrastructure reuse. An in-principal agreement to publish 'Europe Next' has already been secured with 'Agenda Publishing', an award-winning publisher focused on making complex academic ideas accessible to a wider audience.

Significance.

- **Policy Impact:** Empirical insights from WPs 5-7 and WP8-9 will inform future EU-level decisions on staged accession, rule of law benchmarking, and strategic communication, potentially shaping up enlargement dossiers (Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia, Western Balkans).
- **Civic Impact:** Project interventions aim to increase civic understanding of enlargement by >30% in pre/post engagement assessments, and to foster youth participation in at least 10 follow-up initiatives beyond the project's lifetime, guaranteed by the continuous activity of consortium partners also selected for their long-lasting activities with citizen-facing projects.
- **Educational Legacy:** Learning materials developed for schools and universities are designed to remain in circulation beyond the project, with partners committing to maintain access to educational content for a minimum of 5 years post-project. The Edited Collection of Short Country Reports ('Europe Next'), involving College of Europe faculty (consortium contributors and work-package leads) and post-graduate students will serve to transfer and co-create CitiSense knowledge to at least 25 future EU leaders.

2.1.4 Requirements, External Risks, and Mitigation Strategies

Potential External Barriers: CitiSense may face external barriers linked to regulatory, institutional, and societal change. Shifts in enlargement policy at EU level, such as treaty reform or political crises, could affect the uptake of recommendations. To mitigate this risk, the project integrates foresight tools in WPs 7 and 8 and applies agile policy

stress-testing to accommodate dynamic policy shifts. Another barrier lies in public opinion volatility, where rising national-populism or geopolitical shocks may reduce public receptivity to enlargement narratives. This is addressed through WPs 2 and 3's real-time opinion tracking and the adaptive messaging strategies developed in WP10, which together allow for responsive framing and tailored communication. Limited digital or media access for digitally excluded or marginalised groups also presents a challenge. To address this, the consortium partners with journalists through the CitiSense EU Enlargement Expert Hub and the Advisory Board, which includes a communication expert from the European Commission and a journalist from L1, a Dutch regional TV and radio channel. These partnerships ensure outreach in selected regional and local contexts. In addition, WPs 2, 3 and 6 specifically target subnational audiences in Eastern European member states and in Ukraine, while all consortium partners remain responsible for legacy media outreach in their respective national contexts (T11.10). Communication experts from governments also contribute specialised knowledge in devising government communication strategies that are accessible and actionable for local authorities and the broader public.

Dependencies and Assumptions: The project assumes a continued institutional and political commitment to enlargement within the EU and candidate countries. It also assumes sustained cooperation with EU institutions, notably DG ENEST, EEAS, and national governments. Finally, it relies on the establishment of baseline measures of civic trust, engagement, and enlargement support in WPs 2 and 3 (surveys and media analysis), with post-intervention benchmarks collected to assess delta effects.

Environmental Impact: CitiSense does not anticipate negative environmental effects. To minimise its environmental footprint, CitiSense will organise all consortium and Work Package coordination meetings online or in hybrid format. Where travel or printed material is required, such as the kick-off and final conferences, the project will adhere to green procurement and carbon offsetting guidelines in line with the best practices set forward by the Marie Skłodowska-Curie Actions (MSCA) Green Charter.

CitiSense adopts a structured and operationalised risk management framework to ensure that impact pathways remain robust, adaptive and measurable throughout the project lifecycle. While the proposal identified key strategic risks, the Project Management Plan specifies concrete mitigation measures, monitoring mechanisms, and responsibility allocation for each risk category to ensure effective implementation.

Risk management is embedded in the governance architecture of the project and overseen by the Steering Committee, chaired by the Coordinator and Scientific Lead. Risks are reviewed at six-month intervals and additionally prior to key milestones, such as large-scale survey launches, participatory pilots, or toolbox dissemination phases. Each work package leader is responsible for monitoring domain-specific risks and reporting deviations early.

For risks related to low participation in surveys or participatory mechanisms, mitigation measures include pre-testing recruitment strategies, contracting established survey providers with replacement sampling capacity, activating partner networks for targeted outreach, and extending recruitment periods where necessary. If response rates fall below predefined representativeness thresholds, additional sampling waves or supplementary outreach strategies will be implemented. These procedures are pre-authorised in the project timeline and budget planning.

For risks concerning limited engagement from policymakers or public administrations, mitigation measures include early-stage stakeholder mapping, formal letters of engagement prior to major events, leveraging the TEPSA network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub to secure institutional buy-in, and scheduling dissemination events to coincide with relevant EU policy cycles. Where in-person engagement is constrained, hybrid and digital consultation formats will be activated to ensure continuity.

In the event of geopolitical disruption affecting Candidate Countries, the project will implement adaptive data collection strategies, including remote interviews, digital participatory formats, and, if necessary, temporary re-sequencing of fieldwork activities without compromising comparative integrity. A contingency buffer in the timeline allows for such adjustments.

To mitigate risks related to dissemination uptake or limited societal reach, WP9 applies measurable outreach indicators, including participation numbers, social media engagement metrics, download statistics for toolboxes, and feedback surveys from Youth Labs and civil society actors. If engagement indicators fall below projected benchmarks, additional targeted campaigns and partner-led amplification strategies will be activated.

Data-related risks, including GDPR compliance, anonymisation errors, or data loss, are addressed through encrypted storage systems, access-controlled repositories, regular backup protocols, and oversight under the Ethics Monitoring Protocol. Survey providers and research partners must comply with contractual data protection clauses.

All mitigation measures are linked to responsible actors, predefined triggers, and review intervals. Deviations from planned impact pathways are documented in internal progress reports and, where relevant, corrective measures are communicated in periodic reporting to the Commission.

2.2 Measures to maximise impact-dissemination, exploitation and communication #@COM-DIS-VIS-CDV@#

CitiSense adopts a comprehensive dissemination and communication strategy that targets policymakers, civil society, educators, the research community, and the general public across both EU MS and CCs. Communication efforts will begin from Month 1 with the creation of the website and its coordinated promotion across all partners and will continue throughout the lifespan of the project. These will highlight CitiSense's contributions to democratic resilience, policy reform, youth engagement, and strategic foresight. Key messages will emphasise the value of inclusive, transparent, and participatory enlargement processes and the tangible security, economic, and societal stakes involved. This section presents the first version of CitiSense's Dissemination and Exploitation Plan, outlining strategic measures to maximise scientific, societal, and policy impact during and beyond the project. A detailed version will be submitted as D9.1 within six months and updated regularly. The communication strategy is segmented by region (MS, CCs, potential CCs) and by target type (policymakers, administrations, CSOs, youth, media), ensuring tailored messages for each audience.

Policy-Oriented Outputs

- **Policy Papers:** CitiSense will produce 21 policy papers across WPs 1-9, synthesising key trends, challenges, and actionable policy options for EU enlargement and resilience. These papers will distil research findings into accessible, evidence-based recommendations for policymakers across the EU and CCs. (D1.2, D1.3, D1.4, D3.2, D4.3, D5.1, D5.3, D6.1, D6.2, D6.4, D7.2, D8.1, D8.1, D10.3, T11.5/D11.2)
- **Toolbox for Policymakers:** Includes foresight-based scenario modelling and institutional pathways developed through T8.2 and summarised in D8.1, and provides context-sensitive, co-created policy recommendations validated with stakeholders through the Expert Hub. Strategic recommendations and practical tools are compiled in D10.1.
- **Digital Guidebook '30 FAQs on Enlargement':** A user-friendly digital guide providing accessible, context-sensitive responses, co-created in WP8 and disseminated via D10.1.
- **Podcasts and Multimedia Dissemination:** A series of six podcasts featuring researchers and policymakers to communicate key insights to a broad audience. Produced and promoted under T11.9, with outputs included in D11.3.
- **Biannual Observatory on EU Enlargement:** A mailing list and observatory based on the EU Enlargement Expert Hub to distribute updates and outputs to the CitiSense Expert Hub and external stakeholders. Activities captured under T11.2.
- **Synthesis of Key Findings:** D1.5 brings together findings across work packages, providing recommendations for policymakers aligned with governance and communication strategies. Developed under T1.5.

Expert Forums and Strategic Engagement

- **EU Enlargement Expert Hub:** Facilitates continuous exchange between researchers and over 100 policy stakeholders from day one. Developed and managed under T11.2.

- **Strategic Foresight Workshops:** Multi-stakeholder exercises (T8.2) assessing future signals and trajectories. Contributions feed into D8.1.
- **Closed-Door Policy Meetings:** Six meetings hosted in Brussels, linking policymakers with researchers.
- **Training Seminar for Young Professionals:** One seminar in Brussels providing early-career participants with practical experience and policy training. Structured under T11.4.
- **High-Profile Conference Panels:** Panels organised at international academic and policy forums, including contributions to two TEPSA Pre-Presidency Conferences (e.g. in Vilnius 2026). Reported under T11.3.
- **National Policy Briefings:** Policy recommendations discussed in decentralised fashion in four MS. Covered under T11.6.
- **Public Panel Discussions:** Two cross-project events focused on democracy, rule of law, and governance. Coordinated under T11.3.
- **Democracy Dialogue:** Brussels-based workshop drawing lessons from WP4 on citizen engagement, contributing to D4.2 under T4.4.

Civil Society-Oriented Outputs

- **Education & Civil Society Toolbox:** This toolbox provides tailored resources for educators and civil society organisations, including digital learning modules, manuals on participatory tools and democratic mechanisms (e.g., Youth Labs, Hackathons), and youth-targeted educational materials. These co-created materials are validated by the CitiSense Civil Society Network and designed to make EU enlargement policies accessible and actionable for audiences with varying levels of digital literacy and policy familiarity (T10.2, T10.5, D10.2).
- **Citizen's Art Exhibition – 'Framing an EU with 30+ Members':** This participatory cultural initiative invites citizens across EU and CCs to submit artworks, including photography, poetry, audiovisual, and performance, reflecting on the future of an enlarged EU. The exhibition will take place at Maastricht town hall and includes a collective workshop and contest, with selected contributors invited to the final CitiSense conference. Outputs will be featured in digital formats and promoted via social media platforms such as Instagram Reels (T11.13).
- **Digital and Multimedia Outputs:** CitiSense will develop a suite of innovative materials to amplify public understanding of enlargement. These include infographics and animated videos presenting key messages, short participatory Instagram Reels enabling citizen-researcher interaction, and a targeted social media survey to crowdsource public sentiment on enlargement scenarios (T11.8, T11.11, T11.12).
- **Publication 'Europe Next':** This edited collection presents short, accessible country reports based on CitiSense data and insights. Written by College of Europe postgraduate students and designed for broad resonance – including with rural communities and older generations – this publication aims to bridge the gap between policy and research, as well as train future EU leaders on CitiSense generated knowledge (T10.4, D10.4).
- **Citizen Engagement Tools:** CitiSense tests and documents citizen engagement mechanisms through Hackathons and Citizen Assemblies. These activities are underpinned by the systematic use of emerging digital technologies, including online deliberation platforms, interactive polling tools, and virtual collaboration environments (e.g. Mentimeter/Kahoot!). In this way, CitiSense not only extends participation to geographically dispersed citizens but also pilots scalable digital methods that can be mainstreamed in future EU engagement practices. The resulting reports outline methods, lessons, and recommendations for civil society stakeholders to replicate or adapt in different contexts (T4.1, T4.2, D4.1, D4.3).
- **Participatory Scenario Testing Workshops:** Two strategic foresight workshops involve citizens and civil society actors in co-designing future scenarios for EU enlargement, contributing directly to the project's strategic analysis (T8.2, D8.1).

Forums for Exchange with Civil Society and the General Public

- **CitiSense Civil Society Network:** Ongoing engagement with civil society actors, ensuring feedback and dissemination of key outputs. Coordinated under T10.5.
- **Youth Labs:** 14 Labs across Europe engaging young people in interactive workshops, captured in D10.3 under T10.3. These include Youth Labs in: Bratislava (Slovakia), Brussels (Belgium), Budapest (Hungary), Chişinău (Moldova), Duisburg (Germany), Florence (Italy), Kyiv (Ukraine), Maastricht (Netherlands), Rome (Italy), Skopje (North Macedonia), Stockholm (Sweden), Tbilisi (Georgia), Tallinn (Estonia), and Warsaw (Poland).

- **Participatory Pilots:** Citizen Assemblies and Hackathons in four EU MS, delivering inclusive and deliberative engagement (D4.1, D4.3).
- **Practitioner Briefings:** WP4 briefings transferring citizen-led insights to national-level stakeholders in four EU countries: France, Germany, Belgium, and Czechia. Contribute to D4.2 under T4.3.
- **Strategic Foresight Cycles:** Participatory exercises in scenario creation and backcasting for enlargement futures. Linked to D8.1, T8.2.
- **Citizen-Facing Campaigns:** Dissemination of findings and engagement through op-eds, public events, and social media. Tracked in T11.3, T11.10, T11.11, T11.12, T11.13.

Scientific Outputs

- **Academic Publications:** CitiSense researchers will systematically transform project findings into academic articles, targeting prominent peer-reviewed journals in political science, European studies, law, and related disciplines. Each work package will contribute to this effort: WP1 will produce a conceptual framework paper (T1.1, D1.1); WP2 will generate a research report based on public opinion and survey experiment data (T3.1, D3.1); WP4 will produce research on the security implications of enlargement (T5.1-T5.3, D5.2); WP5 will deliver economic cost-benefit studies and analyses of regional inclusion and exclusion (T6.1-T6.4, D6.3); WP7 will focus on the societal impacts and social cohesion dimensions (T7.1-T7.2, D7.1); and WP8-9 will contribute foresight and scenario analysis papers on differentiated integration and future trajectories (T8.1-T9.2, D8.1). All outputs will be open access, in English, and made available through the CitiSense project website, enabling the tracking of citations and public downloads.
- **Methodological reflection paper on citizen participation tools**, based on pilots in WP4 (T4.3, D4.3).
- **Scholarly contributions on differentiated integration and enlargement logics** drawn from WP1 (T1.2, D1.3, D1.4, D1.5) and WP8-9's scenario analysis and stakeholder feedback (T8.1, T9.1, D8.1, D9.1).
- **New Datasets:** CitiSense will produce and publicly release several new datasets to maximise scientific impact and reusability. These will include:
 - **Public Opinion Survey Data** collected across selected EU MS (Estonia, Slovenia, the Netherlands, France, Spain) and CCs (Moldova, Ukraine, North Macedonia, Serbia), providing robust, comparative data on citizen attitudes towards enlargement and its impacts (T2.2, T2.3, T2.4, D2.1).
 - **Survey experiment data** on communication strategies and attitudinal shifts in support for enlargement (T2.3, T3.1, T3.2, D2.1, D3.1).
 - **Cost-Benefit Analysis Data** on security, economic, and societal dimensions of enlargement, derived from quantitative and qualitative analyses in WPs 5,6 and 7 (T5.1, T6.1, T7.2; D5.1, D6.1, D7.1).
 - **Expert interview data** from WP1 and WP5, capturing strategic and institutional perspectives across countries (T1.3, T5.1).
 - **Participatory Engagement Data** from Youth Labs, Hackathons, and focus groups, capturing citizen input and deliberative outcomes (T4.1, T4.2, T10.3; D4.1, D4.3, D10.3).
 - **Foresight and Scenario Data** from WP9, supporting future research on EU integration and enlargement (T9.1, T9.2, D9.1).
- **Toolboxes:** The project will develop and disseminate two multidimensional toolboxes, one for policymakers and one for civil society and educational stakeholders, documenting best practices, recommendations, and innovative engagement methods. These will be published as open-access resources and serve as reference materials for both academic and policy communities (T10.1, T10.2, D10.1, D10.2).

Expert Forums for Scientific Exchange

- **CitiSense Mid-Term Conference:** A mid-term conference will be organised to foster collaboration among consortium members, present preliminary findings, and engage with relevant stakeholders. This event is part of the major project conferences outlined in T11.7 and reported in D12.3.
- **Brussels Final Conference:** The project will culminate in a high-profile final conference in Brussels, where CitiSense's conclusions, policy recommendations, and toolkits will be presented to policymakers, academics,

and civil society representatives. The event will include panel discussions, workshops, and networking sessions to maximise the uptake and impact of project results. Also part of T11.7 and included in D12.3.

- **Regular Consortium and Advisory Board Meetings:** CitiSense will hold regular consortium meetings and engage with an Advisory Board composed of leading experts in EU studies, policy, and civil society. These are coordinated under T11.1 and contribute to strategic oversight reported in D12.3.
- **Engagement with the European Commission and Joint Research Centre (JRC):** The consortium will maintain regular exchanges with the European Commission's JRC and relevant DGs, particularly on strategic foresight, policy analysis, and data sharing. These interactions ensure alignment with EU policy debates and inform foresight outputs developed under T9.2 and coordination efforts under T11.1.
- **Participation in Academic Conferences and Workshops:** CitiSense researchers will actively participate in leading academic conferences (such as APSA, CES, ECPR, EISA, EUSA, ISA, and UACES), presenting project findings and co-organizing panels with other Horizon Europe consortia. These dissemination activities are embedded in T11.14 and reflected in D11.3.
- **Virtual Workshops and Cross-Work-Package Collaboration:** In addition to physical events, CitiSense will organise virtual workshops and cross-work-package working sessions (e.g. M18, M24, M30, M36) to foster methodological innovation and interdisciplinary synthesis. These collaborative forums are part of T1.5, T9.2, T11.1, and T12.3.

#§COM-DIS-VIS-CDV§#

2.3 Summary

Provide a summary of this section by presenting in the canvas below the key elements of your project impact pathway and of the measures to maximise its impact.

KEY ELEMENT OF THE IMPACT SECTION

SPECIFIC NEEDS

What are the specific needs that triggered this project?

EU enlargement policy lacks **citizen-centred tools** to assess and communicate its economic, societal, and security impacts. Existing approaches rely heavily on elite-driven, technocratic models that fail to reflect **public concerns or account for geopolitical volatility, democratic backsliding, and rising Euroscepticism**. At the same time, there is no **integrated framework to engage citizens, educators, and civil society in shaping and validating enlargement strategies** – undermining both policy credibility and democratic resilience.

EXPECTED RESULTS

What do you expect to generate by the end of the project?

CitiSense will generate **multidimensional toolboxes** for policymakers, educators, and civil society, including:

- (1) evidence-based policy recommendations on EU enlargement's security, economic, and societal impacts;
- (2) tailored communication strategies to promote effective framing and enhance public trust;
- (3) participatory foresight scenarios for enlargement futures;
- (4) citizen engagement tools such as Youth Labs, Hackathons, and Citizen Assemblies;
- (5) open-access datasets on public opinion and cost-benefit analyses;
- (6) a suite of educational resources and multimedia outputs to strengthen democratic resilience and promote inclusive public debate on enlargement across the EU and CCs.

D & E & C MEASURES

What dissemination, exploitation and communication measures will you apply to the results?

Exploitation:

Use of the policy and education toolboxes by EU institutions, national policymakers, educators, and civil society. Uptake through university modules, youth training seminar, and democratic resilience programmes. Open-access datasets and foresight tools will support future research and policy design on EU enlargement.

Dissemination:

Academic publications, policy papers, and datasets shared via the project website, peer-reviewed journals, and major conferences (e.g. ECPR, TEPSA Pre-Presidency Conferences). Outputs will be circulated through the EU Enlargement Expert Hub and Civil Society Network, and featured in the 'Europe Next' country report collection, podcasts.

Communication:

Project website, social media channels, and a recognisable visual identity. Public engagement through Youth Labs, Hackathons, and a participatory art exhibition. Infographics, Instagram Reels, and podcasts will translate findings into accessible formats for citizens, especially youth and underrepresented groups.

TARGET GROUPS

Who will use or further up-take the results of the project? Who will benefit from the results of the project?

Policy community: Policymakers, advisors, and civil servants at EU, national, and regional levels (e.g. DG ENEST, EEAS, national ministries).

Civil society and educators: Organised civil society in EU MS and CCs, participants in the CitiSense Civil Society Network, schoolteachers, university lecturers, and civic educators.

Young professionals and students: Early-career diplomats, civil society actors, and university students engaged through Youth Labs and training seminar.

Citizens: Especially youth and digitally excluded communities reached via public campaigns, citizen assemblies, and participatory events.

Research community: Academics, think tanks, and data users in the fields of EU enlargement, democracy, governance, and strategic foresight.

OUTCOMES

What change do you expect to see after successful dissemination and exploitation of project results to the target group(s)?

The uptake of the CitiSense toolboxes by EU institutions, national ministries, and educators will lead to **improved policy communication, better-informed enlargement strategies, and enhanced institutional preparedness for future accessions**. Policymakers will use scenario-tested recommendations and foresight tools to support decision-making under conditions of geopolitical uncertainty.

Activities targeting citizens, civil society, teachers, and young professionals will result in **greater public awareness of the security, economic, and social implications of enlargement**, and promote citizen engagement in democratic life across EU and CCs.

The project's **scientific outputs** – including open-access datasets, methodological frameworks, and scholarly publications – will be widely cited and reused in future academic research, policy analysis, and civic education initiatives, helping to shape debates on the EU's future and its role in supporting democratic resilience.

IMPACTS

What are the expected wider scientific, economic and societal effects of the project contributing to the expected impacts outlined in the respective destination in the work programme?

Scientific: CitiSense will advance the state of the art in research on EU enlargement, democratic resilience, and participatory governance by producing new comparative datasets, the *CitiSense* conceptual and analytical framework, and scenario-based foresight tools. It will stimulate future academic research in political science, European studies, sociology, and law, continue the work of previous Horizon projects and foster a lasting community of scholars focused on EU integration.

Societal: CitiSense will enhance citizens' understanding of the stakes of EU enlargement who will become more aware of cost of enlargement vs. non-enlargement. It will promote civic engagement – particularly among youth, educators, and civil society in both EU and CCs. It will foster a more inclusive and participatory political culture, with citizens better equipped to counter misunderstanding of enlargement.

Policy/Economic: CitiSense will contribute to citizen-informed enlargement strategies, supporting a resilient EU capable of managing future accessions in a contested environment. Policymakers will benefit from evidence-based tools and co-created recommendations, improving the legitimacy and responsiveness of EU communication on enlargement. This will strengthen institutional cohesion, reduce the risks of accession, and enhance the EU's capacity to integrate new members effectively.

#§IMP-ACT-IA§#

3. Quality and efficiency of the implementation #@@QUA-LIT-QL@# #@@WRK-PLA-WP@#

3.1 Work plan and resources

The CitiSense project runs over three years (M1-M36) and is organised into ten interconnected work packages (WPs), ensuring a coherent, efficient, and synergistic approach to achieving its objectives. Implementation is structured into three overlapping phases, each with distinct activities and interlinked WPs designed to maximise cross-fertilisation.

Phase 1: Conceptual Foundation (M1-M12): Led by WP1, this phase establishes the project's theoretical and analytical framework through systematic literature reviews and comparative historical analysis. It synthesises the historical drivers of EU enlargement and develops the CitiSense analytical framework, which informs all subsequent empirical research. Concurrently: **WPs 2 and 3** design and analyse public opinion surveys and launches pilot data collection in selected EU MS and CCs. Survey instruments are explicitly shaped by WP1's framework to ensure alignment with the project's core research questions. **WP4** prepares protocols for participatory mechanisms (Hackathons, Youth Labs), applying WP1's insights to ensure citizen engagement is directly linked to the project's analytical priorities.

Phase 2: Empirical Research and Analysis (M3-M24): From **M6**, WP2 **pilots** the survey instruments; **full-scale fieldwork runs M10–M16**, with preliminary pilot outputs at **M6** and main survey results at **M18** feeding the CBA in WPs 5-7. **WP4** implements participatory pilots in four EU states (M10-M28), using early findings from WPs 2, 3, 5,6 and 7 to tailor engagement activities to emerging citizen concerns. By **M18**, WP8-9 (Strategic Foresight) advances **scenario development**; **participatory testing workshops** occur in **M29–M36**. Iterative feedback is prioritised, with a mid-term conference in M18, and in M24 reviewing Phase 1 and Phase 2 findings and ensuring coherent alignment for Phase 3 activities.

Phase 3: Synthesis and Dissemination (M22-M36): From M22, **WP4 synthesises pilot lessons into policy recommendations**, and **WP8-9** expands foresight activities, developing alternative futures scenarios through participatory workshops that synthesise finalised data from WPs 5-7 and insights from WPs 2,3 and 4. **WP1** concludes its work by integrating cross-WP findings into academic publications and the final project report, directly supporting **WP10** and **WP11**. **WP10** co-creates a multidimensional toolbox, translating empirical findings, foresight outputs, and participatory results from WPs 1-9 into policy manuals and educational resources for stakeholders. Throughout the project, methodologies, outputs, and recommendations are systematically validated through the CitiSense Civil Society Network and Expert Hub (from M1) and Youth Labs (from M12). **WP11** leads targeted dissemination, leveraging outputs from all WPs to maximise impact across policy, civil society, and research audiences.

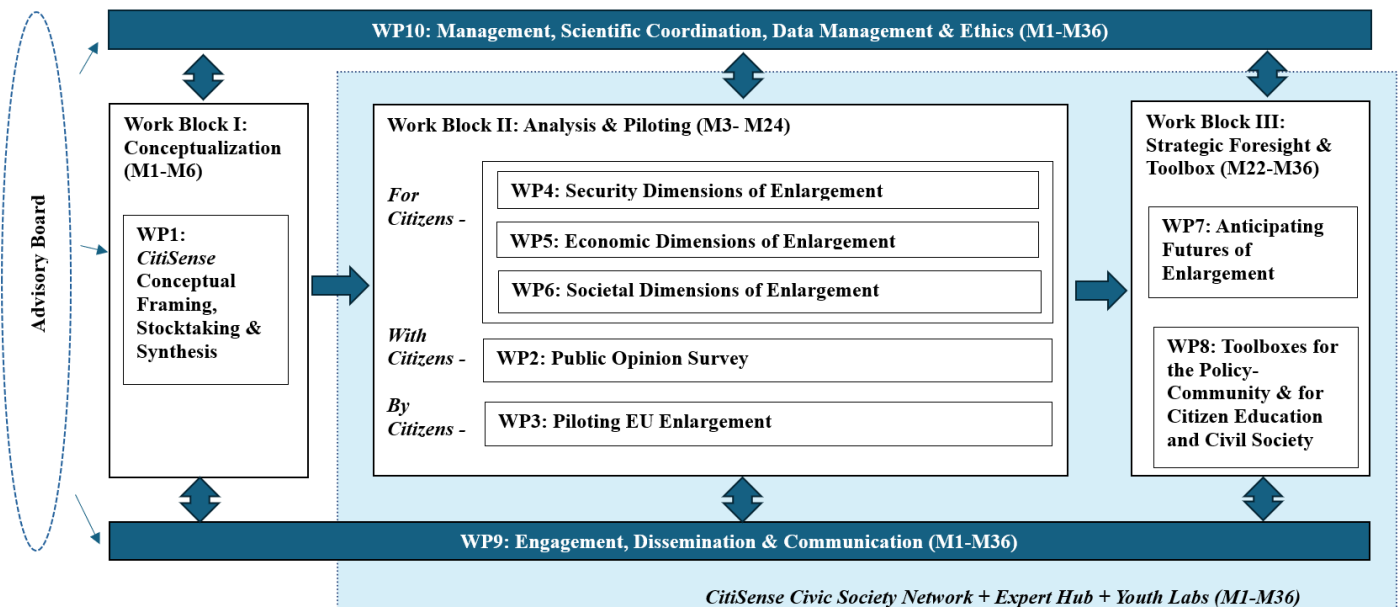
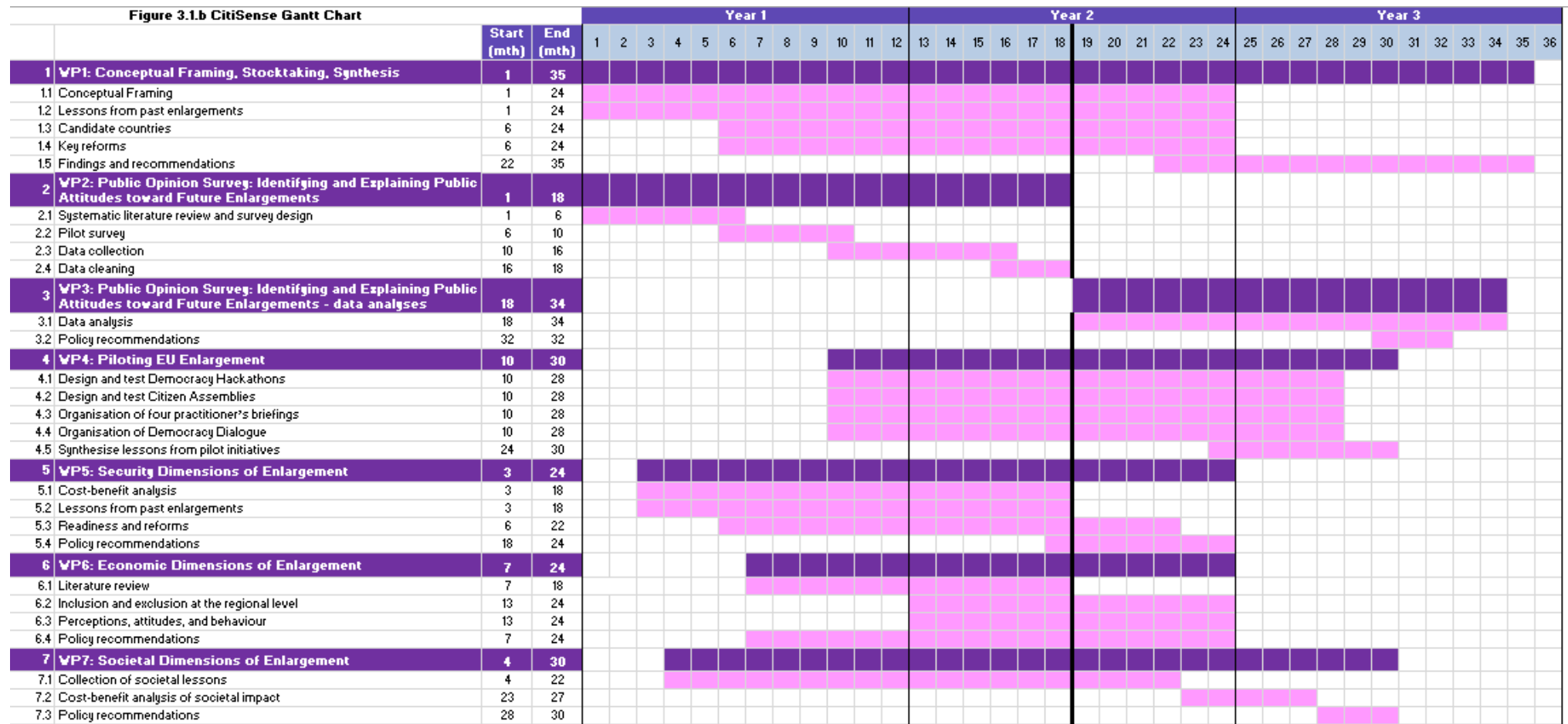


Figure 3.1.a CitiSense Project Structure



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Part B

		Start (mth)	End (mth)	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30	31	32	33	34	35	36	
8	WP8: Feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement*	1	14																																					
8.1	Mapping and evaluate existing concepts of EU Enlargement and differentiated integration	1	12																																					
9	WP9: Anticipating Futures of Enlargement	1	36																																					
9.1	Alternative futures scenarios	6	28																																					
9.2	Participatory testing of alternative futures	29	36																																					
10	WP 10: Toolboxes for Policy-Community and Education	1	36																																					
10.1	Toolbox for policymakers	22	36																																					
10.2	Toolbox for civil society and education	22	36																																					
10.3	Youth Labs	12	32																																					
10.4	National views	13	33																																					
10.5	Civil Society Network	1	36																																					
11	WP11: Communication, Dissemination, and Exploitation	1	36																																					
11.1	External communication	1	36																																					
11.2	EU Enlargement Expert Hub	1	36																																					
11.3	Public panel discussions	18	36																																					
11.4	Targeted training activities	18	36																																					
11.5	Policy briefs	1	36																																					
11.6	National briefings	1	36																																					
11.7	Major project conferences	16	36																																					
11.8	Infographics and animations	1	36																																					
11.9	Podcasts	1	18																																					
11.10	Traditional media	1	36																																					
11.11	Social media survey	1	4																																					
11.12	Video engagement	1	18																																					
11.13	Art exhibition	12	32																																					
11.14	Dissemination	1	36																																					
12	WP 12: Management and Steering	1	36																																					
12.1	Financial and administrative management	1	36																																					
12.2	Data management	1	36																																					
12.3	Coordination	1	36																																					
12.4	Scientific Lead	1	36																																					
12.5	Steering Committee	1	36																																					
12.6	Advisory Committee	1	36																																					

3.2 Capacity of participants and consortium as a whole

Strategic Fit and Excellence. CitiSense positions itself at the intersection of citizen-centred policy innovation, democratic resilience, and EU strategic foresight. At a time when EU enlargement has re-emerged as core EU policy, the CitiSense analytical framework addresses a critical knowledge and legitimacy gap: how to design an enlargement process that is socially embedded, democratically resilient, and strategically informed. To that end, CitiSense brings together a purpose-built consortium of leading academic institutions, policy think tanks, and civil society actors from across Europe and in advanced candidate states. The partners are united by their interdisciplinary expertise in European Union studies, enlargement, democracy and governance, foreign policy, strategic foresight, and public opinion analysis. In line with Horizon Europe objectives, the consortium integrates cutting-edge research in the social sciences and humanities with robust open science practices, inclusive co-creation methodologies, and policy-oriented dissemination. The consortium members share a commitment to strengthening public understanding, societal resilience, and institutional adaptation in the context of future EU enlargement. Together, and through the strength of the institutions they collaborate with, they guarantee the scientific excellence of CitiSense and the large-scale impact of the project.

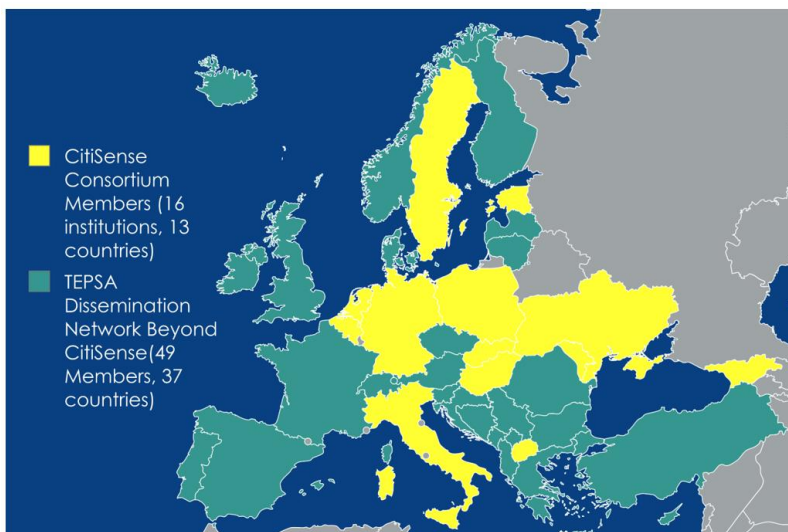


Figure 3.2: CitiSense Consortium Partners and Dissemination Capacity

Consortium Composition and Diversity.

The CitiSense consortium includes 16 institutions from 13 countries, representing all regions of the EU (North, South, East, West), as well as CCs (Georgia, Ukraine, Moldova, North Macedonia). The partner located in North Macedonia (IDSCS) comprises a network extending to all Western Balkan countries – THINK-BALKANS, while TEPSA is a trans-European think tank network present in all EU member-states, amplifying the impact of the CitiSense Consortium at the local level.

This purposeful geographic spread enables genuine pan-European and candidate-level insights into the impacts, real and perceived,

of enlargement. The institutional mix includes world-class universities with a wide reach (e.g. EUI, Maastricht University, Stockholm University), high impact think tanks (e.g. IAI, IEP, ICDS), policy networks (e.g. TEPSA), and civil society partners with access to grassroots constituencies (e.g. EPD, -IPRE, IDSCS). This diverse composition ensures that CitiSense captures elite, expert, and citizen-level perspectives and translates them into tools for policy, education, and civic engagement. The consortium reflects gender, career-stage, and regional balance and includes researchers with experience in democratic resilience, public participation, minority rights, connectivity, and societal vulnerabilities.

Institutional leadership and capacity. CitiSense is anchored at the European University Institute's Robert Schuman Centre for Advanced Studies (EUI-RSC) and Maastricht University (UM). The project is coordinated at EUI-RSC by **Prof. Erik Jones**, Director of the Centre and a leading scholar of European political economy with extensive network leadership experience (formerly Professor and Director of European & Eurasian Studies at Johns Hopkins SAIS; Non-resident Scholar at Carnegie Europe). The Robert Schuman Centre hosts numerous **ERC and Horizon Europe projects** across social sciences, giving Jones direct oversight of Horizon-funded consortia and proven capacity to manage multi-partner projects. This ensures high-level strategic oversight, access to a pan European policy community, and the institutional resources to guarantee successful delivery. Jones' research expertise on European integration, economic governance, and crisis management directly underpins CitiSense's focus on the political economy of enlargement and its security-economic-societal impacts. **Dr. Veronica Anghel** (EUI co-coordinator) conducts research that spans EU integration, enlargement, security and democratisation. Anghel co-leads the **EU Enlargement Hub** at the EUI, a cooperative research and capacity-building initiative with the CEU Democracy Institute and the Kyiv School of Economics, directly aligned with CitiSense's aims and stakeholder map. In preparation for this project, Anghel also co-edited a 2025 *Journal of European Public Policy* Special Issue on EU reform and enlargement and launched the ECPR The Loop blog series on enlargement, shaping both scholarly and

public-facing agendas that underpin CitiSense's objectives. **Prof. Giselle Bosse (UM)** serves as Scientific Lead. She holds a Personal Chair in EU External Democracy Support and Jean Monnet Chair in EU International Relations. Bosse directed the Centre for European Research in Maastricht (CERiM) (2019–2025), served as Vice Dean of Education at Maastricht's Faculty of Arts and Social Sciences, and co-coordinates the EmergEU Jean Monnet Centre. She has been co-applicant on Horizon projects (InvigoratEU, EMBRACE), and PI on major Dutch Research Council (NWO) grants (VENI, ASPASIA, Hestia), securing over €2,2 million in competitive funding. In all these projects, she has designed and led co-creation and participatory research, organised stakeholder engagement with local actors, civil society and policymakers, providing a solid foundation for implementing CitiSense's co-creation approach. Her publication record includes more than 50 peer-reviewed outputs (e.g. *Journal of Common Market Studies*, *Democratisation*, *Geopolitics*), alongside multiple edited volumes and special issues on EU democracy support and the Eastern Neighbourhood. She is Associate Fellow at **Carnegie Europe's European Democracy Hub** and the **Martens Centre** in Brussels, regular advisor to the European Parliament and Dutch government, and frequent commentator in European and international media on EU foreign policy, democracy, and enlargement. Together with Prof. Jones, Dr. Anghel and Prof. Frank Schimmelfennig (EUI & ETH Zurich), Bosse is leading WP1 on Conceptual Framing, Stocktaking, Synthesis.

The CitiSense consortium ensures that each Work Package is led by internationally recognised experts with the required methodological, thematic, and regional expertise. **WP2-3 (Public Opinion Survey)** is led by **Dr. Karina Shyrokykh, Associate Professor at Stockholm University**, a specialist in quantitative methods and statistical analysis, who builds on her Horizon EMBRACE experience to ensure continuity and robust methodology. She is joined by Dr Iulian Groza, Executive Director of Institute for European Policies and Reforms (IPRE) in Moldova, an expert on foreign policy, European affairs and good governance and a former Vice Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Republic of Moldova responsible for European Integration. **WP4 (Piloting EU Enlargement)** is led by **Elene Panchulidze, Research Coordinator at the European Partnership for Democracy (EPD)**, with over a decade of experience on EU integration, civil society, and democratisation. EPD brings expertise from EU-funded initiatives such as YouthDecide2040, Nest4Dem, INSPIRED Moldova, and WYDE Civic Engagement. She is supported by **Prof. Richard Youngs, Senior Fellow at Carnegie Europe**, internationally recognised for his scholarship on EU foreign policy and democracy. **WP5 (Security Dimensions of Enlargement)** is co-led by **Dr. Kristi Raik, Director of ICDS**, an authority on European security and strategic competition, and **Prof. David Aprasidze, Board Member of GIP**, a specialist in security and enlargement who has directed EU-supported civil society initiatives in Georgia. **WP6 (Economic Dimensions of Enlargement)** is co-led by **Prof. László Bruszt, Director at the CEU Democracy Institute**, a leading scholar of economic integration and enlargement and contributor to the EUI Enlargement Hub, and **Prof. Ben Stanley of USWPS University**, a specialist in voting behaviour, political parties, and democratic backsliding who has coordinated major projects including *Measuring Populism* (2019–2020), *DIASPOLitic* (Norwegian Research Council), and *EUROPA/A2–Values Under Pressure* (2019–2020). **WP7 (Societal Dimensions of Enlargement)** is co-led by **Prof. Lucia Mokrá, Dean of the Faculty of Social and Economic Sciences at Comenius University in Bratislava**, an expert on EU citizenship and fundamental rights, and **Dr. Nicoletta Pirozzi, Head of IAI's "EU, Politics and Institutions" Programme**, with expertise in EU governance and crisis management and contributions to InvigoratEU and RECLAIM. **WP8 (Feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement?)** is led by **Prof. Funda Tekin, Director at IEP (Germany)**, with extensive experience on rule of law, enlargement, and foresight (RESILIO, InvigoratEU). **WP9 (Anticipating Futures of Enlargement)** **Prof. Gaby Umbach, EUI**, an expert in EU integration and Europeanisation, founder of the Berlin Futures group, and experienced in applying foresight to EU policy. **WP10 (Toolboxes for the Policy-Community and for Citizen Education and Civil Society)** is co-led by **Prof. Michael Kaeding, University of Duisburg-Essen**. He has widely published on EU governance, compliance, and enlargement, and is an experienced coordinator of EU projects (ActEU, InvigoratEU) with strong civil society and education networks. He is joined by **Elena Ventura (UM)** with practical experience implementing youth labs and developing toolkits in InvigoratEU. UDE, UM, EUI and CUB provide structured training environments and curricula to embed outputs into higher education and professional development, while UM also embeds outputs into secondary education through its international teacher training academies, ensuring long-term educational impact at both higher and secondary levels. **WP11 (Communication and Dissemination)** is led by **TEPSA**, a network of 49 institutes in 37 countries with unparalleled reach to policymakers, CSOs, and citizens. Under the leadership of **Executive Director Mariam Khotenashvili**, TEPSA has advanced citizen participation in enlargement debates, youth engagement (#EngagEU, PADEMIA), and enlargement analysis (TEPSA Expert Briefs, Ukraine Update), and has repeatedly led communication WPs in Horizon projects (SEnECA, InDivEU, DiCE, FEUTURE, ActEU, InvigoratEU).

WP & Title	Core Team & Institution(s)	Key Expertise & Relevant Experience
WP1– Conceptual Framing, Stocktaking, Synthesis	Prof. Frank Schimmelfennig (EUI); Prof Erik Jones (EUI); Prof Veronica Anghel (EUI); Prof. Dr. Giselle Bosse (UM)	Assessment of citizens participations; EU enlargement hub; continuity of InDivEU and DICE;
WP2-3 – Public Opinion Survey	Dr. Karina Shyrokykh (SU)	Quantitative methods; continuity from EMBRACE project. Extensive survey expertise in Moldova & Eastern Europe; countering disinformation.
WP4 – Piloting EU Enlargement	Elene Panchulidze (EPD) Prof. Dr. Richard Youngs (Carnegie Europe)	EU integration, civil society (YouthDecide2040, INSPIRED Moldova). EU foreign policy & democracy, widely published (Macmillan 2021, CUP 2017).
WP5 – Security Dimensions of Enlargement	Dr. Kristi Raik (ICDS) Dr. David Aprasidze (GIP)	European security; Baltic & Finnish foreign policy. Security & enlargement; EU-supported initiatives on civil society in Georgia.
WP6 – Economic Dimensions of Enlargement	Prof. Dr. László Bruszt (CEU) Dr. Ben Stanley (USWPS)	Enlargement & economic integration of peripheries; Enlargement Hub contributor. Quantitative analysis of populism, parties, backsliding; PI of DIASPOLitic, Measuring Populism.
WP7 – Societal Dimensions of Enlargement	Prof. Dr. Lucia Mokrá (CUB) Dr. Nicoletta Pirozzi (IAI)	EU citizenship, fundamental rights, non-discrimination; TEPSA Board. EU governance, crisis management; InvigoratEU, RECLAIM.
WP8-9 – Anticipating Futures of Enlargement	Prof. Dr. Funda Tekin (IEP) Prof. Dr. Gaby Umbach (EUI)	Rule of law resilience (RESILIO); EU enlargement foresight (InvigoratEU). EU integration & Europeanisation; foresight (Berlin Futures group).
WP10 – Toolboxes for Policy & Civil Society	Prof. Dr. Michael Kaeding (UDE) Prof. Dr. Giselle Bosse (UM) Elena Ventura (UM)	EU governance, compliance, enlargement; PI of ActEU, InvigoratEU; ex-TEPSA Chair. EU politics & governance; toolkit & youth lab implementation in InvigoratEU.
WP11 – Communication & Dissemination	Mariam Khotenashvili (TEPSA)	Pan-European network (49 institutes, 37 countries); citizen participation (#EngageEU, PADEMIA). Strong track record in Horizon WP9 leadership (SEnECA, DiCE, ActEU, InvigoratEU).

Think tanks and universities from the EU candidate states, including Ilia State University (Georgia), Kyiv-Mohyla Academy (Ukraine), IPRE (Moldova), and IDSCS (North Macedonia), contribute context-sensitive expertise, local networks, and access to critical data. CitiSense ensures the continuity of the work of Ukrainian colleagues Roman Petrov and Oksana Holovko-Havrysheva in critical areas for Ukraine's EU path they have developed in EU funded projects such as Youth for Europe / YOUROPE, REUNIR, and SHAPEDEM-EU. Zoran Nechev (IDSCS) specialises in relations between the European Union and the Western Balkans and has ample experience in running research and policy networks, including in EU funded projects (e.g., THINK BALKANS, EU IDEA). This collective design ensures coherent coverage of all thematic areas: conceptual framing, citizen engagement, public attitudes, geopolitical and institutional risks, and policy toolkits.

Access to Infrastructure and Data. All partners have the institutional capacity and access to critical infrastructures needed to carry out the proposed research and engagement activities. This includes access to nationally representative survey panels (e.g. SU, USWPS), digital and foresight platforms (e.g. EUI, TEPSA), in-house policy labs (e.g. IAI, IEP), and established networks for citizen and youth engagement (e.g. EPD, IDSCS). CitiSense will also build on several partners' proprietary tools and data resources developed in prior Horizon projects such as the InvigoratEU Civic Society Network and Youth Labs. The EUI Robert Schuman Centre for Advanced Studies (RSCAS) and TEPSA provide technical and administrative support structures; the RSCAS offers top management and ethics

oversight with continuous support provided by a professional project manager. CitiSense partners bring strong expertise in digital participation and communication: -IPRE provides advanced disinformation monitoring tools and TEPSA and EPD run digital platforms for citizen and youth engagement, while the EUI and IEP provide digital foresight platforms. All CitiSense contributors are committed to Open Access and FAIR data principles which will guide the project's research workflows and outputs.

Track Record and Past Collaboration. The consortium draws on a rich history of collaboration across Horizon Europe, H2020, Erasmus+, and Jean Monnet projects. Partners have jointly participated in InvigoratEU, EMBRACE, RECLAIM, EU IDEA, InDivEU, JOINT, SHAPEDEM-EU, and DiCE, among others. CitiSense builds on their proven ability to co-produce high-quality research, manage large-scale projects, and translate findings into actionable policy and societal impact. Several key figures in the consortium – such as Giselle Bosse (MU), Lucia Mokrá (CUB), Funda Tekin (IEP), Michael Kaeding (UDE), Gaby Umbach (EUI), Frank Schimmelfennig (ETHZ and EUI), Laszlo Bruszt (CEU), Kristi Raik (ICDS), Mariam Khotenashvili (TEPSA), Nicoletta Pirozzi (IAI), Kristi Raik (ICDS) – have held coordination or work package leadership roles in high-profile Horizon Europe consortia. Others, like Richard Youngs (Carnegie Europe and UM), Karina Shyrokykh (SU), and Matteo Bonomi (IAI), are recognised contributors to democratic resilience research. The EUI project coordinators, Veronica Anghel and Erik Jones, have a proven track record of successful continuous collaboration. The repeated collaboration of CitiSense contributors across different project constellations ensures deep mutual understanding and operational synergy.

Commitment to Gender Equality, Open Science, and Inclusivity. CitiSense embeds gender equality, open science, and inclusivity across its design and delivery. The consortium comprises a strong representation of female researchers, including Work Package leads and coordinators (e.g. Anghel, Bosse, Tekin, Khotenashvili, Shyrokykh, Panchulidze, Raik, Mokrá, Umbach), and draws on partners with gender expertise in policy and societal transformation (e.g. EPD, CUB, IEP). Open science principles are built into the project's data management, publication, and co-creation strategies, including multilingual access and FAIR data practices. Participatory components explicitly target youth, underrepresented groups, and civil society in both MS and CCs, ensuring that the project is not only about citizens, but also with and by them.

Together, the CitiSense consortium and its already confirmed **Advisory Board** constitute a strategically assembled, interdisciplinary, and impact-oriented team, fully equipped to deliver on the project's ambitious objectives. It combines academic rigor with civic engagement, EU-wide reach with neighbourhood sensitivity, and deep research experience with an openness to innovation and co-creation.

Advisory Board Member	Benefits for CitiSense
Sara Bartoli	As a Young European ambassador highly involved in shaping European affairs, Bartoli provides a unique youth perspective and feedback to CitiSense, in line with the project emphasis on amplifying youth's involvement throughout the enlargement project. Her participation benefits particularly the development of WP10 toolkit on education as well as the implementation of youth labs.
Vahe Gabrielya	Former Ambassador of Armenia to the UK and former Director of the Diplomatic School of Armenia, Gabrielya provides in-depth knowledge and practical experience on the EU's Eastern Partnership policies and context.
Andrea Gawrich	Prof. Dr. Andreas Garwich is the Coordinator of the HE SHAPEDEM-EU consortium, call 'HORIZON-CL2-2021-DEMOCRACY-01-04: Democratic politics in the EU's neighbourhood', 10/2022- 09/2025. Her participation ensures sustainability of previous Horizon Europe project's results and provides the opportunity to identify opportunities for joint activities and cooperation.
Sonja Grimm	Prof. Dr. Sonja Grimm is the Scientific Lead and Co-Coordinator of the HE EMBRACE consortium, call 'HORIZON-CL2-2021-DEMOCRACY-01-04: Democratic politics in the EU's neighbourhood', 10/2022-09/2025. Her participation ensures sustainability of previous Horizon Europe project's results and provides the opportunity to identify opportunities for joint activities and cooperation.
Maurice de Heus	Maurice de Heus is a journalist at L1 (Dutch regional TV and radio channel) working extensively on the European Union and its enlargement strategies. His role on the board is

	key in contributing expertise on communication strategies and amplifying CitiSense's outputs to local communities.
Sónia Pereira de Figueiredo	Sónia Pereira de Figueiredo is a public information specialist at the European Commission advising on sensitive communication to EU citizens for crisis/policy matters, disinformation, and other foreign policy issues. Her skillset in citizens communication, specifically tailored to the European Commission, will support CitiSense in fostering public understanding of and support for enlargement.
Dirk Schuebel	Dirk Schuebel is the Head of Division for Relations with the Russian Federation at the European External Action Service. He previously served as Head of the Delegation of the European Union to Moldova (2009-2013) and Head of the Delegation of the European Union to Belarus (2019-2022). Schuebel's previous experience and expertise in Eastern Partnership countries will support WPs 5-7.
Virginijus Sinkevicius	Virginijus Sinkevicius is a Member of the European Parliament and former European Commissioner for the Environment, Oceans and Fisheries in the European Commission. Sinkevicius provides strategic insight from both the Commission and Parliament, enabling CitiSense to engage more effectively with key EU decision-makers.

CitiSense will formalise post-project ownership and hosting responsibilities in the Consortium Agreement and Project Management Plan prior to the project start date. Ownership of results will follow Horizon Europe rules: each beneficiary owns the results it generates, with joint ownership arrangements defined where results are co-created. For shared digital outputs (e.g., dashboards, toolkits, platform elements), a designated maintaining partner will be contractually identified before month 30 to ensure continuity beyond project closure.

Regarding data sustainability, all anonymised datasets, survey instruments, codebooks, and documentation will be deposited in certified institutional repositories hosted by the European University Institute and Maastricht University. These repositories guarantee long-term preservation, persistent identifiers (DOIs), and open access in line with FAIR principles. This ensures continued accessibility independent of additional project funding.

For the CitiSense platform and digital toolboxes, maintenance responsibility will be assigned to specific consortium partners embedded in durable institutional structures. Policy-oriented materials will be hosted and maintained via established networks (e.g., TEPSA and the EU Enlargement Expert Hub), while educational toolkits will be integrated into partner universities' teaching and outreach infrastructures. Hosting commitments and update responsibilities will be formalised prior to project end.

To ensure orderly transition, the project will implement a structured "Sustainability and Transfer Review" in months 30-34. During this phase, the Steering Committee will confirm:

- The final allocation of maintenance responsibilities,
- Hosting arrangements for all digital outputs,
- Repository deposition of datasets,
- Licensing conditions for continued reuse,
- Any required handover agreements to external institutional actors.

This mechanism ensures that sustainability is not left implicit but operationally governed and contractually defined before the project concludes.

Table 3.1e: Critical risks for implementation #@RSK-MGT-RM@#

In addition to administrative and ethical risks, CitiSense will formally incorporate methodological risk categories into the Project Management Plan, risk table. These methodological risks relate primarily to (1) data collection validity, (2) sample representativeness, (3) cross-country comparability, (4) participatory design integrity, and (5) analytical coherence across work packages.

First, regarding survey implementation (WP2), risks include lower-than-expected response rates, sampling bias, translation inconsistencies, or limited cross-country equivalence. Mitigation measures include pilot testing of survey instruments, back-translation procedures, use of established survey providers with replacement sampling capacity, application of post-stratification weighting, and predefined minimum representativeness thresholds. If response rates fall below these thresholds, supplementary recruitment waves or targeted sampling adjustments will be activated.

Second, in relation to qualitative interviews and case studies (WPs 1, 4-6), risks include limited access to key informants, overrepresentation of certain institutional perspectives, or geopolitical constraints affecting fieldwork in Candidate Countries. Mitigation measures include diversified interviewee lists, remote interviewing protocols, triangulation of interview data with documentary analysis, and, if necessary, adaptive resequencing of fieldwork activities without compromising comparative design.

Third, for participatory mechanisms (WP3), risks include insufficient demographic diversity, dominance of particular viewpoints, or limited deliberative quality. Mitigation includes stratified recruitment criteria, trained neutral moderators, structured deliberation formats (e.g., facilitated small-group discussions), and evaluation surveys to assess perceived inclusivity and balance.

Fourth, cross-work-package analytical coherence presents a potential risk in large consortia. To mitigate fragmentation, WP1 provides a shared conceptual and methodological framework, and regular cross-WP coordination meetings will ensure instrument alignment and interpretative consistency. A methodological review will be conducted as part of the mid-term conference to identify inconsistencies early and apply corrective harmonisation.

Finally, methodological risk monitoring will be integrated into the six-monthly Steering Committee reviews. Work Package Leaders are responsible for early identification of methodological deviations, and any significant risks will be formally recorded in the Portal risk table with defined mitigation timelines.

#§RSK-MGT-RM§#

Table 3.1g: ‘Subcontracting costs’ items

1. EUI		
	Cost (€)	Description of tasks and justification
Subcontracting	€15,000	WP1 - CitiSense will subcontract an external company to design the Comparative Dashboard of Drivers of Enlargement - map of security drivers, economic interdependencies, and public sentiment across CCs. Under Task 1.2, the consortium conducts comparative historical research across previous enlargement waves using: • EU and national archival sources; • public opinion datasets and citizen cost–benefit analyses; • economic modelling of wage and employment trends before and after accession; • social cohesion indicators; • motivation mapping of geopolitical, economic, and security drivers;

		- comparative desk research on staged accession and flexible integration models; - newly conceptualised surveys and survey experiments (in coordination with WP2). The analytical output of T1.2 is a multidimensional dataset capturing how security, economic, and societal drivers have interacted across enlargement waves and candidate countries. Deliverable 1.2 (D1.2) translates this research into a structured, comparative, and interactive dashboard that: - integrates historical and contemporary data across enlargement rounds; - maps geopolitical, economic, and security motivations comparatively; - visualises economic modelling outputs (pre/post-accession trends); - displays public opinion and survey-experiment findings; - enables cross-country and cross-wave comparison of drivers and integration models. The dashboard functions as an analytical tool that systematises the outputs of T1.2 and allows structured comparison across cases and time. The subcontracting is strictly limited to the <i>technical development and digital implementation</i> of this dashboard. The consortium retains sole responsibility for: - the conceptual framework and indicator design; - all data collection and modelling; - survey design and interpretation; - comparative analysis; - substantive content validation. However, the consortium does not have in-house capacity for: advanced web-based interactive data visualisation; backend database architecture for multi-source, multi-wave datasets; dynamic filtering and comparative analytical interfaces. The subcontracted company or expert(s) will therefore be responsible for: - building the secure database structure for T1.2 datasets; - programming the interactive dashboard environment; - integrating modelling outputs and survey data into dynamic visualisations; - designing user interfaces that support cross-case comparison; - ensuring accessibility, interoperability, and sustainability standards. This constitutes a specialised technical service essential to making the outputs of T1.2 operational, accessible, and policy-relevant within the CitiSense framework.
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2. UM

	Cost (€)	Description of tasks and justification
Subcontracting	€30,000	CitiSense will subcontract Prof. Richard Youngs, Senior Fellow at Carnegie Europe and Professor of International Relations at the University of Warwick. His internationally recognised expertise in civic participation, democratic governance, and global democratic trends is not otherwise available within the consortium. His unique combination of academic excellence, policy engagement experience, and civil-society-focused research is essential to ensuring the scientific quality, conceptual coherence, and policy relevance of the project. Prof. Youngs will contribute directly to the implementation of WP1, WP2, WP7, and WP8, specifically: WP1 – Conceptual and methodological framework: Contributing to the refinement of the CitiSense analytical framework;

		supporting the synthesis and interpretation of comparative findings on enlargement; contributing to <i>D1.1 Conceptual and Methodological Framework</i> and <i>D1.5 Synthesis of Key Findings</i>; and ensuring alignment with cutting-edge research on democratic governance and EU external action. • WP2-3 – Public opinion and comparative empirical analysis: Providing expert input for the interpretation of survey data on citizens' perceptions of enlargement; contextualising empirical results within broader global democratic and geopolitical trends; and contributing to policy-relevant recommendations (<i>D2.2, D2.3</i>). • WP9 – Strategic foresight and scenario development: Supporting the identification and analysis of key geopolitical, societal, and democratic trends shaping future enlargement (<i>T7.1, T7.2</i>); contributing to the development and validation of foresight scenarios through expert consultations and foresight workshops (<i>T7.3</i>); and ensuring the analytical robustness and policy relevance of the scenarios. • WP10 – Toolbox development and policy translation: Contributing to the synthesis and translation of research findings into actionable recommendations for policymakers, civil society, and educational stakeholders (<i>T8.1, T8.2</i>), ensuring that toolboxes and guidance materials reflect cutting-edge research and address current democratic-governance challenges. This subcontracting is necessary because the level of internationally recognised expertise required in EU democracy support, global democratic trends, and comparative policy-relevant analysis is not available within the beneficiary institution. Prof. Youngs' extensive experience advising European and international institutions, combined with his leadership in major international research and policy initiatives, provides essential conceptual, methodological, and policy-translation expertise that cannot be replicated internally. Subcontracting is therefore the most efficient and cost-effective solution for delivering the high-level conceptual, analytical, foresight, and synthesis tasks that are critical to ensuring the scientific excellence, coherence, and impact of the project's outputs.
9.SU		
	Cost (€)	Description of tasks and justification
Subcontracting	€100,000	WP2 allocates EUR 100,000 to implement representative, cross-national data collection capturing public opinion on EU enlargement across nine countries: five EU Member States (Estonia, Slovenia, France, the Netherlands, and Spain) and four candidate countries (Ukraine, Moldova, North Macedonia, and Serbia). The scope and comparative design of the project necessitate careful survey development, translation, piloting, and coordination of data collection to ensure high data quality. The budget covers full-scale data collection using online panels. It also includes pilot testing and professional translation to ensure validity across diverse linguistic contexts. The collected data will be analysed within WP2 to explore the drivers of support for enlargement and will also serve as empirical evidence for other work packages, informing cost-benefit analyses, communication strategies, and policy recommendations.

		The data collection activity directly relates to the project's focus on enlargement and the "enlargement with citizens" dimension of the conceptual framework, ensuring that the voices of citizens—within and beyond the EU—inform the design of enlargement policy. The costs are calculated based on survey pricing information obtained from two sociological research companies: YouGov and InfoSapiens.
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The partners internal procurement rules will be followed as well as the principle of the best value for money.

Sustainability of platforms:

CitiSense is designed not as a time-bound research exercise but as a structured contribution to long-term enlargement governance, civic engagement, and policy dialogue. While the proposal focused primarily on delivery within the three-year timeframe, the sustainability of its platform, datasets, and participatory tools is ensured through institutional anchoring, open-access infrastructure, and structured post-project integration.

First, the CitiSense digital infrastructure, including datasets, dashboards, toolkits, and educational materials, will be hosted in established institutional repositories with guaranteed long-term maintenance. Partners will ensure that core datasets, codebooks, survey instruments, and documentation are deposited in trusted open repositories (e.g., Cadmus and institutional FAIR-compliant archives), ensuring persistent identifiers, long-term storage, and continued accessibility beyond the project duration.

Second, the CitiSense toolboxes for policymakers and civil society are designed as modular, transferable instruments rather than project-specific outputs. Ownership and maintenance responsibilities will be clearly defined in the Consortium Agreement. The policy toolbox will be maintained through institutional partners embedded in European policy networks, including TEPSA, ensuring that materials remain accessible and updated where relevant. The citizen and education toolbox will be integrated into existing teaching and training programmes at partner institutions and disseminated through civil society networks, allowing continued use without reliance on additional project funding.

Third, participatory formats such as Youth Labs, Democracy Hackathons, and Citizen Assemblies are intentionally designed as scalable methodologies rather than one-off events. Methodological manuals and replication guidelines will be openly published, enabling public administrations, civil society organisations, and academic institutions to independently replicate the formats. Several consortium partners have committed to integrating these formats into their regular outreach and teaching portfolios after the project concludes.

Fourth, the project's sustainability is reinforced through network institutionalisation. The CitiSense Civil Society Network and EU Enlargement Expert Hub will not dissolve at project end; rather, they will be embedded within existing organisational structures and policy dialogue platforms managed by consortium partners. This ensures continuity of stakeholder engagement and preserves the community of practice established during the project.

Fifth, CitiSense's empirical datasets are structured for secondary use. By ensuring anonymisation, documentation, and open licensing, the datasets become reusable research infrastructure for future enlargement research, comparative political analysis, and teaching. This extends scientific exploitation beyond the original project scope. Each partner will follow their internal guide for best practice.

Finally, sustainability is supported by forward-looking funding strategies. Partners will actively seek follow-up funding through Horizon Europe, national research programmes, and policy-driven calls to further develop and scale specific components (e.g., participatory foresight formats or enlargement dashboards). The project's modular architecture enables incremental extension rather than dependence on a single funding cycle.

Section 4 Ethics self-assessment

- a. Ethical dimension of the objectives, methodology and likely impact

CitiSense will employ several data collection methods, in particular: surveys, survey experiments, interviews, secondary analysis of data, focus groups, citizen assemblies, hackathons and case studies. CitiSense generates original empirical data through large-scale public opinion surveys, survey experiments, and fieldwork, including elite interviews (semi-structured interviews with policymakers from the EU and CCs, and expert interviews) and comparative case studies to assess the impact of enlargement versus non-enlargement, both real and perceived. CitiSense also pilots scalable participatory formats – Youth Labs, Citizen Assemblies, Democracy Hackathons, and a Citizens’ Art Exhibition – alongside easy-to-use digital tools like Mentimeter and Kahoot! CitiSense ensures the continuity of compatible participatory tools developed in previous Horizon projects, thus further investing in keeping and expanding insights already generated by citizens. The project will use already developed best practices to ensure that there are no ethical complications. Participatory mechanisms also include social dialogues, fostering intercultural learning, peer-to-peer exchange, and collaborative problem-solving. Compliance with codes of conduct and laws All surveys, experiments, and interviews will comply explicitly with the codes of conduct and laws existing in each country in which the experiments will take place. The partners executing the experiments will themselves be bound by the applicable law in their respective country. Surveys Full-scale surveys are then implemented online, with telephone interviews in some cases to enhance representativeness. The data is cleaned and processed using statistical software and analyzed using multilevel regression models to explore how demographic factors and narrative framings affect public support (T2.5). Citizen Assemblies (Germany, Czechia) follow OECD/EU best practices. 20 participants will be selected via stratified random sampling to ensure demographic representativeness. Held in hybrid format for accessibility, each assembly begins with a learning phase featuring balanced briefings by enlargement experts and programme representatives (Erasmus+, Interreg, etc.). Participants deliberate in small groups using inclusive methods like the Fishbowl format. Moderators ensure equitable dialogue. Informed consent and information sheet The individuals taking part in the data collection will have to sign an informed consent form before participating. The informed consent forms may be different in each country as each company/partner will have its own specific (legal) requirements. In all cases, the responsible project partner will ensure that each form used by the project will include, as a minimum, the following provisions: a description of the procedural aspects of the experiments, information on the scientific use by the project of the data generated, information on possible secondary use of the data by other researchers, information on the anonymisation of the data generated, the right to withdraw and discontinue participation at any time without penalty, the right to decline to take part in any part of the experiment, a concluding section in which the participant will declare that he or she has read and understood the provisions, and provides his or her consent to participating in the experiment. Secondary data analysis In some of the project work packages researchers will also analyse data already collected, including existing datasets that monitor support for the EU and European integration (including EES, ESS, WVS, EVS, Eurobarometer, EU profiler, euandi). The use of these datasets does not raise ethical issues, as the datasets are pre-cleaned and provided only in anonymised versions. Access to Infrastructure and Data. All partners have the institutional capacity and access to critical infrastructures needed to carry out the proposed research and engagement activities. This includes access to nationally representative survey panels (e.g. SU, SWPS), digital and foresight platforms (e.g. EUI, TEPSA), in-house policy labs (e.g. IAI, IEP), and established networks for citizen and youth engagement (e.g. EPD, IDSCS). CitiSense will also build on several partners’ proprietary tools and data resources developed in prior Horizon projects such as the InvigoratEU Civic Society Network and Youth Labs.

b. Compliance with ethical principles and relevant legislations

Before conducting the above-mentioned activities, the EUI Ethics Committee will be asked to approve the project’s handling of research-related ethical issues. Similar procedures are in place at partner institutions responsible for data collection. Documents needed under national law will be collected by the partner institutions, if applicable. The primary data collection included in the proposal at SU will require ethical approval (subcontracted survey). An application will be made to Stockholm University’s Ethics Committee and research will not commence until approval is received. All CitiSense partners will respect the principles of informed consent, voluntary participation and confidentiality in the collection and processing of all primary data. Personal data will be treated according to the legal requirements, including the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) of the EU or, where applicable, other legal frameworks which provide an adequate level of protection. All CitiSense contributors are committed to Open Access and FAIR data principles which will guide the project’s research workflows and outputs. CitiSense will ensure that research data will be findable, accessible, interoperable and re-usable (FAIR). Research Data Repositories exist for example at the coordinating partner,

the European University Institute (<https://www.eui.eu/Research/Library/ResearchDataServices>). Researchers will be able to rely on the dedicated staff of their libraries to ensure the proper implementation of the Data Management Plan. The DMP will determine whether, when, how, where and under what terms, CitiSense data outputs can be openly shared or shared under more restrictive terms and conditions. The EUI is an intergovernmental organisation established by the Convention Setting up a European University Institute (1972, as amended), and therefore is not directly subject to the General Data Protection Regulation (Regulation (EU) 2016/679, GDPR) or the Regulation on Data Protection for EU Institutions (Regulation (EU) 2018/1725, EUDPR). Instead, the EUI has adopted its own data protection framework through Decision No. 10/2019 of the President of the EUI regarding Data Protection at the EUI, which sets out the rules on the processing of personal data by the Institute. While tailored to the EUI's unique legal status, the policy is closely aligned with the principles, rights, and obligations enshrined in the GDPR and EUDPR. It ensures that personal data are processed lawfully, fairly, and transparently, in accordance with internationally recognised data protection standards and in full respect of the rights of data subjects. Project researchers will be bound by this decision. Data which are not kept in anonymous form may not in any case be diffused beyond members of the research team. The Decision lists specific actions to be taken in order to ensure data subjects will retain individual rights to information, access, correction and consent concerning data protection. For the purpose of ensuring the implementation of the Decision, the EUI has created an Ethics Committee that will supervise the work done under this project's research. Similar procedures are in place at participating partner institutions.

##\$QUA-LIT-QL\$# ##\$WRK-PLA-WP\$#

ANNEX 2

ESTIMATED BUDGET (LUMP SUM BREAKDOWN) FOR THE ACTION

	Estimated EU contribution										
	Estimated eligible lump sum contributions (per work package)										Maximum grant amount ¹
	WP1 Conceptual Framing, Stocktaking, Synthesis	WP2 Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements	WP3 Public Opinion Survey: Identifying and Explaining Public Attitudes toward Future Enlargements – data analyses	WP4 Piloting EU Enlargement: Driven by Citizens, Designed with and for Citizens	WP5 Security Dimensions of Enlargement	WP6 Economic Dimensions of Enlargement	WP7 Societal Dimensions of Enlargement	WP8 Feasibility and probability of existing concepts of EU enlargement	WP9 Anticipating Futures of Enlargement	WP10 Toolboxes for Policy-Community and for Citizen Education and Civil Society	
Forms of funding	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	i	j	n = a + b + c + d + e + f + g + h + i + j + k + l + m
1 - EUI	193 607.75	4 735.48	9 470.95	0.00	37 883.80	0.00	0.00	9 470.95	114 129.05	18 941.90	562 414.88
2 - UM	218 251.12	13 022.35	18 022.35	0.00	15 184.73	0.00	0.00	0.00	7 500.00	169 024.39	528 063.79
3 - ICDS	0.00	7 106.38	0.00	0.00	119 659.13	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	7 106.38	150 736.26
4 - I.A.I.	0.00	5 568.75	0.00	0.00	14 262.50	0.00	93 531.25	0.00	0.00	5 568.75	131 658.75
5 - CEU	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	76 562.50	10 000.00	0.00	0.00	2 187.50	100 225.00
6 - UDE	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	225 250.00	241 600.00
7 - IEP	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	90 000.00	77 500.00	0.00	184 600.00
8 - EPD	0.00	0.00	0.00	285 275.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	4 312.50	307 875.00
9 - SU	0.00	216 750.00	136 562.50	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	5 187.50	372 100.00
10 - TEPSA	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	405 526.67
11 - CUB	0.00	4 303.75	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	88 001.76	0.00	0.00	4 328.24	107 621.25
12 - USWPS	0.00	8 000.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	86 000.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	8 000.00	113 850.00
13 - ISU	16 875.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	18 500.00	16 875.00	11 250.00	0.00	0.00	5 625.00	86 475.00
14 - KMU	9 500.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	20 500.00	14 250.00	4 750.00	0.00	0.00	4 750.00	67 100.00
15 - IPRE	5 625.00	4 687.50	4 687.50	0.00	0.00	7 500.00	7 500.00	2 812.50	2 812.50	7 125.00	60 850.00
16 - IDSCS	5 625.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	16 875.00	0.00	16 875.00	0.00	0.00	11 875.00	64 100.00
Σ consortium	449 483.87	264 174.21	168 743.30	285 275.00	242 865.16	201 187.50	231 908.01	102 283.45	201 941.55	479 282.16	3 484 796.60

Forms of funding	Estimated EU contribution			
	Estimated eligible lump sum contributions (per work package)			Maximum grant amount ¹
	WP11 Communication, Dissemination, and Exploitation	WP12 Management and Steering	WP13 Ethics requirements	
	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	Lump sum contribution	
	k	l	m	n = a + b + c + d + e + f + g + h + i + j + k + l + m
1 - EUI	35 175.00	139 000.00	0.00	562 414.88
2 - UM	65 491.49	21 567.36	0.00	528 063.79
3 - ICDS	7 116.56	9 747.81	0.00	150 736.26
4 - I.A.I.	5 938.75	6 788.75	0.00	131 658.75
5 - CEU	5 312.50	6 162.50	0.00	100 225.00
6 - UDE	4 625.00	11 725.00	0.00	241 600.00
7 - IEP	8 125.00	8 975.00	0.00	184 600.00
8 - EPD	8 437.50	9 850.00	0.00	307 875.00
9 - SU	6 375.00	7 225.00	0.00	372 100.00
10 - TEPSA	390 340.67	15 186.00	0.00	405 526.67
11 - CUB	5 918.75	5 068.75	0.00	107 621.25
12 - USWPS	5 500.00	6 350.00	0.00	113 850.00
13 - ISU	6 375.00	10 975.00	0.00	86 475.00
14 - KMU	6 250.00	7 100.00	0.00	67 100.00
15 - IPRE	10 125.00	7 975.00	0.00	60 850.00
16 - IDSCS	7 250.00	5 600.00	0.00	64 100.00
Σ consortium	578 356.22	279 296.17	0.00	3 484 796.60

¹ The 'maximum grant amount' is the maximum grant amount fixed in the grant agreement (on the basis of the sum of the beneficiaries' lump sum shares for the work packages).

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITEIT MAASTRICHT (UM), PIC 999975911, established in MINDERBROEDERSBERG 4, MAASTRICHT 6200 MD, Netherlands,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Christine NEUHOLD with ECAS id nneuhoch signed in the Participant Portal on 19/05/2026 at 09:28:41 (transaction id SigId-5825-9GZKzi1AczObzt1v5uuCiBhSn232UBurwTcc1UTnTixsMPjYfhac44zzgbAbUYqvYDYBzV197B8Q6iFbtQf3P3F0-POMaLlcnzRygWFnj0ibqHK-0rLVWC0IE8onCPxczKxLyNvziLZWqtF46rDrLeWsqSK1zwqtGGXFpDRpwBIWRuuUzhbSLEq26j0bDjXdY82jZ5G). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.19 09:28:45 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

SIHTASUTUS RAHVUSVAHELINE KAITSEUURINGUTE KESKUS (ICDS), PIC 998833251, established in Narva mnt 63/4 East Building, TALLINN 10152, Estonia,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Kristi Raik with ECAS id n0034kdq signed in the Participant Portal on 27/05/2026 at 16:15:35 (transaction id SigId-11901-bIVGsXgnjN71X4wH0BaAfe4rXwvog3NzzHng90x8lgQRHwsXrjJ3Kw5hWAjDztgA4jOvFROj3WzVmpwb4q4ITxO-R2zIpFT8xjM178RdBPyo0m-kwHRwNMn2RHmm4hcU4FV84xbzKoN3sbNMXE2U0Wx7rWkiLqImPj0aeb50S7ApPFRP1WdNWPdlzOmEnFamqrrFB). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.27 16:15:43 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

ISTITUTO AFFARI INTERNAZIONALI (I.A.I.), PIC 999694708, established in VIA DEI MONTECATINI 17, ROMA 00186, Italy,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Marco Simoni with ECAS id n00mnk3o signed in the Participant Portal on 18/05/2026 at 16:48:15 (transaction id SigId-4408-mBeMS23QY0SSb1znFk5ARi6rMDL2ZewHwzyzaXhpfGyJm2jMLaHD8hzd3QhmthQfvsEU05nMWaRcbrKMCMaSM4-POMaLlcnzRygWFnj0ibqHK-67QQBBuEQ1EFuSCqScdcGIE4rmKWcOFaX2Hs35zhETzzgGdyqqFhEE2UbPKBkpzPJZ1KBhCf6zvaFDtCHbQtYqg). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.18 16:48:21 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

CEU GMBH (CEU), PIC 901064817, established in QUELLENSTRASSE 51, WIEN 1100, Austria,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Vanda TITZ-MOHACSI with ECAS id nmohacvn signed in the Participant Portal on 14/05/2026 at 11:36:46 (transaction id SigId-18665-mhGfnTG79D78HxNQGAhMWKLCj4HzThjj3pqUOcYxNmWcaQWfivR2tziRrNOH9BT957M8zTQq4IBTxVsiDeBEo-R2zIpfT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-yFc3SrV9WIMaziLecyRQTP8ZH82rX8OH4wU1892EeaiTztzzaLzxHozYIR4feGsujagWCWTi0kUpokBxNDiq6ZG).
Timestamp by third party at
2026.05.14 11:36:49 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERSITAET DUISBURG-ESSEN (UDE), PIC 999843312, established in
UNIVERSITATSSTRASSE 2, ESSEN 45141, Germany,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Kirsten GERCEK with ECAS id ngercekn signed in the Participant Portal on 18/05/2026 at 10:07:02 (transaction id SigId-1089-ZdKGdnQAfKERulBPQ2zQA2aD6jzmRerLYyUjiobTL5K8zZXOzVzPoxNjy5zs16x29JdgvCe8nkqbnN4r2k0h37G-POMaLlcnzRygWFnJ0ibqHK-fG4j0X51MJ5sCZdYqWNZPc17P7CripaApWzk0L76LdCwPoZoAnbO37Ti0neBm0KYtZzcrQBzqRZTSIRiUBnaSim). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.18 10:07:06 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

INSTITUT FUR EUROPAISCHE POLITIK EV (IEP), PIC 951217309, established in
BUNDESALLEE 23, BERLIN 10717, Germany,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Funda TEKIN with ECAS id ntekifun signed in the Participant Portal
on 18/05/2026 at 15:33:25 (transaction id SigId-3842-favKj4yosBi65
h7AT6Gp8A6MHwOtwNijyKiBQxcGpzyQGjXGmL50L5WNA1RqyLEE
fBBWHyfbnKuEoUb2MTP7-POMaLlcnzRygWFnj0ibqHK-mKzoa3m
K1rQpxRSbBFdZApFgCNLwRYLgdsCcHQBzye1IWzJzthaRnrR60mTp
piCPFctOTIOgQCij9IE06jjhwm). Timestamp by third party at
2026.05.18 15:33:29 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

EUROPEAN PARTNERSHIP FOR DEMOCRACY (EPD), PIC 907381457, established in RUE FROISSART 123-133, BRUXELLES 1040, Belgium,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Matthijs Berman with ECAS id n00loqe3 signed in the Participant Portal on 14/05/2026 at 09:11:25 (transaction id SigId-18256-IXvY1Ga2IFy5tOna90Kj3WzbEydwCZbDF2tLpzWysiC2E7eMRqrKbVBixaztkOOfiIPSCdQ6uTUgrPzo9ubmes4-R2zIpT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-jcfh2Xzq855vFslyGnHyLo11DR4aeuQezzcj3TnLugDDKx9Ev8x0pGzLGRLM9iHjr5sczzrSLwXbeB0oVsewLC3G). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.14 09:11:29 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

STOCKHOLMS UNIVERSITET (SU), PIC 999885022, established in UNIVERSITETSVAGEN 10, STOCKHOLM 10691, Sweden,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Leif Järlebark with ECAS id n0088gz9 signed in the Participant Portal on 19/05/2026 at 13:26:39 (transaction id SigId-8063-8BpD8sXY7PWdyzIF1IWzLkVQPmfvQy3XuTYiUuyWZKRcZiZiw4zJp59TqizNQNUd2fcxExekTMfrIF2XOlaOkEW-POMaLlcnzRygWFnJ0ibqHK-NdLSnsQvzLu tDD2eB05hWKzsazpTcBn4WboLuG2YZrdsFxNRzh3M4BD6cQ0JSwhi IIRhkcFFHfm21sfBOJFmrWa). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.19 13:26:44 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

TRANS EUROPEAN POLICY STUDIES ASSOCIATION (TEPSA), PIC 997222081,
established in RUE D EGMONT 11, BRUXELLES 1000, Belgium,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Jim Cloos with ECAS id n008arzs signed in the Participant Portal
on 14/05/2026 at 13:03:43 (transaction id SigId-18887-NIhWo2t1j
wZ8y0H854UInzoMWGOhhPisVYKJXrGzqgnBYUHoDzKhjkRxhIk8w
EOdzKfAzXQsFrgr4JQZ1472IiX-R2zlpfT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-20NimHk
TuZKSkk7Hw2BSj4IPGb49CzgnjneVU5S37oY6oUN2qeIwFqJFQdw
WIS9eYujoHiPb3zzHH0tdhOqXaV0). Timestamp by third party at
2026.05.14 13:03:48 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIVERZITA KOMENSKEHO V BRATISLAVE (CUB), PIC 999841566, established in SAFARIKOVO NAM 6, BRATISLAVA 1 814 99, Slovakia,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Ivona Šelmeciová with ECAS id nhrdivon signed in the Participant Portal on 14/05/2026 at 09:03:42 (transaction id SigId-18238-hAspjXBewGUgN4let2rT5BzbRGXoNjjmI1du1cY1cxqjV04mIsHzzQTF6x73qzcv08BTCTdIHbujxrKexzP7h75-R2zIpfT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-oaQQBZd7fUAOzIyC0gOMFcaZXdbt5KMxUK2LHhFohNRmIgPLeg9l02EeQT6Udh8DBT2movgF6uEFVjho4H7zhr). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.14 09:03:47 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

UNIWERSYTET SWPS (USWPS), PIC 999884634, established in UL. CHODAKOWSKA 19/31, WARSZAWA 03-815, Poland,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Aleksandra CISLAK with ECAS id ncislaal signed in the Participant Portal on 14/05/2026 at 17:55:55 (transaction id SigId-19562-zIPYk aOHY6zkel8bjT0BzO7yruPajtCA4WkRozIZRWgT3TaucEUTzG5iZ2S5k N6oE4jrQw8GowbB1zVwITXpjtU1m-R2zIpft8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-xj5pt tDdxYxDOaoH3BMYqGOjzjqzQ32C0sA1DVOBGzo77jbIhX2bn71rl nihgGneM8mD0LTUNB7eQD08WrKu). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.14 17:55:58 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

ILIA STATE UNIVERSITY (ISU), PIC 999612937, established in K CHOLOKASHVILI AV 3-5, TBILISI 0162, Georgia,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Ketevan DARAKHVELIDZE with ECAS id ndarakke signed in the Participant Portal on 14/05/2026 at 13:49:04 (transaction id SigId-19013-ML3TmzYvq0sOpiYXoOxKIFqqLnqYLaag6jbawEQ2vPIKOcEEzrbzX1XgprSEhGezHzb75QxeZLIyM7LBlsjro7t-R2zIpFT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-PzV7mJJoHzzwVgwdCHe44nySSNIKGBROeuYcp7GHaf2dczZZPcYWzW X0ZszzLFBErrsapGUYVFA1y1YIUuzjkkk). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.14 13:49:07 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

NATIONAL UNIVERSITY OF KYIV-MOHYLA ACADEMY (KMU), PIC 955856431,
established in 2 HRYHORIYA SKOVORODY STR, KYIV 04070, Ukraine,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Serhiy Kvit with ECAS id n009qlh0 signed in the Participant Portal
on 18/05/2026 at 10:29:54 (transaction id SigId-1317-fxDwhHWgCc
nJDfgf3FIuXC9Yhx8FJ5ZJJl8Nm3oAs69bFdZqhmPmgUURzYV3ApzG
AzohFICcF2t1rSGZJeNXXJC-POMaLlcnzRygWFNj0ibqHK-62zqb8rpKI
QMuW6Df3PhGdpcySpV3WIE3WzXQQ5w8NjursaxEFKGcfwU2LDog
RGzouw9P9BjOOxPzVHzzh5w1L10). Timestamp by third party at
2026.05.18 10:29:57 CEST

ANNEX 3

ACCESSION FORM FOR BENEFICIARIES

ASOCIATIA OBSTEASCA INSTITUTUL PENTRU POLITICI SI REFORME EUROPENE (IPRE), PIC 894698610, established in STR. BUCURESTI 90 OF 20, CHISINAU 2001, Moldova,

hereby agrees

to become beneficiary

in Agreement No 101286806 — CitiSense ('the Agreement')

between EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE (EUI) and the European Research Executive Agency (REA) ('EU executive agency' or 'granting authority'), under the powers delegated by the European Commission ('European Commission'),

and mandates

the coordinator to submit and sign in its name and on its behalf any **amendments** to the Agreement, in accordance with Article 39.

By signing this accession form, the beneficiary accepts the grant and agrees to implement it in accordance with the Agreement, with all the obligations and terms and conditions it sets out.

SIGNATURE

For the beneficiary

Iulian GROZA with ECAS id ngroziul signed in the Participant Portal on 14/05/2026 at 08:26:01 (transaction id SigId-18128-18xppd8FaOEDbKeMk2tzk8ZojPHXvmRXrebjDza9FVvjXczPK36FSiiuKbA6MS6Yqbn2wbQ5AxzY95Lm1wFJ0QS-R2zIpFT8xjMVQv7ei6TcSG-vzvrzxNxxa pBMktiE28AqGvnldTZzqeMgwE949iN1QMZNhFeNnbwuDwV9jsVW5V6qaYSEuzi6BNiUEW51OS0BhO). Timestamp by third party at 2026.05.14 08:26:05 CEST

ANNEX 4 XXX LUMP SUM MGA — MULTI & MONO

FINANCIAL STATEMENT FOR THE ACTION FOR REPORTING PERIOD [NUMBER]

	EU contribution											
	Eligible lump sum contributions (per work package)											Requested EU contribution
	WP1 [name]	WP2 [name]	WP3 [name]	WP4 [name]	WP5 [name]	WP6 [name]	WP7 [name]	WP8 [name]	WP9 [name]	WP10 [name]	WP [XX]	
	Forms of funding	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	/ Lump sum contribution// Financing not linked to costs/	
Status of completion	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	COMPLETED	PARTIALLY COMPLETED	PARTIALLY COMPLETED	COMPLETED	NOT COMPLETED	
	a	b	c	d	e	f	g	h	i	j	k	l = a + b+ c + d+ e+ f+ g+ h+ i+ j+ k
1 – [short name beneficiary]												
1.1 – [short name affiliated entity]												
2 – [short name beneficiary]												
2.1 – [short name affiliated entity]												
X – [short name associated partner]												
Total consortium												

The consortium hereby confirms that:

The information provided is complete, reliable and true.

The lump sum contributions declared are eligible (in particular, the work packages have been completed and the work has been properly implemented and/or the results were achieved; see Article 6).

The proper implementation of the action/achievement of the results can be substantiated by adequate records and supporting documentation that will be produced upon request or in the context of checks, reviews, audits and investigations (see Articles 19, 21 and 25).

ANNEX 5

SPECIFIC RULES

CONFIDENTIALITY AND SECURITY (— ARTICLE 13)

Sensitive information with security recommendation

Sensitive information with a security recommendation must comply with the additional requirements imposed by the granting authority.

Before starting the action tasks concerned, the beneficiaries must have obtained all approvals or other mandatory documents needed for implementing the task. The documents must be kept on file and be submitted upon request by the coordinator to the granting authority. If they are not in English, they must be submitted together with an English summary.

For requirements restricting disclosure or dissemination, the information must be handled in accordance with the recommendation and may be disclosed or disseminated only after written approval from the granting authority.

EU classified information

If EU classified information is used or generated by the action, it must be treated in accordance with the security classification guide (SCG) and security aspect letter (SAL) set out in Annex 1 and Decision 2015/444¹ and its implementing rules — until it is declassified.

Deliverables which contain EU classified information must be submitted according to special procedures agreed with the granting authority.

Action tasks involving EU classified information may be subcontracted only with prior explicit written approval from the granting authority and only to entities established in an EU Member State or in a non-EU country with a security of information agreement with the EU (or an administrative arrangement with the Commission).

EU classified information may not be disclosed to any third party (including participants involved in the action implementation) without prior explicit written approval from the granting authority.

ETHICS (— ARTICLE 14)

Ethics and research integrity

The beneficiaries must carry out the action in compliance with:

- ethical principles (including the highest standards of research integrity)

¹ Commission Decision 2015/444/EC, Euratom of 13 March 2015 on the security rules for protecting EU classified information (OJ L 72, 17.3.2015, p. 53).

and

- applicable EU, international and national law, including the EU Charter of Fundamental Rights and the European Convention for the Protection of Human Rights and Fundamental Freedoms and its Supplementary Protocols.

No funding can be granted, within or outside the EU, for activities that are prohibited in all Member States. No funding can be granted in a Member State for an activity which is forbidden in that Member State.

The beneficiaries must pay particular attention to the principle of proportionality, the right to privacy, the right to the protection of personal data, the right to the physical and mental integrity of persons, the right to non-discrimination, the need to ensure protection of the environment and high levels of human health protection.

The beneficiaries must ensure that the activities under the action have an exclusive focus on civil applications.

The beneficiaries must ensure that the activities under the action do not:

- aim at human cloning for reproductive purposes
- intend to modify the genetic heritage of human beings which could make such modifications heritable (with the exception of research relating to cancer treatment of the gonads, which may be financed)
- intend to create human embryos solely for the purpose of research or for the purpose of stem cell procurement, including by means of somatic cell nuclear transfer, or
- lead to the destruction of human embryos (for example, for obtaining stem cells).

Activities involving research on human embryos or human embryonic stem cells may be carried out only if:

- they are set out in Annex 1 or
- the coordinator has obtained explicit approval (in writing) from the granting authority.

In addition, the beneficiaries must respect the fundamental principle of research integrity — as set out in the European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity².

This implies compliance with the following principles:

- reliability in ensuring the quality of research reflected in the design, the methodology, the analysis and the use of resources
- honesty in developing, undertaking, reviewing, reporting and communicating research in a transparent, fair and unbiased way
- respect for colleagues, research participants, society, ecosystems, cultural heritage and the environment

² European Code of Conduct for Research Integrity of ALLEA (All European Academies).

- accountability for the research from idea to publication, for its management and organisation, for training, supervision and mentoring, and for its wider impacts

and means that beneficiaries must ensure that persons carrying out research tasks follow the good research practices including ensuring, where possible, openness, reproducibility and traceability and refrain from the research integrity violations described in the Code.

Activities raising ethical issues must comply with the additional requirements formulated by the ethics panels (including after checks, reviews or audits; see Article 25).

Before starting an action task raising ethical issues, the beneficiaries must have obtained all approvals or other mandatory documents needed for implementing the task, notably from any (national or local) ethics committee or other bodies such as data protection authorities.

The documents must be kept on file and be submitted upon request by the coordinator to the granting authority. If they are not in English, they must be submitted together with an English summary, which shows that the documents cover the action tasks in question and includes the conclusions of the committee or authority concerned (if any).

VALUES (— ARTICLE 14)

Gender mainstreaming

The beneficiaries must take all measures to promote equal opportunities between men and women in the implementation of the action and, where applicable, in line with the gender equality plan. They must aim, to the extent possible, for a gender balance at all levels of personnel assigned to the action, including at supervisory and managerial level.

INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY RIGHTS (IPR) — BACKGROUND AND RESULTS — ACCESS RIGHTS AND RIGHTS OF USE (— ARTICLE 16)

Definitions

Access rights — Rights to use results or background.

Dissemination — The public disclosure of the results by appropriate means, other than resulting from protecting or exploiting the results, including by scientific publications in any medium.

Exploit(ation) — The use of results in further research and innovation activities other than those covered by the action concerned, including among other things, commercial exploitation such as developing, creating, manufacturing and marketing a product or process, creating and providing a service, or in standardisation activities.

Fair and reasonable conditions — Appropriate conditions, including possible financial terms or royalty-free conditions, taking into account the specific circumstances of the request for access, for example the actual or potential value of the results or background to which access is requested and/or the scope, duration or other characteristics of the exploitation envisaged.

FAIR principles — ‘findability’, ‘accessibility’, ‘interoperability’ and ‘reusability’.

Open access — Online access to research outputs provided free of charge to the end-user.

Open science — An approach to the scientific process based on open cooperative work, tools and diffusing knowledge.

Research data management — The process within the research lifecycle that includes the organisation, storage, preservation, security, quality assurance, allocation of persistent identifiers (PIDs) and rules and procedures for sharing of data including licensing.

Research outputs — Results to which access can be given in the form of scientific publications, data or other engineered results and processes such as software, algorithms, protocols, models, workflows and electronic notebooks.

Scope of the obligations

For this section, references to ‘beneficiary’ or ‘beneficiaries’ do not include affiliated entities (if any).

Agreement on background — Background free from restrictions

The beneficiaries must identify in a written agreement the background as needed for implementing the action or for exploiting its results.

Where the call conditions restrict control due to strategic interests reasons, background that is subject to control or other restrictions by a country (or entity from a country) which is not one of the eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions and that impact the exploitation of the results (i.e. would make the exploitation of the results subject to control or restrictions) must not be used and must be explicitly excluded in the agreement on background — unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority.

Results free from restrictions

Where the call conditions restrict control due to strategic interests reasons, the beneficiaries must ensure that the results of the action are not subject to control or other restrictions by a country (or entity from a country) which is not one of the eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions — unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority.

Ownership of results

Results are owned by the beneficiaries that generate them.

However, two or more beneficiaries own results jointly if:

- they have jointly generated them and
- it is not possible to:
 - establish the respective contribution of each beneficiary, or
 - separate them for the purpose of applying for, obtaining or maintaining their protection.

The joint owners must agree — in writing — on the allocation and terms of exercise of their joint ownership (‘joint ownership agreement’), to ensure compliance with their obligations under this Agreement.

Unless otherwise agreed in the joint ownership agreement or consortium agreement, each joint owner may grant non-exclusive licences to third parties to exploit the jointly-owned results (without any right to sub-license), if the other joint owners are given:

- at least 45 days advance notice and
- fair and reasonable compensation.

The joint owners may agree — in writing — to apply another regime than joint ownership.

If third parties (including employees and other personnel) may claim rights to the results, the beneficiary concerned must ensure that those rights can be exercised in a manner compatible with its obligations under the Agreement.

The beneficiaries must indicate the owner(s) of the results (results ownership list) in the final periodic report.

Protection of results

Beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must adequately protect their results — for an appropriate period and with appropriate territorial coverage — if protection is possible and justified, taking into account all relevant considerations, including the prospects for commercial exploitation, the legitimate interests of the other beneficiaries and any other legitimate interests.

Exploitation of results

Beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — use their best efforts to exploit their results directly or to have them exploited indirectly by another entity, in particular through transfer or licensing.

If, despite a beneficiary's best efforts, the results are not exploited within one year after the end of the action, the beneficiaries must (unless otherwise agreed in writing with the granting authority) use the Horizon Results Platform to find interested parties to exploit the results.

If results are incorporated in a standard, the beneficiaries must (unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority or unless it is impossible) ask the standardisation body to include the funding statement (see Article 17) in (information related to) the standard.

Additional exploitation obligations

Where the call conditions impose additional exploitation obligations (including obligations linked to the restriction of participation or control due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security reasons), the beneficiaries must comply with them — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Where the call conditions impose additional exploitation obligations in case of a public emergency, the beneficiaries must (if requested by the granting authority) grant for a limited period of time specified in the request, non-exclusive licences — under fair and reasonable conditions — to their results to legal entities that need the results to address the public emergency and commit to rapidly and broadly exploit the resulting products and services at fair and reasonable conditions. This provision applies up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Additional information obligation relating to standards

Where the call conditions impose additional information obligations relating to possible standardisation, the beneficiaries must — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — inform the granting authority, if the results could reasonably be expected to contribute to European or international standards.

Transfer and licensing of results

Transfer of ownership

The beneficiaries may transfer ownership of their results, provided this does not affect compliance with their obligations under the Agreement.

The beneficiaries must ensure that their obligations under the Agreement regarding their results are passed on to the new owner and that this new owner has the obligation to pass them on in any subsequent transfer.

Moreover, they must inform the other beneficiaries with access rights of the transfer at least 45 days in advance (or less if agreed in writing), unless agreed otherwise in writing for specifically identified third parties including affiliated entities or unless impossible under the applicable law. This notification must include sufficient information on the new owner to enable the beneficiaries concerned to assess the effects on their access rights. The beneficiaries may object within 30 days of receiving notification (or less if agreed in writing), if they can show that the transfer would adversely affect their access rights. In this case, the transfer may not take place until agreement has been reached between the beneficiaries concerned.

Granting licences

The beneficiaries may grant licences to their results (or otherwise give the right to exploit them), including on an exclusive basis, provided this does not affect compliance with their obligations.

Exclusive licences for results may be granted only if all the other beneficiaries concerned have waived their access rights.

Granting authority right to object to transfers or licensing — Horizon Europe actions

Where the call conditions in Horizon Europe actions provide for the right to object to transfers or licensing, the granting authority may — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — object to a transfer of ownership or the exclusive licensing of results, if:

- the beneficiaries which generated the results have received funding under the grant
- it is to a legal entity established in a non-EU country not associated with Horizon Europe, and
- the granting authority considers that the transfer or licence is not in line with EU interests.

Beneficiaries that intend to transfer ownership or grant an exclusive licence must formally notify the granting authority before the intended transfer or licensing takes place and:

- identify the specific results concerned
- describe in detail the new owner or licensee and the planned or potential exploitation of the results, and
- include a reasoned assessment of the likely impact of the transfer or licence on EU interests, in particular regarding competitiveness as well as consistency with ethical principles and security considerations.

The granting authority may request additional information.

If the granting authority decides to object to a transfer or exclusive licence, it must formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information it has requested).

No transfer or licensing may take place in the following cases:

- pending the granting authority decision, within the period set out above
- if the granting authority objects
- until the conditions are complied with, if the granting authority objection comes with conditions.

A beneficiary may formally notify a request to waive the right to object regarding intended transfers or grants to a specifically identified third party, if measures safeguarding EU interests are in place. If the granting authority agrees, it will formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information requested).

Granting authority right to object to transfers or licensing — Euratom actions

Where the call conditions in Euratom actions provide for the right to object to transfers or licensing, the granting authority may — up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1) — object to a transfer of ownership or the exclusive or non-exclusive licensing of results, if:

- the beneficiaries which generated the results have received funding under the grant
- it is to a legal entity established in a non-EU country not associated to the Euratom Research and Training Programme 2021-2025 and
- the granting authority considers that the transfer or licence is not in line with the EU interests.

Beneficiaries that intend to transfer ownership or grant a licence must formally notify the granting authority before the intended transfer or licensing takes place and:

- identify the specific results concerned
- describe in detail the results, the new owner or licensee and the planned or potential exploitation of the results, and
- include a reasoned assessment of the likely impact of the transfer or licence on EU interests, in particular regarding competitiveness as well as consistency with ethical principles and security considerations (including the defence interests of the EU Member States under Article 24 of the Euratom Treaty).

The granting authority may request additional information.

If the granting authority decides to object to a transfer or licence, it will formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information requested).

No transfer or licensing may take place in the following cases:

- pending the granting authority decision, within the period set out above
- if the granting authority objects
- until the conditions are complied with, if the granting authority objection comes with conditions.

A beneficiary may formally notify a request to waive the right to object regarding intended transfers or grants to a specifically identified third party, if measures safeguarding EU interests are in place. If the granting authority agrees, it will formally notify the beneficiary concerned within 60 days of receiving notification (or any additional information requested).

Limitations to transfers and licensing due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security reasons of the EU and its Member States

Where the call conditions restrict participation or control due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security reasons, the beneficiaries may not transfer ownership of their results or grant licences to third parties which are established in countries which are not eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions (or, if applicable, are controlled by such countries or entities from such countries) — unless they have requested and received prior approval by the granting authority.

The request must:

- identify the specific results concerned
- describe in detail the new owner or licensee and the planned or potential exploitation of the results, and
- include a reasoned assessment of the likely impact of the transfer or license on the strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security of the EU and its Member States.

The granting authority may request additional information.

Access rights to results and background

Exercise of access rights — Waiving of access rights — No sub-licensing

Requests to exercise access rights and the waiver of access rights must be in writing.

Unless agreed otherwise in writing with the beneficiary granting access, access rights do not include the right to sub-license.

If a beneficiary is no longer involved in the action, this does not affect its obligations to grant access.

If a beneficiary defaults on its obligations, the beneficiaries may agree that that beneficiary no longer has access rights.

Access rights for implementing the action

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — on a royalty-free basis — to background needed to implement their own tasks under the action, unless the beneficiary that holds the background has — before acceding to the Agreement —:

- informed the other beneficiaries that access to its background is subject to restrictions, or
- agreed with the other beneficiaries that access would not be on a royalty-free basis.

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — on a royalty-free basis — to results needed for implementing their own tasks under the action.

Access rights for exploiting the results

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — under fair and reasonable conditions — to results needed for exploiting their results.

The beneficiaries must grant each other access — under fair and reasonable conditions — to background needed for exploiting their results, unless the beneficiary that holds the background has — before acceding to the Agreement — informed the other beneficiaries that access to its background is subject to restrictions.

Requests for access must be made — unless agreed otherwise in writing — up to one year after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Access rights for entities under the same control

Unless agreed otherwise in writing by the beneficiaries, access to results and, subject to the restrictions referred to above (if any), background must also be granted — under fair and reasonable conditions — to entities that:

- are established in an EU Member State or Horizon Europe associated country
- are under the direct or indirect control of another beneficiary, or under the same direct or indirect control as that beneficiary, or directly or indirectly controlling that beneficiary and
- need the access to exploit the results of that beneficiary.

Unless agreed otherwise in writing, such requests for access must be made by the entity directly to the beneficiary concerned.

Requests for access must be made — unless agreed otherwise in writing — up to one year after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Access rights for the granting authority, EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies and national authorities to results for policy purposes — Horizon Europe actions

In Horizon Europe actions, the beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must grant access to their results — on a royalty-free basis — to the granting authority, EU institutions, bodies, offices or agencies for developing, implementing and monitoring EU policies or programmes. Such access rights do not extend to beneficiaries' background.

Such access rights are limited to non-commercial and non-competitive use.

For actions under the cluster ‘Civil Security for Society’, such access rights also extend to national authorities of EU Member States for developing, implementing and monitoring their policies or programmes in this area. In this case, access is subject to a bilateral agreement to define specific conditions ensuring that:

- the access rights will be used only for the intended purpose and
- appropriate confidentiality obligations are in place.

Moreover, the requesting national authority or EU institution, body, office or agency (including the granting authority) must inform all other national authorities of such a request.

Access rights for the granting authority, Euratom institutions, funding bodies or the Joint Undertaking Fusion for Energy — Euratom actions

In Euratom actions, the beneficiaries which have received funding under the grant must grant access to their results — on a royalty-free basis — to the granting authority, Euratom institutions, funding bodies or the Joint Undertaking Fusion for Energy for developing, implementing and monitoring Euratom policies and programmes or for compliance with obligations assumed through international cooperation with non-EU countries and international organisations.

Such access rights include the right to authorise third parties to use the results in public procurement and the right to sub-license and are limited to non-commercial and non-competitive use.

Additional access rights

Where the call conditions impose additional access rights, the beneficiaries must comply with them.

COMMUNICATION, DISSEMINATION, OPEN SCIENCE AND VISIBILITY (— ARTICLE 17)

Dissemination

Dissemination of results

The beneficiaries must disseminate their results as soon as feasible, in a publicly available format, subject to any restrictions due to the protection of intellectual property, security rules or legitimate interests.

A beneficiary that intends to disseminate its results must give at least 15 days advance notice to the other beneficiaries (unless agreed otherwise), together with sufficient information on the results it will disseminate.

Any other beneficiary may object within (unless agreed otherwise) 15 days of receiving notification, if it can show that its legitimate interests in relation to the results or background would be significantly harmed. In such cases, the results may not be disseminated unless appropriate steps are taken to safeguard those interests.

Additional dissemination obligations

Where the call conditions impose additional dissemination obligations, the beneficiaries must also comply with those.

Open Science

Open science: open access to scientific publications

The beneficiaries must ensure open access to peer-reviewed scientific publications relating to their results. In particular, they must ensure that:

- at the latest at the time of publication, a machine-readable electronic copy of the published version or the final peer-reviewed manuscript accepted for publication, is deposited in a trusted repository for scientific publications
- immediate open access is provided to the deposited publication via the repository, under the latest available version of the Creative Commons Attribution International Public Licence (CC BY) or a licence with equivalent rights; for monographs and other long-text formats, the licence may exclude commercial uses and derivative works (e.g. CC BY-NC, CC BY-ND) and
- information is given via the repository about any research output or any other tools and instruments needed to validate the conclusions of the scientific publication.

Beneficiaries (or authors) must retain sufficient intellectual property rights to comply with the open access requirements.

Metadata of deposited publications must be open under a Creative Commons Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or equivalent, in line with the FAIR principles (in particular machine-actionable) and provide information at least about the following: publication (author(s), title, date of publication, publication venue); Horizon Europe or Euratom funding; grant project name, acronym and number; licensing terms; persistent identifiers for the publication, the authors involved in the action and, if possible, for their organisations and the grant. Where applicable, the metadata must include persistent identifiers for any research output or any other tools and instruments needed to validate the conclusions of the publication.

Only publication fees in full open access venues for scientific publications are eligible for reimbursement.

Open science: research data management

The beneficiaries must manage the digital research data generated in the action ('data') responsibly, in line with the FAIR principles and by taking all of the following actions:

- establish a data management plan ('DMP') (and regularly update it)
- as soon as possible and within the deadlines set out in the DMP, deposit the data in a trusted repository; if required in the call conditions, this repository must be federated in the EOSC in compliance with EOSC requirements
- as soon as possible and within the deadlines set out in the DMP, ensure open access — via the repository — to the deposited data, under the latest available version of the Creative Commons Attribution International Public License (CC BY) or Creative Commons Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or a licence/dedication with equivalent rights, following the principle 'as open as possible as closed as necessary', unless providing open access would in particular:
 - be against the beneficiary's legitimate interests, including regarding commercial exploitation, or

- be contrary to any other constraints, in particular the EU competitive interests or the beneficiary's obligations under this Agreement; if open access is not provided (to some or all data), this must be justified in the DMP
- provide information via the repository about any research output or any other tools and instruments needed to re-use or validate the data.

Metadata of deposited data must be open under a Creative Common Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or equivalent (to the extent legitimate interests or constraints are safeguarded), in line with the FAIR principles (in particular machine-actionable) and provide information at least about the following: datasets (description, date of deposit, author(s) and embargo); Horizon Europe or Euratom funding; grant project name, acronym and number; licensing terms; persistent identifiers for the dataset, the authors involved in the action, and, if possible, for their organisations and the grant. Where applicable, the metadata must include persistent identifiers for related publications and other research outputs.

Open science: additional practices

Where the call conditions impose additional obligations regarding open science practices, the beneficiaries must also comply with those.

Where the call conditions impose additional obligations regarding the validation of scientific publications, the beneficiaries must provide (digital or physical) access to data or other results needed for validation of the conclusions of scientific publications, to the extent that their legitimate interests or constraints are safeguarded (and unless they already provided (open) access at publication).

Where the call conditions impose additional open science obligations in case of a public emergency, the beneficiaries must (if requested by the granting authority) immediately deposit any research output in a trusted repository and provide open access to it under a CC BY licence, a Public Domain Dedication (CC 0) or equivalent. As an exception, if the access would be against the beneficiaries' legitimate interests, the beneficiaries must grant non-exclusive licenses — under fair and reasonable conditions — to legal entities that need the research output to address the public emergency and commit to rapidly and broadly exploit the resulting products and services at fair and reasonable conditions. This provision applies up to four years after the end of the action (see Data Sheet, Point 1).

Plan for the exploitation and dissemination of results including communication activities

Unless excluded by the call conditions, the beneficiaries must provide and regularly update a plan for the exploitation and dissemination of results including communication activities.

SPECIFIC RULES FOR CARRYING OUT THE ACTION (— ARTICLE 18)

Implementation in case of restrictions due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security of the EU and its Member States

Where the call conditions restrict participation or control due to strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security, the beneficiaries must ensure that none of the entities that participate as affiliated entities, associated partners, third parties giving in-kind contributions, subcontractors or recipients of financial support to third parties are established in countries which are not eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions (or, if applicable, are controlled by such countries or entities from such countries) — unless otherwise agreed with the granting authority.

The beneficiaries must moreover ensure that any cooperation with entities established in countries which are not eligible countries or target countries set out in the call conditions (or, if applicable, are controlled by such countries or entities from such countries) does not affect the strategic assets, interests, autonomy or security of the EU and its Member States.

Recruitment and working conditions for researchers

The beneficiaries must take all measures to implement the principles set out in Annex II to the Council Recommendation on a European framework to attract and retain research, innovation and entrepreneurial talents in Europe³ ('the European Charter for Researchers'), in particular regarding:

- working conditions
- transparent recruitment processes based on merit, and
- career development.

The beneficiaries must ensure that researchers and all participants involved in the action are aware of them.

Specific rules for access to research infrastructure activities

Definitions

Research Infrastructures — Facilities that provide resources and services for the research communities to conduct research and foster innovation in their fields. This definition includes the associated human resources, and it covers major equipment or sets of instruments; knowledge-related facilities such as collections, archives or scientific data infrastructures; computing systems, communication networks, and any other infrastructure, of a unique nature and open to external users, essential to achieve excellence in research and innovation. Where relevant, they may be used beyond research, for example for education or public services, and they may be 'single-sited', 'virtual' or 'distributed'⁴:

When implementing access to research infrastructure activities, the beneficiaries must respect the following conditions:

- for transnational access:
 - access which must be provided:

The access must be free of charge, transnational access to research infrastructure or installations for selected user-groups.

The access must include the logistical, technological and scientific support and the specific training that is usually provided to external researchers using the

³ Council Recommendation C/2023/1640 of 18 December 2023 on a European framework to attract and retain research, innovation and entrepreneurial talents in Europe, Annex II (OJ C, C/2023/1640, 29.12.2023).

⁴ See Article 2(1) of the Horizon Europe Framework Programme Regulation 2021/695.

infrastructure. Transnational access can be either in person (hands-on), provided to selected users that visit the installation to make use of it, or remote, through the provision to selected user-groups of remote scientific services (e.g. provision of reference materials or samples, remote access to a high-performance computing facility).

- categories of users that may have access:

Transnational access must be provided to selected user-groups, i.e. teams of one or more researchers (users).

The majority of the users must work in a country other than the country(ies) where the installation is located (unless access is provided by an international organisation, the Joint Research Centre (JRC), an ERIC or similar legal entity).

Only user groups that are allowed to disseminate the results they have generated under the action may benefit from the access (unless the users are working for SMEs).

Access for user groups with a majority of users not working in a EU Member State or Horizon Europe associated country is limited to 20% of the total amount of units of access provided under the grant (unless a higher percentage is foreseen in Annex 1).

- procedure and criteria for selecting user groups:

The user groups must request access by submitting (in writing) a description of the work that they wish to carry out and the names, nationalities and home institutions of the users.

The user groups must be selected by (one or more) selection panels set up by the consortium.

The selection panels must be composed of international experts in the field, at least half of them independent from the consortium (unless otherwise specified in Annex 1).

The selection panels must assess all proposals received and recommend a short-list of the user groups that should benefit from access.

The selection panels must base their selection on scientific merit, taking into account that priority should be given to user groups composed of users who:

- have not previously used the installation and
- are working in countries where no equivalent research infrastructure exist.

It will apply the principles of transparency, fairness and impartiality.

Where the call conditions impose additional rules for the selection of user groups, the beneficiaries must also comply with those.

- other conditions:

The beneficiaries must request written approval from the granting authority for the selection of user groups requiring visits to the installations exceeding 3 months (unless such visits are foreseen in Annex 1).

In addition, the beneficiaries must:

- advertise widely, including on a their websites, the access offered under the Agreement
 - promote equal opportunities in advertising the access and take into account the gender dimension when defining the support provided to users
 - ensure that users comply with the terms and conditions of the Agreement
 - ensure that its obligations under Articles 12, 13, 17 and 33 also apply to the users
 - keep records of the names, nationalities, and home institutions of users, as well as the nature and quantity of access provided to them
- for virtual access:
- access which must be provided:

The access must be free of charge, virtual access to research infrastructure or installations.

‘Virtual access’ means open and free access through communication networks to digital resources and services needed for research, without selecting the users to whom access is provided.

The access must include the support that is usually provided to external users.

Where allowed by the call conditions, beneficiaries may in justified cases define objective eligibility criteria (e.g. affiliation to a research or academic institution) for specific users.

- other conditions:

The beneficiaries must have the virtual access services assessed periodically by a board composed of international experts in the field, at least half of whom must be independent from the consortium (unless otherwise specified in Annex 1). For this purpose, information and statistics on the users and the nature and quantity of the access provided, must be made available to the board.

The beneficiaries must advertise widely, including on a dedicated website, the access offered under the grant and the eligibility criteria, if any.

Where the call conditions impose additional traceability⁵ obligations, information on the traceability of the users and the nature and quantity of access must be provided by the beneficiaries.

These obligations apply regardless of the form of funding or budget categories used to declare the costs (unit costs or actual costs or a combination of the two).

⁵ According to the definition given in ISO 9000, i.e.: “Traceability is the ability to trace the history, application, use and location of an item or its characteristics through recorded identification data.” The users can be traced, for example, by authentication and/or by authorization or by other means that allows for analysis of the type of users and the nature and quantity of access provided.



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